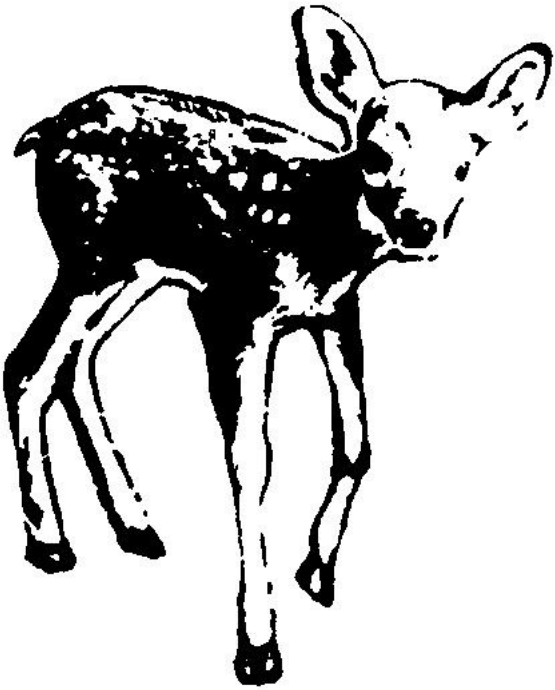
I WORK AT AN AMUSEMENT PARK

Only half of the monsters here are paid actors.



by
the_girl_in_the_crypt

I should start off by explaining a couple things. Our park doesn't focus on one specific theme. We have four sections that are fenced off from one another. There's a spooky one, a western one, an old-timey hollywood one and one that looks like everything there is made of candy. We get a lot of visitors, mostly families and young couples. Every single one of us actors, the actual actors, is assigned to a specific one of the other things. The ones that aren't actors but pretend to be.

Now, you might be wondering why a park would keep around non-human creatures that pose a potential threat to its visitors and of course, you'd have to ask management for an exact answer. My best guess however is that they are in fact good employees: they don't need to be payed, look extremely real and offer a way more authentic experience. Of course, the experience cannot be too authentic, if you catch my drift. That's what we, the actual actors, are here for.

Every section has two actors and two of the other ones. We don't have a specific name for them, but we refer to them as pretenders, not-actors or monsters most of the time. Our main objective is to keep the one we're assigned to under control. Make it seem like they're actors too, not strange beings we don't even know the origin of.

Take my monster as an example. I work at the horror-themed section, that means my territory are the two funhouses, the larger of which is hospital-themed, the indoor rollercoaster and that other really cool outdoor one that winds around a gigantic skull. The rollercoaster goes in through its mouth, comes out of one eyehole and goes back in through the other. It's some genius design, really.

I spend my day walking around in my costume, either chasing the visitors with my whip, which for clarification is part of my role, or leading it around by its chain that is attached to the iron collar around its neck. God help us if that thing ever comes off.

The one I have been assigned to is tall, broad and has black, surprisingly fluffy fur, a round, flat face and two big ram horns on top of its head. Its eyes are two large, red buttons and its mouth holds a set of long,

shiny, sharp fangs. Its tongue usually hangs out of its maw, black drool dripping down from it constantly. It's official name is Mr Scratch on accord of its oversized claws, but I call it the sock puppet.
Mr Scratch is quite obviously a costume. He moves sluggishly and there are even seams and stitchings to be seen in some places. The costume itself however is a living, breathing thing. You wouldn't know if you'd just see it walk around by my side. I however found out pretty soon, on my first day actually.

When they told me they had given me the acting job because of my physical strength and that they needed me to take care of a monster of sorts, I was dumbfounded. Then again, my job interview had included questions like "Would you describe yourself as relatively fearless?" and "If you were to get attacked by a wild animal, would you a. fend it off, b. run for your life and call for help or c. hide?" so... the warning signs were there.

But of course, my first reaction was disbelieve, which by the way was replaced with stern, cold realization in record time on the day I started working my "acting" job.

My manager Dale, a grumpy, douchy guy in his late twenties, had me dress up in the costume I have been wearing nearly every day for three years now. It's hard to describe, kind of like a goth monster hunter outfit which comes with a whip, but it looks really fancy and is agreeably comfortable.

He had then led me to a large cage in the horror-themed section. It was standing next to the bigger funhouse. Its door was held shut by a chain with an oversized lock on it. The sign above it read "Mr Scratch" in big, twisted red letters.

Dale unloaded the large plastic bag he had been carrying from his shoulder and threw it onto the ground in front of me. "You'll find a lamb shank and the metal leash in there," he said curtly, nodding at the bag.

“A lamb shank?” I inquired.

Dale gave me a sleazy, yellow-teethed grin. “We’ve found out it likes lamb,” he replied, as if that explained anything at all. He took out a small key from his pocket and walked over to the cage. “I’ll let it out for you, but just this once so you can tame it. Once you’ve gotten that over with, I’ll give you the key. Won’t be wasting any more of my time doing your job then.”

Part of me still thought he was messing with me, but I was beginning to have my doubts. He proceeded towards the cage and turned his key inside the lock. The door sprang open with a creaking noise and Dale stepped aside.

At first, nothing happened. Then, from the part of the cage that had not yet been reached by the sparse early morning sunlight, the thing they called Mr Scratch emerged. It exited the cage at a slow, menacing pace on all fours, but once it was outside, it rose to its hind legs and raised its head, slowly opening its mouth only for its long, gooey tongue to drop out.

I stared at the moving costume, then at Dale. I was very close to losing my composure. “Are you kidding?” I asked. “Tell that idiot in the costume to cut the crap. If you guys think you can mess with the new one...”

But the look on Dale’s face was serious. He almost seemed a bit frightened. “Feed it,” he hissed. “Feed it and then put on the leash.”

I shook my head and rolled my eyes, but decided to play along. I bent down and picked up the plastic bag, produced the large lamb shank from inside and waved it at the moving costume. “Come and get it,” I sang, feeling immensely stupid for talking to a person like I would to a dog.

The thing came bounding towards me at a surprising speed and ripped the shank out of my hand. When its teeth sank naturally into the meat

and I watched the creature tear it to shreds and gobble it down, I realized that I was not looking at a person in a costume. Gripped by a sudden boldness, I slowly took a few steps towards it, reached out and let my palm travel over its shiny black fur.

It was warm.

I could feel its chest rise and fall and the muscles underneath its skin pulsing, moving. I was staring at the thing with wide eyes, not believing what I was seeing.

Finally, I sprang back into action and picked up the leash from the bag. I attached it to the metal choker and, after making sure I had a good grip on it, gave it an experimental pull. The beast's head jerked towards me and I stumbled backwards in shock, but quickly managed to regain my footing. Luckily, the thing still seemed to be more interested in its meal than in me. Dale came strolling over and gave me a pat on the shoulder, which for the record is the only friendly gesture I've ever gotten from him. He handed me the key for Mr Scratch's cage and told me to make sure not to lose it.

I later asked him jokingly if the creature had ever attacked any of its other caretakers, to which he let out a loud laugh before answering in a suddenly quite serious tone, "No. With one exception."

"Being...?" I offered.

Dale laughed once again before adding, "Just the guy before you. He was good at his job, but we had to let him go. You can't be the Monster Tamer if both your legs are missing." Upon seeing my startled expression, he smirked and told me not to let it get to me, he was sure Mr Scratch liked me better.

He's most certainly not reading this, so I feel safe here when I say that Dale's an asshole.

In regards to the monster, I've already mentioned that I've taken to

calling him the sock puppet. After reading my description of him, I bet you can see where I'm coming from. The sock puppet and I are on pretty good terms by the way. He's never really caused me any problems. I usually walk him around the park and sometimes let him dash forward to "jumpscare" a visitor, only to then pull him back and hiss at the visitor not to get too close to him. That's our favorite trick.

He's run off on me twice before, but those are stories for another day. All in all, Mr Scratch and get along pretty well.

Too bad you can't say that about some of the other actors and their pretenders.

When talking about my co-workers, I guess it only makes sense to start with the one who works in the same part of the park as me. That would be Darius. He's very nice, but easily stressed. He talks a lot about wanting another job, but either that's just an empty phrase of his or he hasn't found one, because he's still around after three years of me working here.

I met him on my second day on the job. Of course Dale had failed to introduce me to any of my colleagues, he had simply given me a short overview about who I was yet to meet and what I was to expect. He hadn't put very much effort into his explanation.

I was on my to Mr Scratch's cage in the early morning about half an hour before the park's opening time that day. I was already dressed up and ready to release the sock puppet, carrying with me the metal leash and a bag of dog treats, both of which I dropped when I collided with the man in the doctor's outfit who had seemingly come out of nowhere. By his fake blood-smeared lab coat and the surgical face mask dangling around his neck, I determined him to be another actor.

"Hey! I'm Darius. You must be the new tamer," he stammered, and without giving me time to answer, added, "I really need your help right now."
"Okay," I responded, taken aback. "What's going on?"

“Did Dale already tell you about... them?” he asked and I nodded. He seemed relieved.

“Oh, thank god. Okay, so, I have to watch out for one myself. She’s like, a zombie nurse, hard to describe, but you’ll know when you see her! Either way, we can’t really put her on a leash like Scratch so we let her roam around this part of the park freely... under my supervision of course. But I kind of lost track of her and now I don’t know where she is! We can’t have her stroll around the kid-friendly sections or the visitors will freak out! You’ve got to help me, please, we don’t have much time!”

I abandoned the leash and dog treats and the two of us got on our way. Darius told me he had already looked for her in our section, so she had to be in one of the others. Our first guess was the hollywood one since it was pretty much right next to ours.

While we did not find her there, Darius made use of our time by informing me about the workings of the park in a bit more detail. All the not-actors are put into cages overnight to keep them from wandering off. Half an hour before opening time, they’re being let out. He also told me a few bits about some of the other monsters, but said it would be best for me to find out myself. We didn’t pass any on our way through the hollywood section, but we did find the nurse.
She was standing next to a food booth, the owner of which thankfully had not arrived yet. She had her back turned to us and was swaying slightly. Her thigh-length nurse costume was smeared with red stains, not unlike that of Darius, but something told me that no fake blood had been used on hers.

“Thank god, there she is,” Darius muttered. “Dale would’ve killed me.”

“What now?” I asked.

“I’ll just walk her back to our section. It’s as easy as that,” he replied. “She’s basically braindead.”

I watched as he approached her, grabbed her by the shoulders and

turned her around. I nearly gagged upon seeing her face. Half of the lower portion of her jaw was missing, the other half was dangling loosely off her head. Blood was steadily dripping from her tongue, reminding me of that of Mr Scratch. She was completely unresponsive, her eyes staring past me and Darius into the distance. If she knew we were there, she wasn't letting it on.

I followed Darius, who was leading the nurse by her shoulders, back to the entrance of the horror-themed section. There were still ten minutes left before the park would let in visitors. Upon realizing this, I hurried to release the sock puppet from its cage and put it on its leash. And that was that, basically.

The sight of the undead nurse may have grossed me out for a little while, but I learned pretty soon that she wasn't the kind that I needed to fear. There are some much, much worse things in this park than her.

the Laughing Cowboy and the Sugar Plum Fairy

Those who have read my first post will know that half of the actors at the amusement park I work at aren't really... actors. We call them pretenders, not-actors or monsters, plain and simple.

Also, just saying, I had some trouble thinking of a shorter and less misleading title this time. I get it, I had it coming, but the joke about the unpaid actors got old really fast.

It appears I have to preface this one by answering some frequently asked questions regarding Mr Scratch.

Yes, I do give him scritches and belly rubs and all that stuff from time to time. I often find myself treating him like my pet, even though I really shouldn't be doing that. Due to his size and strength, I have not yet attempted to play or wrestle with him, nor do I wish to try anytime soon.

About his anatomy, I guess I could have made myself more clear. Imagine a huge, detailed costume as it would be worn by an actor in a theme park. Now imagine the costume as an animal. The outer layer is made of fabric and the fur is artificial, but there's a whole bunch of functioning organs, blood and muscle tissue inside. It's a costume and it is a living, breathing thing. And it does defecate. For some reason, a lot of you wanted to know that. They clean out the his cage once a day when I'm out walking him about.

I also mentioned him running off before. He only did it twice and to be honest, it wasn't that big of a deal. The first time it was actually my fault. My hands had grown sweaty from having held the leash for so long and he was in a bit of a funky mood that day, so when he gave the chain one hard, strong pull, I lost my grip on it and it flew out of my hand. He didn't get very far either. I'm a fast runner and he only managed to make it to one of the ice cream parlors before I caught up to him.

I got my hands back on the leash just as Dale, my manager, came running up to me. Upon noticing I had gotten the sock puppet back under control, he let out a sigh and muttered "Close shave, idiot" under his breath as he passed me.

I don't want to talk about the second time he ran off. It was nasty and the only way I sleep soundly at night is knowing that it wasn't my fault.

All in all, the sock puppet barely acts up. Unlike some of the others. You would think that the worst not-actors are from our part of the park, the horror-section. But while the Undead Nurse and Mr Scratch might be the more creepy-looking ones, the pretenders one should actually be afraid of are not under my or Darius's care. And this is what leads us to the neighboring section.

The amusement park I work at might not be the biggest, but it is not modest by any means. This is proven by the most flashy and beautiful section: The Wild West one, or as we call it Twin Vale Point.

This name is painted in large, black letters onto the wooden sign welcoming visitors into the western style town. You'll find the most gorgeous, old-fashioned wood rollercoaster in there. It's my personal favorite and I'm guilty of sneaking rides on it during my breaktimes when there aren't as many visitors around.

Other than that, I make it a point not to get too close to Twin Vale Point at any time. The setup is quite beautiful and a refreshing contrast to the grimdark black and gray colors that I'm usually surrounded by when working in my own ghost town, but the western section also happens to be home to one of the pretenders that really freak me out.

The Laughing Cowboy.

Technically, I should not be able to encounter him as often as I do. Twin Vale Point is a bit further away from the horror section, but somehow, and don't ask me why, our paths keep crossing anyway.

The first time I met him was when I was already one month into the job. By then I had gotten used to the way things work around here and had come to enjoy my daily walks with Mr Scratch, but I had also learned that it is important to give him a bit of a break from time to time.

It was a particularly busy day and the park was bustling with visitors. I had been walking the sock puppet around for about three hours straight and had noticed him getting a bit tired, so I brought him back to his cage. It had been newly cleaned and padded out with some fresh hay. He seemed very relieved and happily marched inside once I let him off his leash. I locked the door behind him before making my way back to the main plaza where I would often walk about.

Now, you need to know that during seasons in which we expect a lot of visitors, us actors carry around walkie-talkies in case something happens and we need to inform the others. They aren't management-issued, Dale could not give less of a damn about if we have a hard time or not. Someday, an actor just came up with the idea and bought a bunch of them.

So, it was one of those busy seasons and I had just arrived on the plaza when I heard my portable radio come crackling to life. I quickly walked over to a deserted corner behind a booth and pulled it from where I had tucked it into my waistband.

"Um... hello? Hi, anyone from the horror section? Guys, I need someone from the horror section, come in, please. Hurry."

Raising the speaker to my mouth, I responded. "Horror section speaking, what's the matter?"

The distorted voice on the other end stayed silent for a little while before finally answering. "Oh! I get it, you must be the new tamer! Are you with Mr Scratch right now?"

"No... he's in his cage. What's the matter?"

"Okay, so, I hope I'm not overwhelming you with this, but I'm gonna need you to help me with something here. It's... um... urgent. This is Mitchell from Twin Vale Point speaking. The not-actor I'm assigned to just ran off, I lost sight of him and I can't find him anywhere.

“ I think he’s in your section.”

“Shoot. Okay man, what’s he look like?”

Mitchell cleared his throat. “Uh... cowboy attire, you know, large hat, leather vest, chaps and boots. Cleft lip and black teeth.”

“Any idea where he might be at?” I asked.

“Yes, actually. He’s run off into your breakroom once or twice before. I don’t know, maybe he likes it or something, but chances are he’s in there.”

I sighed. “Got it. I’ll check it out. In case I find him, can you wait for me by the entrance?”

“Will do. See you then. Oh, wait, one more thing! He doesn’t talk, but he laughs an awful lot. Don’t let it get to you, he only wants to creep you out.”

“Alright... I’ll remember that.”

After this rather bizarre conversation, I instantly set out for the breakroom. The one in our part of the park is not very large, but it offers a space for Darius and me to change clothes, a table we sometimes eat at as well as a small bathroom with merely a sink and a toilet. Upon entering the room, I immediately spotted him. A man in a cowboy hat was sitting at our table with his back turned to me.

I cleared my throat. “Hello?”

I was really trying to sound confident, but something about the way he was sitting perfectly still and the strange silence that hung in the air just made my skin crawl.
“You’re going to have to return to Mitchell,” I said firmly, hoping the pretender would not notice the slight quiver in my voice. “You don’t belong here. Now get moving.”

No reply. Instead, the cowboy's shoulders began shaking slightly.

"Dude, you're starting to get on my nerves. Get up and walk your ass back to the western section this instant," I ordered, taking a few slow, careful steps towards him.

Again, no response. The quivering of his shoulders grew stronger.

"You hear me? Come on. Please. I need to get back to work."

I walked just a little bit closer and hesitantly reached out to touch his back. The second my hand made contact with the leather of his vest, his head suddenly jerked back. He didn't turn around, he just threw his head back and stared up at me with wide eyes. I instantly backed away blindly, unable to break his gaze. His mouth opened, stretching into a wide, eerie smile and I saw that his teeth were completely black, just like Mitchell had told me. I remember absentmindedly taking notice of the cleft in his upper lip as well. A low, rumbling chuckle erupted from his throat.

The cowboy slowly stood up, his neck still bent backwards so he could keep looking at me. It was a grotesque sight. Finally, he turned around, cackling loudly. He straightened his hat and proceeded towards me, holding out his hand. I stared at him, hesitant to take it, but eventually relented. His palm felt cold and clammy.

"Yeah, uhm... nice to meet you. Are you... gonna get going now?" I stammered, unsure of what to say.

His laughter had faded and he was now regarding me with a strange, void smirk on his face. He didn't let go of my hand. When I tried to pull it away from him, his grip strengthened. I could feel my heart beating faster and faster in my chest. The cowboy was simply standing there, holding my hand and grinning at me with his black teeth.

I didn't know what to do. Trying not to look scared, I watched as droplets

of equally black saliva formed on his lower lip. They soon grew and grew and began running down his chin in tiny streams. I felt some of them land on my own habd which he was still squeezing painfully hard.

A wave of relief washed over me when he let go of my hand. He then reached up to his collar and began unbuttoning his shirt. I quickly took a few steps backwards, raising my hands.

"What are you...? Oh, no, man, you keep that on!" I ordered. I did not like where this was going.

To my surprise, he actually listened this time. He stopped and instead peeled back one side of his shirt, allowing me to see part of his upper body. There were three bullet holes in his chest. The skin around them was frayed and the flesh in the holes themselves gray and dark. It looked rotten. I gagged slightly and turned my head.

I could hear him start to giggle again. His snickering grew into a fit of laughter and when I dared to look at him again, he had buttoned up his shirt and was doubling over. I merely stood there, watching in disbelieve as his eerie, throaty cackle seemed to echoe off the walls of the empty breakroom.

Suddenly, the door was thrown open and light flooded the rather dimly lit space. There was a man standing in the doorway. He was dressed like a sheriff out of an old wild west movie. The cowboy's smile instantly faded from his face when he turned to look at the sheriff, visibly disappointed.

The man dashed forward and grabbed the cowboy by the collar, pulling him away from me. "Here I am, turning my back to you for one damn second and next thing I know, you're off to harass the new employee!" he grunted as he flung him aside. The cowboy quickly regained his footing and looked up at his attacker with narrowed, hateful eyes.

The sheriff introduced himself to me as Mitchell and I accompanied him back to the entrance to Twin Vale Point where we said our goodbyes.

Mitchell had kept a firm grip on the not-actors upper arm the whole time. It reminded me of a parents angrily dragging their misbehaving child along. He told me a couple of things about the cowboy on our way. Due to his humanoid appearance he could not be led around on a leash, so Mitchell had to observe his every move and keep him from wandering off the boundaries of Twin Vale Point.

Usually, he wouldn't cause too many problems. But from time to time he would become a little adventurous. Maybe it was just to annoy Mitchell. Either way, everytime he'd get into that mood, he would run off and pull a prank or get up to some other trouble.

"I don't think he cares what it is he does, as long as it gets on my nerves," he said, side-glancing at the pretender who was begrudgingly walking alongside him.

I wouldn't say that the Laughing Cowboy is the monster I am most scared of. What I find so unnerving about him is that he keeps me in a limbo of trying to decide if he is a threat to me or not. He acts all cute around the visitors, always pauses to take photos with them and posing and stuff. The only time he gets disturbing like that is when one is alone with him.

Plus, I'm not sure if he really means to do any harm or if he just wants to mess with people. There have been instances of him being quite nice to me. One time he even almost saved my life in a way.

Since I was already talking about the not-actors that scare me, I believe it's time I told you about the Sugar Plum Fairy.

The Sugar Plum Fairy is one of the monsters from the candy-themed section. Of course it's directed mainly at really small children. Not unlike the cowboy, the fairy does not cause a lot of trouble most of the time, except for when she does, she makes a way bigger mess.

She has the general appearance of a very short, young woman in a tutu. She wears a bunch of cute accessoires in her hair that look like candy.

She spends all day ballet dancing on a small stage in the candy section. She never stops moving. But every night when the park closes down and the monsters are brought into their overnight shelters, she goes absolutely berserk.

Sure, I can understand she doesn't want to be locked in a cage, but who knows what she would get up to with no one around to watch out for her. The person assigned to her is Maxine. She's a very nice girl and we get along really well. She's dressed up as a princess and loves nothing more than taking pictures with the visitors. She spends her time hanging around the plaza in the candy-section, watching out for the Sugar Plum Fairy.

While the fairy never acts up when there's still visitors around, she sure doesn't hold back when we're the only ones left in the park. This results in Maxine often needing our assisstance in catching her and locking her up at nighttime.

That one night, I had just taken Mr Scratch to his cage, Maxine radioed for me to come over. Most of the other actors had not quite finished up their work yet and were still busy taking care of their own assigned pretenders, so I had to go and help her catch the fairy.

I made my way over to the candy-section where Maxine was waiting for me. She had already changed out of her costume and into her normal everyday clothes. She hurriedly explained to me that the Sugar Plum Fairy had run off when she had entered the stage to take her back to the small trailer she spends the night in and was now roaming this part of the park. We split up to go look for her and I admit I was more than just a little nervous.

The Sugar Plum Fairy doesn't ever show her real face to the visitors. She keeps it hidden under that thing, that mask, which looks like a face but isn't. It's hard to describe.

So I went down to the booths to look for her. It wasn't the first time I had encountered her, so I knew what to expect, but when I found

her sitting on the roof of one of the closed food stands facing me, I nearly got a heart attack. After I had caught my breath again, I carefully continued to approach her.

"Hey," I said softly. I had learned early on that it is best not to anger her. "Would you come down here, please?" I reached up and held out my hand for her, to help her jump off. "Please? For me?"

I breathed a sigh of relief when she placed her tiny hand in mine. Moments later, she landed gracefully on the ground on her tiptoes. No idea how she does that by the way. She let go of my hand and for a moment, we just looked at each other, smiling.

Then her eyes suddenly rolled back into her head, she reached up and pinched the skin on her neck between her fingers and slowly peeled it off all the way up to her forehead, nearly stripping her entire head of its skin and revealing what I already knew was underneath.

The true face of the Sugar Plum Fairy consists entirely of one, large, razor-sharp beak not unlike that of a kraken. She opened it wide, hissing and snarling at me. I stumbled backwards, not sure if what to do. My hand reached for the whip on my waistband, my only means of self-defense, only to remember I had already changed out of my costume.

I continued to back away, the Sugar Plum Fairy slowly and menacingly proceeding towards me on her tiptoes. I screamed for Maxine to help me, knowing full well it was useless. By the time she'd find me, the monster would have probably already managed to take a good chunk out of my arm or something.

The only option I had left was to run. I think I mentioned previously that I am quite fast, but apparently, the Sugar Plum Fairy is faster. She came bounding after me in long, graceful leaps, sometimes stopping to twirl or hop in place. It must have looked funny from an outside perspective. Still, she effortlessly managed to catch up with me and block my path.

Her tiny hands pushed me to the ground with a strength betraying her small, delicate frame. I felt her step on my stomach, painfully pushing the tip of her foot into my soft flesh. Then, all of a sudden, she pulled back.

I hadn't seen or heard him coming, yet when I looked up, the cleft lipped cowboy from Twin Vale Point was standing over me. The look on his face was stern and he had placed one of his hands on the fairy's shoulder. She hissed at him and snapped her beak into his direction a couple times, but he remained unfazed.

He just took her by the arm and calmly walked off with her. I pushed myself off the ground and followed them. He lead her to her trailer, opened the door and helped her climb inside before closing the latches and locking her in. I watched in disbelief as he tipped his hat at me before wandering off to the wild west section. I thought I could hear Mitchell shout something along the lines of "Where the hell were you?" in the distance.

All in all, I think the Sugar Plum Fairy might be the one that creeps me out the most. The cowboy is a close second, but just because he's so unpredictable. Then again, there's so many of them to choose from and each pretender just hits another nerve with me, so I really can't tell for sure.

the Stagecoach and the Mime

Since I touched on the one not-actor from the western section who left a lasting impression in my last post, I think I should introduce the other monster from Twin Vale Point. If you could even call it a monster.

However I need to get some things out of the way regarding the pretenders' origins before I get started. None of us actors know where they come from or what they are. All of them have been here long before any of us started working our current jobs. Then again, Nathan might know something. He is the other actor from Twin Vale Point, but I'll get to that in a second.

The not-actors come in all shapes and sizes. Literally. Sure, most of them share some common traits. For example, only two of them can talk, and they are extremely restricted in their ability to do so.

The other not-actor from the wild west town can barely be described as a single living being at all. It's an old western stagecoach pulled by two large, beautiful chestnut stallions. The stagecoach itself does not have a coachman. That's where Nathan comes in.

Nathan is the actor assigned to the stagecoach. He is the one who steers it. He sits on his coach seat all day, wrapped in an old, ragged blanket. He doesn't talk much. In fact, the only times I've ever really spoken to him, we just exchanged quick greetings. Our interactions never went anywhere past a very awkward introduction. He offered me a dead fish handshake and we just stared at each other for a little while with none of us knowing how to start a conversation and that was it.

For all I know he never leaves his coach seat either. Sure, he probably goes home sometime in the evening, but I've never seen him leave. If Mitchell hadn't told me he was an actor, I'd probably think he was a pretender himself. He's sort of creepy too. I sometimes wonder if maybe the stagecoach has turned him into a part of itself... if he might be a pretender.

The stagecoach only really starts getting weird at nighttime. During the day, Nathan just drives it around Twin Vale Point, much to the

amusement of our visitors. The horses act really friendly around them too. However as soon as sun sets, they... change.

The horses go from docile and gentle to raging and furious. Their eyes start to glow with a blinding white light, making them look alien and eerie. I've seen them buck and even wildly chase through the different parts of the park, pulling the stagecoach along with them as if it had no weight whatsoever. Therefore it is Nathan's task to take the horses to their fenced meadow in the back of the park come nightfall where they cannot be seen or reached by visitors.

According to Mitchell, who apparently learned a lot about Nathan's strange occupation from working alongside him, the chestnuts refuse to be separated from their stagecoach. Whenever someone tries to take off their harnesses, they start going completely berserk. They'll buck and kick and neigh as if they were being slaughtered.

Like I already said, Nathan and I don't talk much, meaning that my contact with the stagecoach is also highly limited. So most of the time, I only spot it in its normal, peaceful state.

I've touched on this in my previous post, but I really love Twin Vale Point for its dry, old-timey charm. I'm a big fan of wild west movies, too. I've caught myself a couple of times sneaking after the stagecoach in hopes of seeing it do its magic, but my curiousity was never rewarded. Instead, the only times I've actually witnessed the horses act up were when I was unprepared and busy and therefore couldn't really enjoy it. I feel bad for liking to watch the stagecoach turn weird, but the few times I've seen it were insanely impressive. It really did look like something out of a movie.

I didn't want to come back to the Laughing Cowboy, but in regards to the stagecoach I guess I have to. I have noticed his tendency to, in lack of a better term, mess around on it.

One time, I saw him standing atop its roof. There were a bunch of visitors standing below him, taking pictures and hollering. There was a little

boy amidst the crowd who seemed to be really into the stagecoach, and the cowboy actually bent down and lifted him up so he could stand on top of the carriage with him. I remember the kid being insanely happy about it, clapping and squealing like crazy. I must admit, the scene was a bit heartwarming.

Other times, the cowboy will just lay or sit down on top of the roof and ride around with Nathan. Of course, the latter can't be bothered with that, although I have seen him try to shoo him off by occasionally making use of his horse whip, only to provoke signature fits of laughter from his unwanted passenger.

My disadvantage in this is that the cowboy in turn appears to have noticed my own tendency to follow the stagecoach around, resulting in him staring at me from atop its roof with a wide smile on his face. I can't stand his gaze for long, so whenever he's around the carriage, I make it a point not to get too close to it.

Speaking of things I cannot stand, I simply have to mention the other not-actor from the candy section. While the Sugar Plum Fairy is scary enough as she is, this one doesn't really have to get aggressive to make me run for it.

Let me preface this by saying that I absolutely hate mimes. I don't know what it is, but I just don't like them. I don't think they're entertaining and their face paint just looks weird. Plus, their exaggerated motions and expressions are sort of unsettling to me, but it's not like I'm actually scared of them.

However if there is one mime worth being scared of, it's the one of the candy-section of our amusement park. The actor assigned to him is Anne. She's a sweet, bubbly girl who I get along with splendidly. Her costume is a clown outfit, but it's really cute, pink and frilly, not one of those creepy ones you see in horror movies. The kids love her and for some reason that is just absolutely beyond me, they also love the Mime.

He spends all day hopping around his part of the park, making balloon animals for the children and handing out candy to them. However, not unlike the Laughing Cowboy, the Mime has these days on which he's in a bit of a strange mood. Thankfully, one can determine what kind of state he is in just by looking at him, so all Anne really has to do is assess his behavior in the morning and then decide on whether to let him out to roam the park for the day.

He's the only human-like pretender who sleeps in a sheltered cage instead of a trailer or something similarly comfortable. The Mime's shelter might have a bit of a prison cell look to it, but at least there's a roof above it and there's blankets and pillows and stuff. He is simply too dangerous on his bad days.

It is very easy to tell when he's not fit to be let out. The first time I saw him like that was on a cool morning in early June. We were expecting a ton of visitors that day, so the other actors and I had decided we were going to be using our walkie-talkies. I was in my and Darius's breakroom, the latter having not yet arrived, and in the process of dressing up when to my surprise, the portable radio came crackling to life.

"Hi! Anyone here already?" Anne's cheerful voice came from the small device.

I grinned. "Hey, Anne!"

"Glad I'm not the only one who's early," she replied. "Hey, could you come over? I kinda need a second opinion here."

"Oh? Trouble with the Mime?" I asked.

"Yeah, sort of... I'm not sure if I should let him out today. He seems fine, but I have a bad feeling about this. I can't explain why, but I'm really not sure."

"Well, okay then. Give me a minute, I'm heading over right away," I assured her.

I was not fully dressed up yet but I didn't want to keep Anne waiting, so I walked over to the candy-section in my black, frilly monster hunter dress shirt and yoga pants, a combination that caused my co-worker to laugh at me for about two minutes straight before finally getting to the point. She led me over to the Mime's shed which was hidden behind a row of booths.

Looking through the bars of the cage, I found the Mime standing in there, upright and perfectly still. He looked back at us with a thin smile. He was very quiet.

"I feel like he's messing with me," she explained in low voice when we were out of earshot from the pretender again. "He's never been so calm before. He's usually way more excited."

"Yeah, but come on. You really think he's, like, smart enough to try and deceive you?" I asked. "I always thought you two were on good terms."

"Yes, but I just can't say for sure this time. Do you think I should let him out?"

I frowned. "We can't keep him in there if he's not acting up. I mean, he hasn't done anything wrong. I think it wouldn't be fair. I've never seen him be hostile before, but this really doesn't look too bad."

Anne sighed. "You're right. I guess I was just worrying too much again." She reached into her pocket and retrieved a small key which she turned inside the doorlock and then continued to unlatch the two additional deadbolts. She opened the door and the Mime stepped outside.

"Hey," she greeted him. "Sorry I kept you waiting."

He didn't react. Instead, he sunk to his knees and threw his head back. "Oh crap," I could hear Anne mutter before he opened his mouth. A choking sound came from somewhere in his throat as his lips and then his jaws proceeded to part wider and wider.

What he did next is nearly indescribable. Have you ever seen the ballet dance "The Spider" by Milena Sidorova? It's amazing as a performance, but when the Mime dropped onto all fours with the corners of his mouth stretched all the way to his ears and began to hiss at us, it was not quite as pretty.

He was standing on the tips of his fingers and toes, his back bent at an unnatural angle. I cursed myself for not having dressed up completely before leaving the breakroom. My whip might have served as a good means of defense. The Mime scuttled past us at an alarming speed and Anne and I exchanged quick, knowing glances before sprinting off after him.

"I can't believe he actually tricked me," Anne panted. She was a bit out of shape and unable to keep up with me for long.

"I'm sorry!" I shouted as I passed her, continuing to pursue the not-actor.

The Mime was incredibly fast. I found myself wheezing and gasping for air after about eight minutes of following him through the candy-section. Eventually, I had to stop to catch my breath and before I knew it, I had lost sight of him. I cursed.

Suddenly, out of the corner of my eye, I saw a shadow vanish behind the stage the Sugar Plum Fairy always dances on. She had not been let out yet, so the stage itself was deserted, but I was certain I could hear the tapping of feet behind it. I made my way around its back, but he wasn't there. At least that's what I thought before something wet and warm hit my head.

I slowly looked up to find the Mime hovering above me. He was holding onto the stage's metal light fixture and staring down at me, his mouth still opened unnaturally wide. Drops of saliva were dripping from his tongue which was hanging out from his maw.

I stood frozen in horror for what felt like an eternity, not daring to break

the stare of the pretender. I could feel my heart pounding wildly in my chest and my hands beginning to tremble. The Mime seemed to slowly, ever so slowly lowering himself towards the ground.

Suddenly, I saw something fly past me out of the corner of my eye and collide with the Mime's head. The not-actor let out a sharp hiss of pain and I took a step back just in time as he had lost his grip on the light fixture and fell to the ground. I took my chance and threw myself on top of him to hold him in place and instantly began to yell for Anne to come help me.

The thing that had caused the Mime to fall was a small, but heavy rock. I discovered it lying on the ground next to me while I was waiting for Anne to arrive, still holding the struggling pretender in place. To this day I have no idea who had thrown that rock, but whoever it was probably spared me a lot of physical pain. I'm not sure if I would have stood a chance against the Mime if it weren't for this short but effective distraction.

Either way, I can only repeat that I am not fond of mimes whatsoever and the one we have in our park sure isn't helping that. Also, Anne has agreed to never take my advice again. As you might expect, I kept apologizing to her for a long while after that incident.

Lastly, I should probably mention that I talked to Maxine about the Sugar Plum Fairy's enclosure. She explained that the trailer she lives in is very secure, albeit old, and that it holds a bed for her to sleep in. Some of you suggested it might be helpful to give her a bigger space to stay in for the night since all she seems to want to do is dance around, meaning that she would not be as opposed to returning into the trailer. To me and Maxine, this makes total sense and it would also spare us a lot of trouble.

We have decided to try and approach Dale about the issue, but I'm not sure any type of conversation with him will lead to positive results. I think I've said it before, but he's a douche. Still, trying doesn't hurt and that's what we're going to do. I guess we'll just see how it goes.

my shady manager

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. After my last post, I initially wanted to introduce the two pretenders from the Hollywood section today, but in light of very recent events, I changed my mind. It's very late as of me writing this.

Let me preface this by explaining a few things. While the park is closed for the season, that of course does not mean we are allowed to stay at home. There are two reasons for this. For one it would be utterly irresponsible to simply abandon the creatures in our care and also, we would not get paid a single cent. Paid leaves don't really exist in Dale's book. That means they do exist, but only on paper.

Therefore, even though the park is completely void of visitors, each of us have to come in at least for a couple hours a day to check up on the pretenders. By the way, they aren't locked up at the moment. We decided on leaving them running around freely since it would be torture to force them to stay in their enclosures during our absence. So of course, we need to be alert.

I don't really know when the others come in, so I got ready in the morning and arrived at the park around early noon. I was aware I would probably be the only one there, but I admit I like the quiet. Plus, you're never really alone with the not-actors at large. I obviously had my whip with me. Ever since I got around to learning how to use it, I've grown rather fond of it... it looks cool when I crack it is what I'm saying.

Dale had given me and the other actors extra keys for the employee entrance so we could get in and out effortlessly. I was not surprised to find the park completely deserted. While I was not sure where the other pretenders were at, I did not waste any time on trying to find out. Instead, I determinedly headed for Mr Scratch's cage.

As expected, I found its door wide open, but the sock puppet was lying inside nonetheless, peacefully snoozing away. He's grown a bit lazy these days. He must have noticed me approaching, because as soon as I had reached the cage, he perked up and clumsily rose to his feet. He sluggishly came trotting out to greet me and I took my sweet time

petting and scratching his shiny fur.

I didn't need to put him on a leash today. Why would I? There were no visitors around he could potentially pose a threat to. We peacefully walked alongside each other for about half an hour. We did not encounter any of the other not-actors, which was very refreshing. Plus, it was nice being at my usual workplace in my comfortable everyday clothing instead of the costume for once.

Afterwards, I fed him some raw chicken which he gobbled down in one go. I was really enjoying myself so I wanted to keep strolling around, but the sock puppet apparently had a different idea. He returned to his shelter where he plopped down to take another nap. That was fine with me though. Why not let him have his lazy days?

I for one decided on taking another walk around the premises. There was not a soul out on the plaza or the streets. The funhouses looked even creepier with no one around. I figured the other not-actors were taking the same approach to their new-found freedom of movement since I had yet to come across any of them, although I was willing to bet that the Sugar Plum Fairy was up on her little stage dancing. The thought of the pretenders hiding somewhere was rather unsettling though.

Before I knew it, I had left the streets and reached the grassy part of the terrain on the outer edge of the park. I thought about going to the meadow and checking out the stagecoach, but changed my mind when I suddenly heard someone murmur.

My mind instantly wandered to the likes of the Mime and I reached for my whip, however upon looking around, I found that there was nobody there. Still on high alert, I proceeded to sneak along the fenced perimeter until I finally spotted a man with his back turned to me a short distance ahead.

I squinted but soon recognized the familiar slouching posture of my manager Dale. A bit taken aback but relieved that there was no pretender around after all, I walked up to him. He didn't notice me at first, rather

he seemed to be focused on something he was holding in his hands, all while continuing to mutter inaudible phrases to himself.

At first I barely payed any attention to his behavior at all. I figured that now was as good a time as any to talk to him about the Sugar Plum Fairy's enclosure, so I put on my finest good-employee-smile and quickly approached him.

"Good morning!" I called out to him.

His reaction was... unexpected. He let out a startled gasp and spun around with wide eyes. Upon seeing me, he seemingly relaxed a little. I could now see the object in his hands as well. It was a slim, worn-out notebook. As soon as he noticed me staring at it, he slammed it shut.

"Shit!" he growled, running his hand through his hair. "What the hell's gotten into you? Why'd you have to sneak up on me like that?"

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to scare you or anything," I said, trying to look like I actually cared. "What are you doing?" I added curiously.

"None of your business," he replied, eyeing me suspiciously. "What did you see?" he asked after a little while.

"Just you talking to yourself while holding a book. Which is weird. That's why I asked."

Dale nodded, and appearing to be a little more at ease, repeated, "None of your business." He sounded a little friendlier this time though.

"So," I began, "Maxine and I have been wanting to ask you something, but before you say no, please hear me out."

Dale sighed exasperatedly. "Look, I don't really..." his voice trailed off. "Nevermind. What do you want?"

Ignoring his slightly aggressive tone, I explained our suggestion about a

larger enclosure for the Sugar Plum Fairy. "See where I'm coming from? It's obvious all she wants to do is dance. If we give her more space, she'd be less reluctant to being locked up at night. And I don't think I have to tell you that that would save us a lot of trouble financially. Think of what it would cost to have an actor or another employee attacked and needing medical attention. On top of that, now that there's no one visiting the park, we'd have plenty of time to re-house her and let her get used to her new home."

With that, I finished my speech. Dale looked at me pensively for a few seconds before clearing his throat. "I admit you do have a point."

I beamed at him. "Does that mean we'll do it?"

"No."

"What? But why not?" I asked.

"First off, we'd have to buy a larger trailer and those things are expensive. No one from higher management is gonna want to pay for some luxury van only for that tutu creep to dance around in it. Also, and I'm gonna be frank here, who cares?"

"Well, you sure don't," I muttered.

Dale chuckled. "Don't tell me you actually thought I wasn't gonna see through this. It's for your own good. You shouldn't treat monsters with too much affection. If you start thinking of them as humans, things here will go downhill in no time. Sure, some of the ones we have here might be a bit more agreeable and for them I'd be willing to comply. But the fairy... na-ah."

Despite his condescending tone, I tried one last time to convince him with kindness. "But couldn't we at least look for a better option? Maybe we'll find something cheap. You said yourself that we have a point. Come on... please?"

Dale rolled his eyes. I hated myself a little for pleading with him like that. “Look, it’s not my decision to make, I get it! But Maxine and I would be very, very relieved if we could re-house the fairy. Do it for us then!”

He squinted. “Are you hitting on me?”

I felt my stomach drop at the sheer thought. I had tried to be nice, but this was it. I was so done with his crap.

“Not to be rude, but the Laughing Cowboy has better chances than you,” I hissed.

Dale threw his head back and laughed. “Oh, I bet he does.”

This is it, I thought, I’m going to murder my manager.

He must have sensed it, because he suddenly backed up a little and raised his hands. “Chill out, girl. Let’s not... get physical here. If this is so important to you and Maxine, I’ll meet you ladies half way. If you two can find a new, better enclosure for the Sugar Plum Fairy, I’ll help rehouse her. I’ll give you some money for it, but the park won’t be able to pay for more than a third of it. We’re not making profit at the moment, so we gotta be careful with our savings.”

I felt myself relax a little. “That’s... actually nice. Thanks. I can work with that.”

“Good. Now that that’s out of the way, would you mind leaving me alone?”

“Yeah, um... what is it that you’re doing here anyways?” I repeated my question from earlier in hopes of receiving an answer now that he was more cooperative.

“I already told you, it’s none of your business,” he replied.

I decided to leave him be, but I kept watching him from a safe distance. He walked the length of the fence enclosing the park, nose buried in that worn notebook of his. I soon grew tired of observing him, so I returned to the sock puppet's cage to play with it some more.

The image of Dale murmuring to himself while staring at his writings did not leave my mind though. In the back of my head I was conjuring up the strangest theories about what he could be doing. Was he conducting some sort of ritual? Part of me wondered whether the notebook might be holding incantations of sorts, even though that sounds sort of ridiculous.

I made my way home in the late afternoon. The sun was already setting as I headed out through the employee entrance. To my surprise, I encountered Maxine there. She told me she had come to check up on the Sugar Plum Fairy. She had apparently been at the park in the early morning hours already. She doesn't have a lot of work on her hands these days. I've never seen the fairy eat or drink or let on she required anything a normal person might need to live. As I said, all she does is dance.

I relayed my conversation with the manager to Maxine. We've already asked some of our friends including our co-workers, and it turns out Mitchell's dad has a very large trailer he wants to get rid of. He's willing to give it to us at a low price, so if Dale keeps his promise, we should be able to re-accomodate the fairy in it very soon.

I have since done some research on Dale too. At least I tried. I know it's not a very sophisticated way of snooping around, but I googled his full name only to get no results other than him being listed as manager on the official website of our amusement park. I'm starting to think that maybe I should try and get my hands on that book he was carrying. I have not given up on finding out about the monsters' origins yet, and if he is not going to answer my questions, maybe I'll just have to resort to more direct measures.

Each time I am asked about incidents in the theme park that have caused

casualties, I instantly remember one specific, extremely heartbreaking event that took place nearly two years ago. Since a lot of people have expressed interest in these kind of happenings, I believe this might be a good time to talk about it.

We do not have casualties as often as one might think. Surprising, I know, and it certainly isn't because management is particularly careful or something. This incident is more or less connected to a not-actor I introduced last time. The Mime.

As you know, this creature unsettles me quite deeply. Anne for some reason actually likes him. She says that he's only creepy on his bad days and that I should remember all the times he's been docile. She's delusional.

Then again, I can kind of understand her. When you are assigned to a certain object or being, it's immediately a personal matter and it can kind of start to grow on you. Me and my sock puppet are the perfect example.

The night in question was a special one. I don't exactly remember why, but I do know there were some celebrations going on and that there was going to be a firework.

For clarification, we had already had fireworks on multiple occasions and none of the not-actors ever appeared to be bothered by them. Actually, I think I even saw the nurse look up dreamily at the sky regarding them one time, one of the only occasions on which she has shown any sign of conciousness. Nobody could have expected what happened and I don't think it had anything to do with the special show.

The visitors had gathered on the main plaza of the Hollywood section. All the lights had been turned off and even the ferris wheel wasn't shining in its flashy colors anymore. All was quiet until the fireworks began.

I remember standing a bit offsides next to Darius. We were staring at

the night sky expectantly. When the first golden sparks illuminated the darkness, the whole crowd, including us, began to cheer. Soon, the square was filled with noise. The voices of the guests and the sounds of explosions should have drowned out everything else... except they didn't.

I remember distancing myself from the crowd because I thought I had heard someone scream. Not the normal happy kind of shouting of the fireworks' audience though. I tried to ask Darius if he had heard it too, but he did not even hear me. He was too caught up in the moment, I guess.

Nonetheless, I made my way over to where I had thought the scream had come from. I wandered the booths, main street and restaurants. Almost everyone had gone off to watch the fireworks and there were only few employees left in the shops. At first, my search yielded no results. Still, I continued looking. Maybe there indeed was somebody in need of help somewhere after all.

I don't remember where I found her exactly. I just know I rounded a corner and there she was. She was lying flat on her stomach in the middle of a side street between two restaurants. I don't think I've ever seen so much blood in one place before.

I immediately ran up to her, not having quite fathomed yet that it was already too late. I turned her onto her back to find that her throat was torn. Not slit, not like one had used a knife on her, more like a wild animal had clawed at her neck. She was one of the restaurant waitresses, I recognized her uniform and apron, even though her clothers were covered in blood.

I must have been standing over her body for a full minute before finally getting a grip on reality again and rushing off to get help. But just as I was turning around, I spotted familiar black and white stripes out of the corner of my eye. For a split second, and I am absolutely sure of this, I saw the Mime cowering behind a trash can further down the street.

The park was shut down immediately after I had reported my discovery. The police were called. We, the actors that is, were tasked with gathering the pretenders in the back of the park where the cops wouldn't find them. They didn't come looking though. No one ever did.

The Mime acted very inconspicuous that night. There was no blood on his clothing or anything and Anne kept assuring me my fear of him combined with the horrifying experience of discovering a dead body had caused me to see things. I had no choice but to relent.

Plus, there was no way of proving anything. It was a bit unlikely that the Mime could have gotten from the candy section to the Hollywood one and back in such little time, I'll admit that. Still, knowing that he's prone to deceive people, I would not want to discard that idea entirely.

Dale seemed to at least believe me a little bit. He ordered to keep the Mime in his cage for two entire months after that incident. According to him, it was to assess his behavior, but I think it was more akin to a punishment. When he was allowed back out, he was as peaceful as can be. I still think it was him though. After all, who else could have done it?

On the paper, the casualty was not a casualty at all by the way. The official story is that the waitress had chosen that night to commit suicide and that it was Dale who had found her. Of course, that's complete nonsense.

I don't think most outsiders would ever question this story. For all I know, the waitress lived by herself and had no closer relatives, so there was no one there to question it in the beginning. As for the police, I can only imagine how much money was paid under the table that night to keep the finer details from getting out. I've been suspecting management to have some sort of deal with the local officials anyway.

The park lost none of its prestige and in the end, it's like the whole thing never happened. And that's exactly what bothers me. The death of a person being swept under the rug like that... it's terrifying to me. Whether it was the Mime who took her life or not.

the Aged Diva and the Pianist

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. After I mainly talked about my suspicions regarding my manager in my previous post, I finally want to introduce the two other pretenders that roam the theme park. I also want to mention that I have some rather interesting news up ahead, but first things first.

The Hollywood section of the amusement park I work at is, and I'm going to be frank here, the one I care for the least. Its rollercoasters are rather standard and tame and there's nothing special to me about its design. It looks like something out of a movie, sure, but not the type of movie I'd watch. Everything in there is shiny and glammed up. I can't deny it all looks very pretty, but it just doesn't catch my eye as much as the horror or wild west section do.

I will begin with the pretender from the Hollywood section I first came into contact with: the Aged Diva.

She's a tall, slender older woman dressed in one of these sparkling dresses out of the fifties or sixties from the looks of it. She wears black silk gloves and is always holding one of these long, slim cigarettes.

She is the most articulate out of all the pretenders since she can actually talk in full sentences. The problem is that the only times she makes use of this ability are when she is thanking people for getting complimented. When she does talk, she repeats herself a lot and her words sound like they were recorded prior to the conversation, if that makes sense.

Flattery matters a lot to her. She reacts very friendly when praised, however when she is being insulted in any way, things can get... interesting. I've seen it happen a few times. Personally, I think she gets offended way too easily, but of course I would never say that to her face. Hell, even I've managed to accidentally trigger her a couple times. Let me give you an example.

I was just strolling around her part of the park during breaktime. I had changed into my daily wear and just bought myself some ice cream when I noticed her standing nearby. I was not in my costume so I wasn't

sure she'd recognize me as a park employee, but I thought I'd try and talk to her anyways since I had not gotten much opportunity to do so up to that point.

I had already met her assigned actor Oliver, an enthusiastic, friendly guy who had told me all about the Aged Diva. That she could actually talk but only really reacted to compliments and so on. Obviously, I wasn't going to pass up this chance to get to know her, so I walked up to her.

Smiling politely, I greeted her. "Um... hello! It's very nice to finally meet you, I'm..." I began, but she cut me off.

"Oh thank you, dear! Would you like to take a picture with me?" She was beaming at me.

I shook my head. "No, actually, I'm an..." My voice trailed off the second I realized I probably should not have said no.

The corners of her mouth began to droop first. Then the skin of her cheeks slowly began to sink to her chin. Her lower eyelids began to flow down and the white of her eyes soon followed after. It was like Oliver had told me... her face was melting off. I felt like gagging.

I stood in front of her with raised hands, unsure of what to do. Looking around frantically, I found that to my great relief none of the visitors were watching. Redirecting my attention to the Aged Diva, I noticed that by now, her scalp had molten off as well and I could actually see the white of her skull. I rose to my tiptoes, trying to obscure the sight from any passing guests. I knew it wouldn't be long now.

Finally, her head was looking like a shapeless wad of wax by then, she reached the, as Oliver had called it, last stage. I don't know how else to say this, but she... exploded. There was a sharp sound not unlike a balloon being popped, and suddenly, all that was left of her were a few sparkles in the air. Oliver was really angry with me about it.

This does not happen as often as one would expect. Sometimes there are

some bad-mannered kids running around where she's at and trigger her by shouting insults or just not being polite in general, but I can count down the amount of times that happened on one hand. On the few occasions that it did occur, the visitors seemed to think it was some sort of magic trick. At least that's what I believe since I don't think anyone ever made a big deal of it. She dematerializes and reappears in random locations all throughout the Hollywood section.

She seems to have forgotten all about my little mishap by now, which is a good thing considering I viewed her as my only potential source of information for a long time. However when I finally got around to talking to her again, she proved to be pretty much useless.

It was a cloudy, muggy day and the ashen sky threatened an oncoming storm. There were very little visitors in the park that day and, since I was on my break and Oliver was busy, I snuck over to the Hollywood section to see the diva. I found her sitting at a table in a deserted café near the main plaza. I took a deep breath, mentally preparing myself. I had thought it all out and decided she might be able to talk normally to me if I'd sprinkle in small compliments all throughout our conversation. In hindsight, that idea was simply stupid.

I walked up to her and greeted her with a wide smile. "Hello, ma'am, it's so nice to see you! You're looking absolutely splendid today!"

She looked up to me, returning my broad grin. "Oh my!" she said in that high-pitched, hoarse voice of hers. "What a lovely thing to say! Here, won't you sit with me?" She pointed at the chair across from her.

I nodded eagerly and took a seat. "Thank you very much, you're too kind! So, ma'am, I have been wanting to ask you some questions I believe only you are able to answer."

The elderly lady perked up. "You don't say. Well, ask away then. What can I help you with, dear?"

"Where does a beauty like you come from?" I felt utterly ridiculous.

“Ah, sweetheart, I was born here. I’ve been here all my life.” She sighed dramatically. “I was predestined for Hollywood life, it seems.”

“I do think you were,” I replied. “Now, I hope I’m not stealing any of your precious time, but would you mind telling me where the others are from then?”

“What others, dearie?”

“Well, the ones that are... like you.”

“What others, dearie?” she repeated in the exact same tone and cadence as before. It was eerie.

“Like, the... uh... the ballerina? And Mr Scratch, the stagecoach and the cowboy who’s always laughing?”

Her expression darkened. “The cowboy? That ugly, misshapen brat?”

I felt tempted to tell her she was not the prettiest herself, but refrained from doing so. “Yes, that one. Know anything about him or the others?”

“What others, dearie?”

I sighed. “The ballerina, Mr Scratch, the stagecoach, the cowboy and so on,” I told her.

“The cowboy? That ugly, misshapen brat?”

It was useless. I thanked her, got up and left.

I have come to the conclusion that I will probably not be getting any answers from the pretenders themselves. But I won’t stop trying.

The other pretender from the Hollywood section is a bit more strange than the Diva, although he looks just as inconspicuous at first glance. We simply call him The Pianist.

The Hollywood part of the theme park is home to a lot of restaurants, ice cream parlors and the like. That's because it is closest to the entrance of the park itself, meaning that no matter which section the visitors go for first, they will pass tons of little establishments emanating the alluring scents of food and candy.

In one of the largest, prettiest restaurants, there's a small stage with a piano on it. And that's where he sits, all day, everyday. He reminds me a lot of the Sugar Plum Fairy since he never does anything else but play that piano. However he is a little more extreme about it.

The Pianist cannot be locked away at night. In fact, he cannot be moved from the stool he's sitting on at all. He looks to be middle-aged and wears a white tuxedo. He's always smiling and usually never even looks up from the keys of his instrument. There is a tip jar on the piano though and whenever one of the visitors throws a coin into it, he looks up at them, smiles and thanks them.

The Pianist is definitely one of the more mysterious pretenders. He might seem harmless, but he's more of a threat than he's letting on.

His assigned actress is Caroline. She's sweet, but I'm not as close to her as most of my other co-workers like Maxine, Anne or Darius. Her costume resembles the outfit of Audrey Hepburn in Breakfast at Tiffany's. While one might think she wouldn't have a lot of work with her not-actor since he doesn't need to be locked up or closely observed, she does have one very important task.

Every day at three pm, Caroline has to go up to him and ask him if he needs anything, to which he will always respond with the same words.

"No thank you, dear."

For a long time, I didn't understand what was so pressing about this matter. It was not until I had the chance to have a longer conversation with Caroline in the same restaurant that I got an idea of why she took

her responsibility to do this seemingly futile chore so seriously.

"It's not about if him actually needing anything," she explained to me. "It's all about the question itself. When I started working here, Dale stressed that I could never be late with it. Everytime someone fails to ask him, somebody in the park dies."

I remember perking up. "For real?"

She nodded, a stern look on her face. "That's what Dale says at least. But I'm not going to take any chances. Especially since he told me what happened the last time someone didn't ask him in time." She leaned across the table we were sitting at and added in a lower tone, "The guy before me forgot one day. He was five minutes late, but that was already enough. During these five minutes, a man had suffered a heart attack riding one of our rollercoasters. Of course, the actor was fired."

I frowned. "Couldn't it have been a coincidence?"

"No way. It's happened twice before that too, you know. It was always during the time in which the assigned actor of the piano player failed to show up, and it was always a heart attack. I think the first time was a lady on the ferris wheel. Does that sound like a coincidence to you? No healthy person will just get a heart attack all of a sudden, let alone on something as harmless as the ferris wheel."

I had to admit it made sense. Looking over at the Pianist who was sitting on his stage and playing as always, I got a weird sinking feeling in my stomach. He suddenly seemed a lot less innocent than before.

I mentioned that I had something interesting to tell you before and I think now is the time to do so. Ever since my conversation with Dale yesterday, I've been thinking about how he was protecting his precious notebook from my curious eyes. There had to be something important in there, something he didn't want me to see. With the way he was avoiding my questions, it simply had to be of significance. When I went to the park today, I had already made up my mind. I was going to try

and get my hands on that book.

Dale has his office in a small building near the main entrance of the amusement park, right where the tickets can be bought. He usually does not spend all day in there though, I often see him wandering about outside. It appears he has not dropped this habit of his, even now that the park is shut down and completely deserted.

After I had arrived, it must have been around twelve am, I went to follow my normal routine of feeding and playing with Mr Scratch. The sock puppet was rather happy to see me. I guess he's been growing pretty bored lately with no visitors around. I took him for a long walk during which I kept an eye out for any not-actors or shady managers.

I actually did spot the nurse standing in front of one of the funhouses, staring into nothingness as always. I wondered if Darius was coming in at all these days. A bit later we came across the Stagecoach. Nathan was sitting in his coach seat holding the horses' reins like he would on any other day. I waved at him and he nodded back to me wordlessly. I watched as the carriage rolled past me. Afterwards, I took Mr Scratch back to his cage before making my way over to Dale's office.

Of course I had to pass through the Hollywood section to reach it. It was spooky being all alone in there. While I looked for my manager, I couldn't find him anywhere, meaning that if he was in the park at all, he was nowhere nearby.

The building Dale's office is in is more of a polished shed. It's even smaller than our breakroom and has only one window. I tried the door first only to find it locked, which was not too surprising but disappointing nonetheless. I then rounded the corner to peer in through the window. It was shut and could not be opened from outside, but I could see Dale's desk in the middle of the room as well as a large closet and a file cabinet.

I realized that I had not thought this through. I had no means of getting in there. I was just about to leave so I turned around, but let out a scream as I collided with someone who had been standing right behind me.

Half expecting it to be my manager, I instantly backed away, only to realize that it wasn't Dale I had bumped into.

The Laughing Cowboy was looking down at me with a knowing black-teethed smirk.

"It's you," I gasped. "Oh snap... you really scared me. Did you have to sneak up on me like that?"

His harelipped grin stretched all the way up to his ears as he tilted his head sideways. Slightly unsettled, I attempted to return a smile, only for him to start chuckling. Black, thick saliva dripped from the corner of his mouth.

"What are you doing here at all?" I inquired. "Are you bored or something?"

The cowboy's chuckling grew fainter as he slowly shook his head.

"Why are you all the way out here? I thought you didn't like Hollywood..." my voice trailed off. "Did you follow me here?"

He nodded, beginning to snicker quietly once again. Before I could say anything else, he raised his hand and pointed at Dale's shed, raising a brow. Suddenly feeling like I had to explain myself, I fumbled for words. "Okay, I know this looks weird, but there's something in Dale's office... I mean, I don't know if it's in there... but he has, like, this notebook that I want to have a look at. I swear, I didn't want to break anything... uh..."

The cowboy raised his hand and I fell quiet. He looked as if he was trying to tell me to stay where I was. He then turned around and ran off. I thought about following him, but eventually remained in place. I waited for about ten minutes before I could hear hurried footsteps echo through the empty streets again.

The cowboy was sprinting towards me, keeping his hat in place with one hand while holding something in the other. As he got closer, I

recognized it to be the notebook. He was cackling loudly. Instead of coming to a halt in front of me, he let go of his hat and grabbed me by the wrist, pulling me along with him.

"I take it we're running from Dale?" I panted as I hurried to keep up with him. He was surprisingly fast. Of course, I received no reply except for a short nod.

We hid away in a side street by the plaza between two gift shops. The cowboy handed me the notebook and gestured for me to hurry. I nodded and frantically began flicking through its pages. In hindsight, I should have probably taken some pictures of the notebook's content with my smartphone, but in the heat of the moment, logic apparently escaped me.

Most of the pages held either numbers which I failed to interpret but assume to be of financial meaning. However there was a set of pages that struck me as off. There was a piece of paper glued to one of them which seemed to be a photocopy of some very old piece of writing. I didn't have enough time to study it, but the handwritten lines on the following pages were strange enough in themselves.

I cannot remember them in exact detail, mainly because the phrases were more of a jumbled mess of words than anything else. One sentence however kept reappearing throughout and burned itself into my memory.

"We who now claim ownership of this land are aware of and willing to pay the price."

It was little later that I could hear quick, heavy footsteps approaching.

"Come back here, you asshole!" Dale's familiar voice came from somewhere out on the plaza. "This crap really isn't funny anymore!"

The cowboy, who had been standing next to me looking over my shoulder, swiftly grabbed the notebook from my hands and rushed

back out onto the street before my manager could find us. I heard Dale shouting at him for about a minute before he gave one final, exasperated grunt and left. When the sound of his footsteps had grown distant, I left my hiding spot.

The Laughing Cowboy was leaning against the wall of a restaurant on the plaza, apparently waiting for me. I thanked him profusely. With his help, I had at least gotten a glimpse of what Dale had been so keen on hiding. The best thing about that was that my manager obviously believed the cowboy had simply been playing a prank on him. He doesn't know I had a look at it, which spares me a lot of trouble.

In regards to the Laughing Cowboy, I told him that if he ever needed anything, he should let me know. This seemed to get him thinking for a while, but eventually, he just shook his head and tipped his hat at me before leaving, which I believe to either be his way of saying "You're welcome" or "Goodbye". Or maybe it's both.

Either way, I'm at home now and still trying to make sense of Dale's notebook.

"We who now claim ownership of this land are aware of and willing to pay the price."

the Nurse

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. After I introduced the two pretenders from the Hollywood section in my last post, I'll have to touch on one of my earlier mentions again this time.

I never really thought I would have to talk a lot about the Nurse. The only questions asked about her have been inquiries as to whether she is hot, because apparently, my description of her missing her lower jaw and being braindead have not been a sufficient answer to that.

However there have also been comments about how her non-threatening and rather pitiable appearance may be a front and that she might be more dangerous than she's letting on. I admit I never truly took that possibility into consideration, but if I ever had reason to believe it could be the case, today is the day that I got it.

I came in to work at around twelve and went straight for the cage of the sock puppet. He was apparently expecting me since he was sitting outside his shelter and instantly came bounding towards me. It's rare that I receive such an exuberant greeting from him, but I guess he does have his lively days after all.

By the way, some of you have asked if I ever played fetch with him, and I did try to do so a couple times before opening hours, but I was never too successful. Whenever I would throw a ball for him, he would just look at me stupidly instead of running after it.

One time, I brought in a plushie to see if that would get him going, and it actually did. He chased after it, but instead of bringing it back to me, he attempted to eat it. At least until he noticed what he was digging his teeth into was merely a helpless heap of cotton and not some kind of treat. He went on to stare at me with a look of betrayal that entire day. I think the concept of playing is simply beyond his understanding.

Anyways, after feeding and grooming him a little, we set out on our daily walk around the park. On our way, we encountered Mitchell. He was sitting at a table outside a saloon in Twin Vale Point, eating

his homemade lunch. I sat down across from him and we talked for a while, at first only about this and that, until for some reason, the topic of Darius came up.

"Have you seen him at all lately?" I remember Mitchell asking.

I shook my head. "Not really, no. But I don't blame him. I mean, it's not like the Nurse needs him around or anything."

Mitchell shrugged. "I don't think the cowboy needs me either, but I still come in to check up on him."

"As proven by you sitting here eating," I remarked, raising a brow.

Mitchell gulped down a bite of his sandwich. "It's not like that! He's fine, I just went to see him. He's with Nathan, riding around on that carriage again."

"If you say so."

Mitchell sighed. "All I'm saying is that it feels weird not having seen Darius for so long. I wonder if he's okay."

"Have you tried calling him already?" I suggested and Mitchell shook his head no. "Let's try it then," I added, taking out my cell phone and dialing his number. We waited for Darius to answer for about half a minute before I gave in and ended the call. "Strange," I muttered.

"You'd think he'd have time to answer his phone," Mitchell remarked. "I got a bad feeling about this. You think something's happened to him?"

I frowned. "I hope not. We'll just try again later. Or maybe he'll call back."

Mitchell finished up his lunch and then got up to join me in walking the sock puppet. It was sort of nice having someone to talk to tag along, even though he made it a point to keep his distance from Mr Scratch.

He's a bit wary of him.

We went all the way over to the breakroom of the horror section. Mr Scratch nudged me gently as if wanting to say goodbye before trotting away to his cage. Leaning against the wall of the small building the breakroom is in, I took out my cell phone again. I figured that maybe this time Darius would take my call. Mitchell looked at me expectantly. We waited in vain until suddenly, I thought I could hear a ringtone coming from inside the small building.

I gestured for Mitchell to follow me as I proceeded to open the door and entered the breakroom. The sound of the ringtone got louder. It did not take long for us to find the source. Darius's cell phone was lying abandoned on top of the table, right next to his backpack.

I ended the call and picked up my co-workers smartphone. It showed seven missed calls in total, two of which I knew were my own. Most of the others were listed as "Mom" and "Dad". There was even a message from his mother reading, "I thought you were going to come over this morning?"

Mitchell and I exchanged concerned glances. He was the first out of the two of us to speak up.

"This means he's gotta be around here somewhere, right?"

I nodded sternly. "We have to go look for him," I uttered, a dry feeling in my throat.

We decided it would be best to split up. While I began by looking in the candy section, Mitchell stayed in the ghosttown. We promised we would call the other over the phone as soon as we would find any trace of our missing friend.

It was eerie walking through the candyland all by myself. I remember wishing I had the sock puppet by my side. Even though I had my whip with me, I couldn't help but feel vulnerable on my own. The thought

of Darius lying around somewhere, possibly severely wounded or even worse, made my stomach churn.

I passed the little stage where the Sugar Plum Fairy was raptly dancing as always. I spotted the Mime perched on top of the light fixture over her head like a spider resting in its web. I felt a shiver run down my spine as I was instantly reminded of that one morning I had chased him through the park. Thankfully, neither of them appeared to notice me walking by. Or maybe they were simply minding their own business, who knows with these two.

I didn't dare to break the silence hanging over me by calling Darius's name. The twenty minutes that I spent combing through every corner of the candy section may have just been some of the tensest of my entire life. By the time I had worked my way forward to Twin Vale Point, I felt like I was ready to explode, therefore I don't blame myself for jumping at the sudden sound of hooves hitting the sandy street.

I spun around to find that the Stagecoach had rolled up behind me. Nathan, who was sitting atop the coach seat as always, was staring over at me with a calculative look on his face. I held his gaze for what felt like an eternity before he finally raised his hand and waved me over.

Either I was creeped out by Nathan's silent attitude or my already anxious mind was running wild with me, but I caught myself inconspicuously checking the roof of the carriage in hopes of spotting the Laughing Cowboy. Ever since I started thinking about how much he had actually been helping me in the past, I have begun to feel a lot safer around him. But he was nowhere to be found.

It was just Nathan and me with no one else in sight. I swallowed my unease and approached the coachman. As I got closer, I couldn't help but wrinkle my nose at the stench that old blanket wrapped around his shoulders was emanating. It smelt like horse, but somehow even stronger than an actual horse, if that makes sense.

"Hi," I stammered, "have you..."

I was interrupted by Nathan leaning over to me. “If it’s your friend you’re looking for, I saw him enter one of the funhouses last night. The one that looks like an abandoned hospital,” he told me in a low, husky voice.

With that, he straightened up in his seat again and on his command, the horses began trotting off. I didn’t even have the time to thank him.

Heeding his advice, I began running all the way back to the horror section, fumbling for my cell phone in the process. I called Mitchell, who was thankfully not too far away, and told him to meet me in front of the funhouse Nathan had told me to go to.

We arrived there at the same time, both of us panting heavily. As soon as we had caught our breath, we headed inside.

The Haunted Hospital concept is a bit overused in my opinion, but it’s still good for a scare if pulled off correctly. While I don’t know who designed this funhouse in the theme park I work at, they did a really good job. The entrance to the hospital looks like an actual sliding glass door had been broken down. The building itself is not that big as there are only four main rooms.

The first room looks like a reception area. There’s even a large desk with an old, broken computer on it and a puppet that looks like a rotten corpse is sitting on a swivel chair right behind it. The second one is just a long, empty hallway with an old wheelchair standing around in it. Usually, the Nurse will be sitting in there or just standing in the middle of the room, forcing the visitors to squeeze past her.

The third room is where Darius would normally be. It holds a hospital stretcher with another corpse prop on it and there are fake severed limbs hanging on meat hooks from the ceiling. It may sound lame the way I describe it, but it looks pretty freaky with flashing lights. The last room is basically just the exit, but it also holds some skeleton animatronics that can pop out of the walls to either side.

Since none of the attractions including the funhouse are currently being

powered, Mitchell and I had no special effects to scare us. That however didn't help the fact that we were both on the brink of wetting our pants.

"Darius?" I called out, my voice trembling ever so slightly.

Both Mitchell and I jumped when we heard a low groan come from somewhere closeby. We ran forward into the long hallway to find our co-worker slouching in the ragged wheelchair. Upon seeing us barge in, he arduously lifted his head.

"Oh my god," I whispered before rushing to his side. "What happened?"

Mitchell joined me and together, we heaved Darius up from the wheelchair. It took us some time to carry him out of the funhouse and into the breakroom where we sat him down on one of the benches. By then he had fully regained conciousness and was sobbing quietly while thanking us profusely at the same time.

"We need to get you to a hospital," I told him, fumbling for my car keys. "Yes, I noticed the irony in that," I added upon feeling Mitchell's eyes on me.

"Wait... no..." Darius coughed and leaned forward, holding out his hand to stop me. "I'll be fine. It was mostly shock, really."

"Are you sure, man?" Mitchell asked, looking down at him worriedly.

"Yeah, it's alright," he muttered weakly.

"...fine." I sat down on the breakroom table, facing Darius. "What happened back there?"

Darius straightened up and cleared his throat. "I came in yesterday night to check up on the nurse. I figured she might... I don't know. She never needs anything, but I just wanted to make sure everything was alright over here. I couldn't find her immediately so I went into the funhouse since she hangs out in there most of the time. I found her standing in

the hallway facing the wall, right next to the wheelchair.

I think I wanted to take her outside. I don't know why anymore, maybe just for some fresh air. Can't hurt, right? So I go up to her and I place my hands on her shoulders as always. And then all of a sudden... she spins around, and she grabs me and pushes me into that wheelchair and then..." his voice trailed off as his face contorted in disgust.

"...and then she just takes her hand and shoves it down my throat. She was holding something, I think. Something small and cold, and I don't know what it was, but she pulls her hand back out so I swallow it." He retched slightly at the memory. "Everything went dark after that. I guess I passed out due to the shock... that's happened to me before."

He let out a long sigh. "I can't believe it. I've been assigned to the nurse for five years. She's never shown any signs of... well, sentience before. And now, all of a sudden, this outburst. I don't get it. What in the world is going on with her?"

"And other than that, you're okay?" I asked softly. "Does it hurt anywhere?"

Darius shook his head. "No. It was just the shock, I'm sure of it. How long was I out for?"

"Well, right now it's two forty pm," Mitchell stated, glancing at his watch.

"Yeah, we found your phone and all. I think your parents are really worried. Better call them, tell them you had an accident," I suggested, handing Darius his backpack. "But still, you should go see a doctor. Who knows what that thing was she had you swallow."

Darius nodded slowly. "Yeah, okay. Fine."

"Come on," Mitchell grunted, pulling him to his feet. "I'll drive you."

"Thanks, uh... one more thing though. Where's the nurse at right now?"

Mitchell and I exchanged worried glances. Neither of us had encountered her while looking for Darius. Finally, I bit my lip and said, "You two go see a doctor. I'll stay and look for the nurse."

I ushered them out the door and watched as Mitchell guided Darius, who was still a bit wobbly on his feet, to the employee entrance before I set out on my search. I didn't really know where to look or what I'd do if I'd find her. I decided to take Mr Scratch with me this time. I did not want to wander the park on my own again.

I went to the Hollywood section first. There I met Caroline, who was thankfully coming in like clockwork as always. I waited for her to ask the Pianist her question and afterwards told her about what had happened to Darius. She was understandably unsettled and joined me in looking for the pretender.

I think Mr Scratch spotted her first, seeing as his low growl alerted the two of us before we even laid eyes on her. She was sitting on a bench in front of an ice cream parlor, unmoving and voidly staring down at her feet. Caroline and I contemplated on what to do. Finally, I came to the conclusion that we would lock her up in the sock puppet's cage and have him sleep in the breakroom instead.

The nurse put up no resistance. I approached her from behind and placed my hands under her arms to lift her up. Then Caroline and I each grabbed one of her arms so we would have more control over her in case she would suddenly go rampant again and proceeded to walk her all the way over to the horror section. She was still staring past us absently as we locked her in.

We then took a seat on a bench nearby from where we had a good view on the cage. We spent about half an hour talking and petting the sock puppet before I got a call from Mitchell. I was surprised at the happiness and apparent relief in his voice as he greeted me. I told him Caroline and I had caught the nurse and then inquired about Darius's state.

Mitchell chuckled awkwardly. "Yeah... about that. The doctor says he's

fine. His throat seems to be okay too. We didn't tell him the truth about what happened, obviously, but we didn't have to make up an excuse either. You see, while we were waiting for him to be examined, Darius had to go to the toilet real quick... turns out the thing the Nurse shoved down his throat was a key."

"A key?" I repeated incredulously.

"Yeah, after a couple hours it just came back out the natural way, I guess."

"That's wild," I muttered. "We need to find out how she's gotten her hands on it. I mean, what is she even doing with a key?"

"And what it unlocks," Caroline added from beside me.

"How about we all meet up here tomorrow and figure this out together? There are a couple things I've been wanting to try and need help with anyways," I suggested.

Caroline nodded eagerly and Mitchell agreed. I reminded him to tell Darius and to bring the mystery key. Caroline immediately called Oliver and I informed Anne and Maxine. We'll all meet up at the large saloon in Twin Vale Point tomorrow at four in the afternoon.
I don't know what we will be able to find out, if we will find out anything at all, but I do believe this will be interesting. Plus, this is my chance to get some answers out of the other not-actors. I know the cowboy can't talk, but, as a lot of commentors have pointed out, he might be able to write or tell us something the visual way.

As for the Aged Diva, I believe that maybe her handler Oliver can get through to her. The two seem to have somewhat of a connection, so it's at least worth a try. I don't think the Pianist will be too helpful, but Caroline says asking some more questions for once probably won't hurt. I must admit I'm excited. We just might be getting some answers after all.

today was a huge letdown

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. I already mentioned that my co-workers and I were going to meet up today in my last post and that's what we did. And boy, was it a day.

When I arrived at the saloon in Twin Vale Point at four in the afternoon just like we had discussed, the other actors were already sat at the large round table in the middle of the room, talking excitedly.

"Fashionably late to her own party," Mitchell commented, raising the bottle of light beer he was holding to me.

I grinned. "More like Darius's party though, isn't it? Did you bring the key?" I asked, sinking onto the cushioned chair flanked by Anne and Maxine.

Darius nodded and reached into his pocket to produce a small, shiny steel key. I reached my hand out to take it, but stopped seconds before my fingers could come into contact with it. "You, uh... you did clean it properly, right?"

Darius flushed, rolled his eyes and nodded.

"Okay, I'll trust you on this," I said, taking the key from his hands. It didn't look special in any way. Had I not known about the adventurous journey this nondescript little object had taken through my co-workers digestive system the day prior, I would have never suspected there to be anything off about it.

I had the others take a look at it, but none of them seemed to recognize it. I then placed it in the middle of the table and we just stared at it quizzically for a few seconds until Oliver broke the pensive silence.

"So, let me get this straight. You want to find out where the not-actors are from and what they are and you're saying that this mystery key is going to help with that."

“I’m saying it might,” I argued. “The Nurse has never acted up before. Everyone, including Darius, thought she was mentally completely incapable. And now all of a sudden, she not only gets her hands on a key, but she also musters up enough vitality and strength to shove it down her handler’s throat.”

I could hear Darius gag slightly at the mention. “On top of that, I recently had a very interesting encounter with Dale. He was circling the park holding a notebook while quietly chanting to himself. I managed to get a glimpse of his writings. While I did not have much time to study the book, there was one phrase that kept reappearing and it really stood out to me. We who now claim ownership of this land are aware of and willing to pay the price,” I recited.

Oliver frowned. “This is all really intriguing, but are you guys sure we want to know what this is about? It’s always been obvious that something’s seriously messed up here, but maybe we should just let it go? I think all of us have tried on some occasions to find out about this place, and none of us ever succeeded. Maybe it’s better this way. I mean, what if we don’t like what we find?”

Anne leaned forward in her chair, a stern look on her face. “Don’t you get it? That’s exactly why we need to know more. Dale’s acting shady as fuck and if he’s up to something freaky, maybe we’re part of his plan. Whatever is going on here directly involves every single one of us.”

“She’s right,” Maxine chimed in. “Also, we don’t know if the other not-actors are gonna act up as well. I don’t know about you guys, but when the big fluffy one goes berserk, I do not want to be anywhere near him. Now that we actually have the chance to find out more, no way we’re gonna pass it up.”

I nodded grimly. “Then it’s settled. Okay, so here’s the deal. Mitchell, Oliver and Caroline, I need the three of you to help me out with your pretenders. The Aged Diva and the Pianist can talk and might be able to tell us some interesting things if we get through to them. Of course, I don’t know how to approach this exactly, but we’ll figure it out. The

cowboy might not be able to talk, but he'll try to help. Maybe he can tell us the visual way. I brought a pen and some paper."

"You sure he'll try to help?" Mitchell asked quizzically.

"Of course. He's helping us out all the time," I responded, a bit taken aback.

"I'm not sure what you're talking about, but... if you say so."

I shrugged. "As I was saying, the four of us will try and talk to the not-actors. And yes, we will totally feel like morons but that doesn't matter right now. Maxine, Anne and Darius, you will try and find whatever lock fits this key. Once we know that, we'll probably know how the Nurse came into possession of it in the first place as well. Just try every single door in this park until you've got the right one. Start with Dale's office though. Maybe we're lucky."

"Shouldn't someone keep an eye out for Dale himself though?" Darius spoke up. "I mean, you said he was wandering around the edge of the park. Maybe he's doing that right now as well?"

Maxine raised her hand. "Then how about I go look for him and you guys try and find the matching lock?"

"Good idea," I replied. "Have some of you got your walkie-talkies with you by any chance?" I looked around to see a affirmative nods from Anne, Maxine and Mitchell.

"Alright. It'll be easier staying in touch this way. As soon as anyone has found anything that could be of importance, they have to radio us. Especially you, Maxine. If you find Dale anywhere, follow him and keep us updated about his position. We need to avoid running into him. I don't think we'd get into trouble, but who knows. Better he stays unaware of what we're doing here," I explained.

After we had checked our portable radios, we each got up and left in our

small groups. Maxine went straight for the outer edge of the park while Darius and Anne headed for Dale's office. Mitchell, Oliver, Caroline and I figured it would be best to go for the Hollywood section first, mainly since we were not expecting the not-actors there to be too helpful.

Our first stop was the Pianist's restaurant. Mitchell, Oliver and I waited by the door, watching as Caroline walked inside and greeted the man in the white tuxedo. He was sitting on his piano stool as usual, his fingers dancing over the black and white keys. I admit his music is very relaxing to listen to. If it weren't for him being a lethal threat, I would maybe even be able to enjoy it.

"Good afternoon," Caroline said upon halting beside him. He didn't look up. Caroline glanced over at us and I shrugged, to which she grimaced and turned back to the Pianist. "Could you maybe... tell us something about yourself?"

No reaction. The man simply kept playing, not paying attention to the woman next to him. Caroline frowned, chewing on her lower lip. "Can you hear me?" she inquired.

She waited for about ten seconds before letting out a sigh. "I'm sorry to have bothered you," she told him, then turned around and walked back over to us.

"Well, that was disappointing," Mitchell remarked.

"But not surprising either," Caroline added. "I told you, he's never said a word other than when he's thanking people, really."

"It was worth a try nonetheless," I replied, and addressing Oliver added, "Now where's that screen goddess of yours?"

It took us a while to find her. She was sitting in an ice cream parlor a little further away from the main plaza. Maybe it was due to there being no visitors around, but she looked a bit sad. We let Oliver do the talking. The aged woman seemed quite elated to see him. It was just like

I thought, they appeared to get along very well.

"Can you tell us about Hollywood?" Oliver began once they had exchanged pleasantries.

The Diva smiled. "I don't understand."

"Was there a time before this? Have you always been here?"

"Why yes, dear. I thought you knew."

"And... are you happy here?" Oliver asked, a hint of insecurity in his voice.

"Of course I am, sweetheart. As happy as a girl can be."

It was when she said this that I noticed a certain twitch of her eye. Like someone blinking away a tear. Assuming it to have been my imagination but not wanting to take any chances, I quietly asked Oliver to repeat the question. A bit confused, he followed my whispered order and once more asked, "Are you happy here?"

"Of course I am, sweetheart. As happy as a girl can be."

There it was again. A twitch of her left lower lid. This time, I was certain. I'm not sure what had gotten into me, but I just suddenly had an idea. I shrugged my backpack off my shoulders and hurriedly pulled out a marker and a piece of paper, both of which I handed to Oliver.

"Tell her to write that down for us," I told him under my breath.

Oliver slid the marker and paper across the table. "Would you mind... writing down what you just said?" he asked politely.

The Aged Diva stared at the paper, then back up at him. Firmly holding her handler's gaze, her one hand that wasn't holding the long, slender cigarette reached for the marker. It was like her hand moved on its

own accord as she began scribbling down letters. Oliver had to hold the paper in place so as to keep it from sliding off the table under the marker's forceful pressure.

When she was done, she let go of the marker and stared up at us with wide, blank eyes. None of us said a word, so when the skin of her face slowly began to droop, the four of us were equally startled. Mitchell, who apparently had not had the pleasure of watching her dematerialize very often before, covered his mouth with his palm to keep himself from retching.

Once the older woman had disappeared, Oliver, who still looked a bit shaken, reached out to take the piece of paper. I frowned. I don't know what I was expecting, but it was certainly not that. There was just a single word, but it was written over and over again. Laurel.

The Aged Diva had scribbled it down several times, her handwriting sloppy and barely legible. Caroline was the first one to break the silence.

"What does it mean?"

"I don't... I don't know..." I muttered. "I don't even know why I came up with this in the first place. I just wanted to see if she could write, I guess."

After a short pause, I added, "You think Laurel might be her name?"

"The not-actors don't have names though," Caroline argued.

I felt a lump form in my throat. "Maybe they used to," I muttered.

"I don't understand!" Oliver breathed. He sounded shocked, and quite understandably so. "She shouldn't have exploded, none of us even said a word. This is... a bit unsettling, to be honest."

"We'd best leave her alone for today. Let's just go for the cowboy next. Maybe he's gonna be a bit more informative," Mitchell suggested.

We set out for Twin Vale Point. About two minutes into our walk, Mitchell's walkie-talkie came crackling to life.

"Hey guys, Anne here," the familiar voice of my friend came from the speaker. "Darius and I have tried the door to Dale's office several times now, no luck. We also tried the restrooms, the ticket booths and... well, basically every other door we came across."

"But the key has to fit somewhere, right?" I thought out loud. "Maybe it's for something inside of Dale's office then."

"Okay, but how do we get in there?" Anne asked.

"Probably not at all," I replied. "Also, I might be wrong. Just try some more doors if you can find any and if not, come back to the saloon."

Caroline leaned over to speak into Mitchell's portable radio. "Any news from Maxine's side?"

A faint buzzing of static followed before Maxine's voice came on. "No Dale. Have been looking around for quite a while now, no trace of him."

"That's a good thing, I guess," Oliver remarked and I nodded.

"Don't stop though," I told her. "He might still be around here somewhere."

Our little group soon reached the entrance to Twin Vale Point. We didn't have to look long for the cowboy. In fact, shortly after we had entered the wild west part of the park, an empty plastic water bottle came flying towards us seemingly out of nowhere and hit Mitchell on the head. He cursed and upon turning into the direction the bottle had been thrown from, we spotted his pretender sitting on the porch of one of the closed giftshops.

"That hurt, you asshole!" Mitchell shouted. "Where'd you even find that thing?"

Letting out a cheerful cackle, the cowboy casually pointed at a nearby trashcan.

Mitchell groaned. “Normally I’d kick your ass for that, but I actually kinda need your help right now.”

The cowboy began to wheeze with laughter as he raised his hand and flipped him off.

Mitchell turned to look at me. “See? What’d I tell you? Help us my ass!”

I shook my head and stepped in front of my colleague. Adressing the not-actor, I called out, “By that he means we all need your help. Can we ask you a few questions? Please?”

To my surprise, he didn’t hesitate. He got up and walked up to us. I smiled. Mitchell let out a low growl not unlike that of Mr Scratch. “You have got to be kidding me.”

We took the pretender over to another, smaller saloon-style bar where we sat down on the porch. I pulled out pen and paper once again and slid them over to the cowboy. He stared down at them blankly, then looked back up at us.

I cleared my throat. “You can’t write, can you?”

He looked a little embarassed, slowly shaking his head. Suddenly he perked up, as if he had remembered something. He grabbed the marker and slowly, concentratedly began writing something. It took him about half a minute, and when he was done, he held it up for us to see.

I instantly felt reminded of the Diva. Again, it was just a single word, and again, it was a name. Except this time, it was my name.

Leah.

I don’t think I’ve told you yet, but my name is Leah. The cowboy was

smiling proudly and I wasn't quite sure of what to say, so I decided it would be best to smile back and ask some more questions, ignoring the quizzical stares of my co-workers.

"Are you happy here? In Twin Vale Point, I mean."

He nodded eagerly.

"Uh... is there anything you want us to know?" I inquired. Pretty straightforward, I know.

The cowboy looked confused. He seemed to think for a while, then shook his head.

"Okay. What about Dale? For how long have you known him?"

No reaction. I offered him the marker again, but he didn't seem to want to write down anything either.

"Is he to be trusted?" Caroline chimed in.

The cowboy didn't look at her. Instead, he slowly cast his eyes to the ground below him. We tried asking him some more random questions, but he replied to none of them. We were quickly running out of ideas. Suddenly, a thought crossed my mind. There was one more thing I could ask.

"Why don't you ever speak?"

The pretender's head jerked up and he stared at me with wide eyes. He then slowly rose from his seat and pushed past us. We watched in silent bewilderment as he walked off.

"Shouldn't we stop him?" Mitchell asked.

I shook my head. I suddenly felt extremely guilty. I still wish I hadn't asked him that. Something about that question must have hit a nerve

with him. I don't know if it's even possible to hurt a not-actor's feelings, but somehow I feel like I did just that.

The four of us stood on the bar's porch a little while longer before returning to the saloon. Darius and Anne were already waiting for us and it appeared that Maxine had given up her search and returned as well. We told them about everything that had happened and had to admit that we were none the wiser.

On the plus side, I came up with the idea of contacting the former handler of Mr Scratch and asked Darius about him. He seems to remember him pretty well. He gave me his number and I called him this evening. His name is Joshua and he says that he would gladly receive me to talk about his time at his former job. So while our little investigation today brought up nothing but further questions, I might come back tomorrow with an interesting story about how my predecessor lost his legs.

I admit I'm rather disappointed right now though. But I'm not giving up just yet.

Mr. Scratch

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. In my last post, I mentioned I was going to meet up with Joshua, Mr Scratch's former handler, and that's what I did. We had agreed to meet at twelve pm at his place.

Now, I'm not a shy person. I used to be, but that is a past long behind me. Even though I consider myself rather brave, I admit my fingers were shaking a little when I pressed them down on Joshua's doorbell. About ten seconds later, a lady in what looked to be her late thirties opened the door. She eyed me up and down before sighing deeply and pushing the door wide open, motioning for me to come in.

"You must be from that wretched park," she grunted. "Come on in. Joshua's waiting for you in the living room."

I offered her a polite smile as I stepped inside, which she promptly ignored. She pointed at a doorway ahead and I walked past her into the living room of the small cottage-style home. While it did look rather cozy, I noticed a general sickliness hanging over the interior. Every single piece of furniture somehow managed to look worn and tired in its own special way. The place reminded me a lot of what I would feel like entering my grandparents' home as a kid. It felt like a place that would belong to an elderly person, not to a couple in their thirties.

Next to the couch in front of the TV which was humming away at a low volume was a man sitting in a wheelchair. Upon noticing me, he waved me over, flashing me a wide, warm smile.

"Well, hello there!" he exclaimed cheerfully. "Won't you look at that. And here I was, thinking I'd never see any of the doomed souls slaving away in that park again."

He said this in a happy, joking voice, but in light of the recent events I could not help but shudder a bit.

"Joshua, I assume?" I said, offering him my hand.

He grabbed it firmly and gave it a fierce shake which I admit I didn't really expect from his rather gentle appearance. Then again, this man used to be the monster tamer for years before me, so I guess it's just natural that he has a lot of leftover strength.

"Exactly, young lady! You know, I don't think the park has had a female monster tamer before..." he thought out loud, his voice trailing off pensively. "Oh well. Guess there's a first time for everything. And judging by that handshake of yours, you're probably doing just fine!" He chuckled and reached up to pat me on the shoulder. "Please, take a seat. Right here."

He pointed to the edge of the couch next to his wheelchair and I sat down, instantly sinking about ten inches deeper as the old, weary cushion gave in underneath me.

"So," Joshua took a deep breath as he leaned forward. "What can I do for you?"

My eyes traveled down his body to the two stumps left of his legs. One was a bit longer than the other, but both ended just above where the knee would have been. The former tamer must have noticed it, since he grinned and said, "Ah. I shoulda known."

I turned my head, mumbling an apology for staring so impolitely.

"I don't mind! Stare at them all you want."

"So, I have been trying to find out about the not-actors' origins. My co-workers and I have been doing quite a lot of research." I found myself unsure of how to describe how I felt about his missing legs. "It's hard to believe Mr Scratch did this," I finally muttered.

Joshua nodded. "I know, right? He had always been so friendly. He really does grow on one, doesn't he? By the way, excuse my wife's icy demeanor, but to her, everything that has to do with the park is evil. Took me long enough to convince her to let you come over. To her, the

park is where her husband lost his legs and nothing else."

"And to you?" I asked. "What is the park to you?"

He smiled. "It's where I spent eight years of my life working. I am still fond of it, in a way. And admittedly, I miss Mr Scratch. Even though he ate, like, thirty percent of my body. I don't hold any grudges. I don't think he knew what he was doing."

"So?" I inquired, curiously leaning over to him. "How did it happen?"

Joshua grinned broadly. "Sit back, girly, for you're about to hear a most tragic tale," he told me in a dramatic voice, making me giggle a bit.

"It was a day like any other. I came in early to feed Mr Scratch and, you know, play with him a little. I remember meeting Dale on the way and talking to him. I've known Dale for a long time. I even knew the manager before him. That was his dad, by the way. Two years into me working there, his old man retired and Dale filled his position. The two of them were really alike back then already, but if you ask me, Dale's even surlier than him.

Anyways, I come in, let the big guy out of his cage and all goes according to plan. Then the visitors start flooding the park, and from then on, everything goes wrong all of a sudden. I don't know why, but that day there were just some real jerks among them. Some of the kids began to hop around Mr Scratch and they were kind of pulling on his fur and shouting like crazy. I tried to scare them off a little, but they stuck around.

Visitors aren't allowed to touch us and it was already like that back then, but those children apparently didn't care and neither did their parents. Sure, they were kids and the visitors all think Mr Scratch is just some guy in a costume, so I guess they didn't mean any harm. But I noticed he was getting uncomfortable. He was trembling a little and just had this nervous vibe to him. Still I obviously couldn't drop the front, so I tried to get away from them as far as possible, but well, no luck.

When those brats finally got a move on, Scratchy was so nervous and jumpy I thought I'd better take him back to his shelter where it's a bit quieter. So he could relax, you know. Thankfully there were no visitors around the funhouse next to Scratch's cage then. There were renovations going on there so that part of the section was closed off completely. There were these view blockers where it was fenced off, so nobody saw what happened to me."

Joshua's smile had slowly faded. He swallowed audibly. "I led him behind the view blockers. It was completely deserted. Once behind the fencing, I let him off his leash. And that's where I made my mistake. I accidentally dropped it and had to step forward to pick it up. I was a bit tired myself, so I must have overlooked that Scratch has suddenly placed his paw in my way. Next thing I know, he lets out a howl of pain and I realized that I was standing on it.

Tense and nervous as he was, this must have been what gave him the rest. He lost it. It's all a blur, I was completely overwhelmed when it happened. I feel his teeth in my leg and he... he flings me up into the air but I don't fall back down. He's caught me by my other leg and I feel his fangs sink deeper and deeper into my flesh. And then there's this crunching sound and... the pain is blinding, but it was only for a few seconds. Then I lost consciousness.

I came to in the hospital. My wife was there... and so was Dale. I remember my wife yelling at him with tears in her eyes. He'd lied to the medical staff. Told them I had had an accident at the renovation site, probably had given them some money too. At least I believe he did. No one ever asked any questions. My wife later said she wanted to try and file a lawsuit or something, but I told her to leave the park alone. It would be no use anyways. The park never has to face legal issues. It's always been like that."

I had listened intently. "I'm very sorry for... that. All of that. I hope you're doing alright."

Joshua smiled softly. "Always have been. Of course, it wasn't easy at first.

It still isn't. I don't know, I'm just glad to be alive, you know. It could have been much worse."

While he had seemed cheerful at first, he was now looking rather sad and I instantly felt bad for making him retell his experience. Maybe he hadn't wanted to after all. I decided to drop it.

"You said something interesting earlier. That Dale took over his father's job. I didn't know that. Is the whole park family-run by any chance?"

Joshua let out a laugh. "You bet. If Dale ever mentions upper management, he's talking about his aunts, uncles, grandparents... all of that."

"You're kidding," I replied, eyes wide. "How do you know?"

"I did some research back then. I was curious, just like you. You know, I think Dale never mentions it because him and his folks don't want us to know that the park is a family matter. I mean, usually that's just something people know about their workplace, right?"

"Definitely. But why do you think does he keep it a secret?"

Joshua frowned. "My bet is that it has something to do with the monsters. But I guess that's nothing new. It all has to do with the monsters in some way." He grew silent and the look in his eyes became contemplative. "I stopped caring when I lost my job there. I'll never return anyways, so why bother."

"Is there anything else I should know? Anything important you can tell me?"

Joshua lifted his head and looked me in the eyes. "Just one thing. I want you to be careful. While I think it's great someone actually seems to be making progress with their investigations of the park for once, Lord knows many have failed, we can't say for sure where this will go. Stick to the facts and only to the facts. Proceed with an open mind. Don't be too suspicious of someone who might seem like bad news. You never know

when they might save your ass."

I took a deep breath. "I think Dale might be turning people into pretenders," I blurted out.

The man next to me regarded me with silent interest.

I swallowed and went on, "My co-workers and I talked to some of the not-actors... like, we tried and we have reason to believe that they might have been... you know, normal people at some point. Okay, considering what you said earlier, it would probably be Dale's whole family who turns them and not only him, but do you think that could be where they come from?"

"That's quite an accusation. Do you really think Dale's family would have a reason to do such a thing?" Joshua asked sternly.

"Maybe it's about money," I argued.

"The people don't visit the park to see the pretenders though. Sure, having actors and all makes it more unique and fun, but I doubt they are the main source of its income."

He had a point. "Well, it doesn't have to be about money. Maybe it's for some other reason we don't know yet. Did you know someone from the park by the name of Laurel by any chance?" I asked him to which Joshua frowned and shook his head no.

"Alright. I guess that's all then. Thank you for your help. I'm sure you weren't too keen on talking to me."

Joshua's friendly smile suddenly returned. "Don't be silly! I really wanted to meet the new tamer. Tell Darius I said hi."

On my way home, I took some time to think about what he had said. I remembered my first days on the job. How it all just weirded me out so much. At first, I could hardly believe any of the things I was so suddenly

confronted with were actually happening. From one second to the next, I was standing in this strange, surreal land of candy, glamour, sand and spook, holding a leash attached to something I had never thought I would encounter outside of the realm of my nightmares.

I don't know when exactly I got used to it. Maybe it began when I met my colleagues and befriended them. Or when I started to think of Mr Scratch like a pet. Anyways, at some point I must have stopped feeling scared of it all. I wondered if it had been the same with Joshua when he had first started to work at the park.

Of course I still went in to work later on. My conversation with the former tamer had put me into a bit of a melancholy and I was feeling quite tired, but someone has to feed to fluffy monster. Plus, I had made a mental note to try and talk to Nathan. I think he knows more than he's letting on.

When I arrived at the park, it somehow felt even more empty and deserted than usual. I slid in through the employee entrance as always and made my way over to the breakroom where the sock puppet is currently lodging. The Undead Nurse is still locked in Mr Scratch's cage.

I already told Darius that this is no permanent solution and that he at some point will have to let her out again, but he was understandably reluctant to do so. I think he's still a bit shaken from the incident with the key. I have therefore allowed him to use the cage for one more day, meaning that he will have to set her free again tomorrow. I promised him I would be there with him so I would be able to help him in case she would lash out at him again. I have a feeling it's going to be fun.

After feeding and petting him a little, I decided to go look for the Stagecoach. To my surprise, the sock puppet seemed to set aside his laziness for me seeing as he followed me to the wild west section. Fortunately, Nathan was just steering the carriage past the entrance to Twin Vale Point when we arrived. I hurried to run after him.

"Wait!" I called out. "Nathan!"

The drumming of hooves on the ground came to a stop. When I caught up with the Stagecoach, I noticed a familiar figure perched atop its roof. Not sure who to address first, I motioned for Nathan to give me a moment. The cowboy was staring down at me with a void look in his eyes. He looked thoughtful. I remember thinking I had never seen him like this before.

I blinked up at him, using my hand to shield my eyes from the light of the setting sun. He wasn't smiling or showing his teeth and for once, there was no black saliva dripping from the corners of his mouth. If I squinted, I could almost ignore the large deformity in his upper lip. For a moment, a very short moment, he looked almost like a completely ordinary person.

"Hey," I said, not sure how else to greet him.

He didn't react, merely continued to stare at me blankly.

"About yesterday, I didn't mean to upset you. I don't know what it was exactly that got you so angry or sad or whatever, but it really wasn't my intention." Swallowing my apprehension, I cleared my throat and asked: "Are we good?"

He seemed to think for a few seconds before he bit his lip and nodded.

"Good," I muttered. "That's... that's a relief."

His lips curled ever so slightly and I let go of a breath I didn't know I was holding. Walking up to Nathan, I greeted him politely. The stench of his blanket hit me instantly and I tried not to wrinkle my nose at it.

"I was wondering if I could ask you some questions," I explained.

Nathan looked at me, then over at Mr Scratch who was standing by my side. "Try it," he said in that low, husky voice of his. "See if I answer."
"Okay..." I bit my lip, thinking for a little while. "What do you know about the park?"

“That’s a very vague question,” Nathan replied. “I know a whole lot of things about the park. But I don’t think they’ll be of any use to you.” He almost sounded like he was mocking me. He glanced up at the roof of the carriage above him where the cowboy was still sitting, watching us attentively. “Maybe I don’t even want to talk to you.”

“But...” my voice trailed off as he motioned for me to back off.

“If I were you, I’d get away from the Stagecoach now. The sun’s about to set.”

A thin smile I had never seen on him before began to spread on his lips and he clicked his tongue. “GIDDY UP!” he called out, cracking the reins. The horses neighed loudly before dashing off. The Laughing Cowboy held onto the edge of the roof, starting to chuckle joyously as the carriage set into motion. I was left alone with the sock puppet, staring after them.

Later at home, I did as some of you advised me in the comments and attempted to research the name the Diva had given us, Laurel. In short, my search yielded no valuable results. There are no missing person cases from anyone by that name in this area or anything like that, or at least I couldn’t find any.

All in all, while Dale is still very, very suspicious in my opinion, I want to heed Joshua’s advice and proceed with an open mind. After all, I haven’t forgotten about the key yet either and who knows where that will lead us. I guess it’s best to be ready for just about anything right now.

firewater

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. Some of the suggestions on yesterday's post really piqued my interest. This is why I decided to take your advice to heart and try out a couple things.

I live in a small apartment located in a larger residence right by a very busy street. The lady who I live door to door with is a friendly older woman with an avid passion for gardening. She keeps a ton of potted plants on her balcony and all throughout her home. I've been over at her place a few times to chat and have lunch together, so I knew she would gladly help me out.

She sure was surprised to have me knock on her door in the early morning hours and ask if she had any laurel plants. Still, she scurried off into her living room and returned with a greenery sprouting twig which she handed to me with a friendly smile. I thanked her and told her I would explain my strange request someday when I would find the time.

Before I got on my way to the park, I took out my cell phone and dialed my manager's number. He had given it out to us for emergencies only, but I guess under the given circumstances, I could allow myself a tiny bit of misconduct. Dale picked up almost instantly.

"What happened?" he asked straight away, his tone surly and annoyed.

"Nothing, listen... Dale, we need to talk."

"We do, do we?" he muttered after a long sigh. "About what?" he then asked.

"I have some questions... about the pretenders. There are just some things I need to know, I have to..." my voice trailed off. "Please," I added sternly.

"Don't tell me you've been running around behind my back playing detective or some crap," he responded in a low, slightly menacing tone.
"No. Of course not," I stammered, trying to sound confident.

“Who do you think I think I am?”

“...what?” Dale sounded a bit confused, but caught himself rather quickly. “Leah, how many times do I have to tell you not to interfere with other people’s business?” he hissed, but I could sense a hint of desperation in his disgruntled voice. “Why can’t you just do your job and let me do mine?”

“I don’t want to interfere with your job in any way. It’s just that I’ve been feeling sort of creeped out lately. It all came crashing down on me one day recently that I don’t actually know where the pretenders come from. And what they are. Like, reality check, you know? I only want to know a few things so that I can feel safe working here again,” I explained, hoping I had sounded emotional enough for him to believe my excuses.

A long pause followed, so long in fact that I already started wondering if he had hung up on me, before he finally answered: “Okay, fine. I’ll meet you at my office today, four pm, do not be late. That doesn’t mean I’ll tell you what you want to know, but we are going to have a talk. That’s all I can and will do for you. Will you leave me alone from then on?”

“Sure,” I lied, fiddling excitedly with the laurel twig.

“Why do I have a feeling you won’t?” Dale pondered before giving one final sigh and adding, “four in the afternoon, my office. See you there.” With that, he ended the call.

When I arrived at the park, Darius was waiting for me by the employee entrance.

“Hi there,” he greeted me sleepily before letting out a yawn and, nodding at the twig in my hand, adding, “What’s that about?”

“It’s laurel,” I said curtly.
“Oh! Like, because of the Diva?”

I nodded and the two of us stepped inside, heading for Mr Scratch’s

repurposed cage. The Nurse was standing inside as if she had not moved at all during our absence. She was staring blankly into the distance as we approached. I placed the laurel twig on the ground before pulling the key to the cage out of my pocket, only to halt mid-motion.

"Hey, let's show her the key, see if she reacts in any way."

"Okay, sure," Darius replied, fumbling for the small object before producing it from within his jacket and holding it out for the Nurse to see. The not-actor continued to voidly gaze past us, not paying any attention to the key.

Darius cleared his throat. "Hey, uh... remember how you shoved this down my throat?" he asked more jokingly than serious and I rolled my eyes. Finally, he put away the key and turned back to me. "You gonna let her out now?"

I nodded affirmatively and stepped forward to unlock the door. The pretender didn't budge. Her eyes were as glazed and empty as always. Darius swallowed audibly as he inched closer to her, reached out and carefully placed his hands on her shoulders. The moment his palms made contact with her body, a low, guttural groan erupted from her throat. He slowly, ever so slowly pulled her out of the shelter.

"Huh," he uttered. "She seems to be all normal again."

Still on high alert, I picked up my laurel twig once again. Darius and I exchanged concerned glances as he stepped back from the pretender. Once we had both calmed down a bit, I went to get the sock puppet. My colleague watched me feed and pet him and when he had settled back down in his shelter, Darius and I took a seat on the bench nearby to talk and watch over the Nurse who was still standing right beside the funhouse where her handler had walked her over to.

I admit we wasted a lot of time chatting and pretending all was well. It was nice not having to worry about the mystery of the park for once, but come three pm, I remembered my appointment with Dale. Time to

get serious.

I told Darius about my exchange with Joshua the previous day and what I had found out. I also informed him of my impending meeting with the manager and then asked him to lend me the Nurse's key which he willingly handed to me.

"I can't believe he'll actually talk to you about the park. Does he know we've been snooping around?" he inquired.

"Of course not. Well, I do think he has a feeling I might have caught on to some of the odd stuff around here. I believe he only sees me as a curious employee though. And I'm certain he doesn't know anything about the key." I gave Darius a reassuring smile. "I'm taking it because it might fit into something inside of his office. I mean, I doubt I'll get the chance to try it, but who knows."

My colleague nodded sternly. "Best of luck then, I guess," he muttered with a frown. "Don't... you know. Don't tell on us. Watch what you say." While this might have sounded like a threat coming from anybody else, Darius' tone was genuinely concerned.

"Don't worry. I will," I assured him before setting out for the Hollywood section. There was one more thing I had to do before meeting with Dale.

I found the Aged Diva sitting on a bench on the main plaza. She was staring up at the sky absentmindedly and almost seemed startled when I sat down beside her. Without saying a word, I pulled out the laurel twig and handed it to her. She took it with her slender, wrinkly fingers and regarded it silently.

"Is this what you wanted to tell us?" I asked softly. She didn't respond. Her sudden quiet attitude reminded me a lot of the Nurse. She looked up at me with a blank expression before her lips began to curl into a wide smile.

"Why hello there, dearie! I didn't see you coming," she said.

“Is this place cursed?” I whispered. “You wrote down the word laurel for us when Oliver and I talked to you yesterday. At first I thought it was your name, but then I found out that laurel, as in bay leaves, can be used to cleanse a place of negativity or to break a curse. Is that what you wanted to tell us? Does the park need cleansing?”

The elderly woman stared at me for a few seconds before suddenly tightening her grip on the delicate, helpless laurel twig and snapping it in half. My jaw dropped as she took both pieces and began breaking them down into smaller and smaller ones, crushing the bright green leaves in the process. She was mumbling something under her breath, her voice steadily growing louder and louder until it rose to a scream.

“That ugly, misshapen brat... that ugly, misshapen brat... that ugly, misshapen brat, *THAT UGLY, MISSHAPEN BRAT!*”

With that, she hurled the tiny pieces of the laurel twig in her hand away from her with all her might. I watched as they flew through the air and hit the ground a small distance ahead of us. The Diva then let out a low gurgle as the corners of her eyes began to droop and her skin started to melt. I didn’t stick around to wait for the explosion.

When I arrived at Dale’s office, I found the door to be open just a crack. I decided to knock anyways.

“Dale? It’s Leah,” I called out. “You said we could talk.”

“Come on in,” my managers voice came from inside.

I nudged open the door and entered the small room. Dale was sitting at his table, or rather slouching. While I had never thought of him as much of a lively person, he somehow managed to look even more under the weather than usual.

Dale is a shorter, slightly overweight guy with greasy, sand blond hair. I have never seen him clean-shaven and there are always dark bags under his brown eyes. He usually wears long-sleeved shirts and cargo pants,

both of which normally way too baggy to be flattering in any way.

“Hello...” he slurred. “Have... have a seat.” He pointed at the chair across from him.

I frowned. “Um... are you drunk?” I inquired. I didn’t really need an answer though seeing as when I approached him and sat down, I spotted the two bottles of whiskey on his desk, one of which had already been emptied halfway.

“A little bit,” he admitted, covering his mouth to suppress a hiccup.

“Should I come back another time? When you’re more... uh... sober, maybe?” I offered.

“No, no, you stay right here. You wanted to... to ask me a couple things, right?” he inquired, seemingly straining himself to appear focused.

“Yes, if you don’t mind.” Still a bit uncertain, I straightened up in my chair and cleared my throat. “But first off, I’d like to know why you’re drunk at four in the afternoon.”

Dale looked up at me with bleak eyes. “Is that really so surprising to you? This is... this is what you truly see me as, isn’t it? I’m the asshole boss who sits in his ivory tower sipping champagne... while you and your friends work your asses off.”

“That’s whiskey you’re having there though,” I remarked.

“What? That was a figure of speech. Well, it doesn’t matter what it is. What matters is that you don’t know shit about me, missy! You think...” his voice trailed off and he frowned, as if he had forgotten what he had been about to say. “You think I’m the bad guy, but you don’t know shit,” he finally added.

It was hard to take him serious. “Look, Dale, I don’t think you’re the bad guy. But you have never given me any reason to trust you. All I want is

to know whether this place..."

"Fuck this place!" Dale interrupted me. "To hell with it! I know you've been going behind my back trying to find out where the pretenders come from! Don't play dumb on me!" he called out. "I'm not some... some..." his voice trailed off and he fumbled for words. "I just don't fall for it! Doesn't work on me."

He leaned over to me across the table, close enough for me to smell the stench of alcohol in his breath. "You know why I don't care though? Because you'll never, ever find out the whole truth."

"So you admit that you're keeping information from your employees," I inferred.

Dale let out a high-pitched laugh. "Oh... oh, you are cute... information..." He lost himself in a fit of giggles. "Seriously though. You think you know something about what's going on here? You don't. You're barely scraping the tip of the iceberg, this thing... this whole thing is way too big for you. No matter how hard you try, you're not gonna get the whole story because I'm the only one who could theoretically tell you and even if I wanted to, I couldn't."

"Care to explain that to me?"

Dale shook his head. "No way. Couldn't care less." His face softened and he once again leaned over to me. "But there's... one thing I'll give you. Just one small truth and that is that I'm not the bad guy here."

I swallowed. "So you're not a threat to me and my co-workers?"

"I am. I definitely am. But I'm your blessing as well." He sunk back into his chair. His gaze had grown bleak again. "God, my life sucks..." he slurred.

I suddenly remembered the key in my pocket. I quickly glanced over at the file cabinet leaning against Dale's office wall. While I feel guilty

about what I did next, I cannot honestly claim that I regret it. I figured if I could get him to drink some more, just a little more, I might get the one singular chance to try and get into it.

Fortune seemed to be on my side this time. My manager turned to me again and asked, "You want some?" He pointed at his whiskey. "I heard they call it firewater. Don't know why, but I think it's because it feels like your mouth's on fire when you drink it."

I shrugged. "Sure."

Dale bent down and rummaged about in his desk drawers for a few seconds before producing an old-looking, slightly dirty glass which he placed next to his own. He filled up both and handed me the new one.

"To..." he began, raising his glass, but apparently realizing that he wasn't sure what to drink to.

"Hell?" I offered.

Dale smirked. "Damn right. To hell with it. I feel like I'm already there anyways." With that, he downed his whiskey in one go before immediately refilling his glass. Not wanting to raise suspicion, I did the same.

Now, there's one thing you should know about me. I'm not much of a drinker. I like beer, but that's already it. And I really don't hold my liquor well at all. Already after my first glass of whiskey, I felt my stomach grow uncomfortably warm. After my second glass, I began to feel a bit too amused. My sudden giggles seemed to have a contagious effect on my manager as he began to laugh himself.

"You know how much I've lost?" he asked in-between chuckles and I shook my head. "I lost a whole lot. Wanna know something really sad?" I nodded. "A person I love... or at least someone I used to love... he's dying. He's dying and I'm the one who's killing him. I don't want to, you know. But I got to. They make me do it." He let out a wheezing laugh,

quickly followed by a train of hysterical sobs.

He refilled our glasses for the third time. “Who’s them?” I inquired, noticing with concern that I was slurring myself. “Your family?”

Dale looked at me in confusion. “How’d you...? Whatever. Yes. But it ain’t just them. I won’t tell you... I won’t...” his voice slowly trailed off. He filled up glasses number four with shaky hands. He swallowed the contents of his glass after I had done the same before looking up at me one last time. Then, his head sank down onto his desk.

I had trouble getting up from my chair. I felt really sick all of a sudden. Still, I managed to make my way over to the file cabinet. I had to make use of my chance while Dale was out. It took me a while to insert the key into the lock of the cabinet, but to my suprise and delight, it fit perfectly. Upon turning it and sliding open the drawer, my tired eyes were confronted with folders over folders, neatly lined up behind one another in what little space they had.

I remember spotting one titled “Expenses 2020”, another one titled “Earnings 2020” and so on. I decided to try if the other drawer would yield more interesting results, so I bent down and unlocked it. To my surprise, it was completely empty, except for two things: an ancient looking wood handle revolver and a black and white photograph.

I took the latter out of the drawer to inspect it, straining my eyes as I struggled to focus. The picture showed two people in very old-fashioned clothing, a man and a younger woman, or maybe still a girl. They were standing next to each other in front of a grey background I found hard to determine. I thought I could make out some trees, but I could have been wrong.

What instantly struck me as truly odd however was that the faces of the man and the girl could not be seen. They were blank. There were no eyes, no mouths, no noses... just a blank space were all of that should be.

Suddenly, I felt my stomach starting to turn. I knew I was going to be

sick. I dropped the photograph back into the drawer and hurried to lock both it and the upper drawer up again. I quickly tucked away the key in my pocket before dashing out the door of Dale's office. I had barely made it over to the trashcan next to the bench on the Hollywood plaza when I couldn't confine the contents of my stomach any longer.

I threw up into the trashcan once, maybe twice before I sank down onto the bench beside me. My surroundings grew darker and darker as my eyes slowly fluttered shut. I barely noticed the low clacking of boots on the pavement approaching. When I felt someone placing their arms under my own and lifting me up, I didn't resist. When they heaved me over their shoulder like a wet sack of sand, I felt the leather of their vest brush uncomfortably against my skin.

They carried me away from the bench. I opened my eyes a few times on our way to see the gray street move underneath me. It was dizzying. The color of the pavement soon grew darker, then light and sandy. Finally, I don't know for how long the person had been carrying me, they came to a halt and carefully lifted me off their shoulders.

I blinked a few times, groaning as I struggled to stay awake. I was so incredibly tired. I found myself sitting on a wooden porch. It looked familiar and I soon recognized it to belong to the saloon in Twin Vale Point where my co-workers and I had met up two days ago. The man kneeling in front of me, holding my limp body up by the shoulders was familiar too, although it took me a while to place his features.

He looked genuinely concerned. I remember thinking it was a first, seeing as I usually only knew him with a wide grin on his face. I think I said something, but I can't remember what. It was probably just inaudible stammering anyways.

The cowboy smiled sympathetically, also something I had never seen him do before. He then raised his hand to brush a strand of hair out of my sweaty forehead. His cold, dry-skinned fingers traced down the side of my face and rested on my cheek for a little while. I am unsure of why I remember this particular action so well, but I do. I stared at him with

hooded eyes, trying not to drift off to sleep. It felt like he was trying to comfort me.

Suddenly, the silence was broken by the loud voice of a man. I recognized it to be that of Mitchell. "HEY! WHAT DO YOU THINK YOU'RE DOING?"

The cowboy jumped to his feet and I immediately flopped down onto the rough wood below me. I could hear Mitchell run towards us and felt myself being pulled to my feet.

"Leah? Holy shit... are you alright?" I heard my colleague ask me. I tried to respond, but no words left my mouth.

Mitchell proceeded to walk me over to his car, and after about five minutes of me trying to tell him my address, he finally understood where I lived and drove me home.

After a refreshing nap in Mitchell's car's backseat and later on my own couch, I had finally recovered from the whiskey's influence. All that is left of it now is a nasty, nagging headache.

I told Mitchell about my conversation with Dale and what I had found in the file cabinet, and while we couldn't quite make anything of it, we agreed that things were apparently just continuing to get stranger and stranger. I also told him about the laurel twig, to which he remarked that since the Diva had reacted to it in such a weird way, it must be of importance somehow.
"Still, we can't just go around performing any weird rituals or whatever," he warned me in a low voice to go easy on my headache. "Who knows why she destroyed the twig after all. We need to figure this out first, then we decide what to do about it."

"Dale was certain we wouldn't find out anything though," I muttered, massaging my temples. "At least he said as much."

Mitchell grunted. "What does he know? He was rolling drunk, obviously

he didn't make any sense. Also, did he really say he was into guys?"

I shot him an angry glare. "That's what you care about, of all the things I just told you?"

"What? I'm just curious," Mitchell retorted.

I sighed. "He said something about how a man he loves is dying and that he's the one who's killing him because he's being forced to."

Mitchell leaned back against the cushion of my couch, staring at the ceiling in thought. He stayed a bit longer to keep me company. Later that night when my colleague had left, I got a call from Dale himself. He sounded terrible, embarassed and tired at the same time.

"Um, hi... I wanted to apologize. I just woke up, like, half an hour ago and while most of our exchange escapes me, it was probably really unprofessional. If I did anything, well, gross, I want you to know I'm sorry."

"No worries," I told him. "We just had some whiskey together and you whined about your life, but that's all."

"Oh." He paused. "I was meaning to tell you to stop asking me stuff. Did I do that?"

"Yeah, you did, actually. I won't stop though."
"Figured as much. Well, you're not gonna get too far anyways, so I'm not too worried. Do as you please, just stay out of my hair." And there he was, Dale's good old douchy normal self.

After advising him politely to see a therapist, I hung up. I was relieved he apparently hadn't noticed that I'd messed with his file cabinet. I spent the rest of the night watching TV, but in the back of my head, I kept thinking about what my manager had told me in his drunken stupor.

Then, exactly twelve minutes after midnight, I had an idea. It's completely

absurd, but if it's true, it might be the most brilliant thought I've ever had.

All I know for now though is that I need to talk to Nathan again. More than ever.

I hitched a ride on the Stagecoach today

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. I think I've mentioned a couple times before that I am a huge fan of wild west movies. This is probably why I'm so fascinated by the Stagecoach.

My daydreams about this gorgeous carriage usually involve steering it, sitting inside of it and being driven around or even riding on top of its roof like the Laughing Cowboy. I really am a bit envious of him about that. Ever since I first saw the Stagecoach, I just wanted to ride it so badly, be it only once.

Well, it seems this dream of mine has finally become sweet, sweet reality today. And I paid the price for it alright.

My chest and stomach hurt like hell... but it was worth it.

Let me explain.

Before getting on my way to work today, I went down to the small convenience store on my street to purchase a few things I would need that same day. The store is tiny and run by a grumpy, chubby older dude with a gray beard who always wears a Panama hat. It has this musty, stale feel to it, but I sort of like it. Plus, the clerk and I like to joke around sometimes. I think he was even rather happy to see me today since I can hardly imagine he's been getting a lot of customers lately.

I was the only one in the store, except for the owner of course. I collected a few candy bars from the shelves and carried them over to the cash register. I then proceeded to inspect the array of cigarrets and other tobacco products lined up in front of the clerk before picking out a colorful metal box of chewing tobacco and adding it to my pile of junk food.

The clerk looked me up and down with mild surprise. "Usually the only thing you buy here are protein bars and soda," he remarked.

"They say the only constant is change," I replied.

The bearded man grunted amusedly before beginning to ring up my purchases. When he reached the box of chewing tobacco, he held it up to study it. "Gettin' a little something for your man, huh?" he presumed.

"Way off, I want it for myself. I can't get enough of it," I said jokingly and the clerk chuckled and shook his head. When he had bagged all of my items, I went back to my apartment to get my whip and remaining necessities before stopping by at my neighbor's place to ask for some more laurel. I have decided to keep experimenting with it.

I set out for the park with one clear goal in mind: to talk to Nathan. I felt a bit like a stalker, the way I snuck up to the entrance sign of Twin Vale Point after tending to the sock puppet at six in the morning. I could hear the sounds of the oncoming carriage in the distance. I waited by the town entrance for the horses to come into sight. As soon as they did, I began waving at Nathan, who was sitting in his coach seat as always. I swear I could see him roll his eyes even from half a mile away.

The coachman sure wasn't happy to see me. That didn't stop me though. I ran up to him and came to a halt right in front of the horses, forcing him to stop so as to not run me over. I smiled at him and made my way over to where he was sitting.

"Hi," I said.

"Hello," he replied dryly.

"Are you a little more willing to talk to me now by any chance?" I asked.

Nathan leaned over to me, the smell of his blanket instantly penetrating my nostrils. "Look at my face and tell me yourself," he growled.

"You look like you wish you hadn't stopped the Stagecoach just now," I remarked.
Nathan grimaced. "Wow. Here I was thinking you had no self-awareness. I didn't know you were simply ignoring it."

“You sound a bit like Dale,” I commented.

Nathan’s reaction to my manager’s name was instantaneous. His expression darkened and for a second, I thought his face would scrunch up like that of a baby and he would start to cry. Instead, he just swallowed audibly before cracking the reins and shouting at his horses to start moving again.

I sighed and sat down by the entrance sign. He drives around in circles, so I knew he’d have to come by again eventually. I found myself wishing for company. Maybe Darius or Mitchell would come by soon. Or better yet, one of the other girls. It had been a while since the last time I had privately talked to Anne or Maxine.

I sat and waited for about fifteen minutes before the sound of horseshoes clacking guided me out of my thoughts. I stood up and casually walked up to the approaching Stagecoach. Nathan looked even more annoyed to see me this time.

“Would some chocolate change your mind? I brought some junk food from home,” I called out to him, shrugging the backpack I was wearing off my shoulders. “You’ve got to be hungry, right?”

Nathan groaned. “Damn, you’re persistent.”

I nodded. Nathan puffed. “Leave me alone. I mean it. No clue what you want to know, but I probably won’t be able to tell you.”

“Let’s try it then! Come on, please,” I begged, but Nathan just shook his head and set the carriage into motion again.

Another round of waiting until once again, the carriage came rolling up to me. I rose to my feet. This time, Nathan stopped the Stagecoach right next to where I was standing. He stared at me calculatingly for a moment before nodding at the empty space beside him on the coachseat. “Hop on,” he ordered curtly.

“You mean it?”

Nathan rolled his eyes and nodded. “Quick, before I change my mind.”

He didn’t have to tell me twice. I climbed onto the Stagecoach and sat down next to him.

“I’d hold onto my seat if I were you,” Nathan told me before cracking the reins and shouting, “Giddy up!”

The horses neighed and began trotting off. The carriage bucketed jerkily over the sandy, bumpy ground. I could hardly believe it, I was actually on the Stagecoach. And it felt awesome.

“So, what about the sudden change of heart?” I inquired, trying hard to keep my cool.

“You would’ve just kept waiting anyways. Best to just get it over with,” Nathan explained. “Also, this is what you always wanted, isn’t it? Don’t pretend. I see you watch the carriage all day, you know.”

I let out a flustered chuckle. “True. I guess I’m a bit of a fan.”

For a split second, I thought I could see a smile appear and quickly vanish again on the coachman’s face. “It’s not that great when you’re the one driving it,” he muttered with downcast eyes before looking up at me again. “So. What do you know?”

Swallowing down my apprehension, I began. “I know for sure that this park is family-run. I also know that something really messed up is happening to you and I want to help. Then there’s some stuff I believe I know but am not fully certain about.”
“What would that be?” Nathan sounded calm, but stern.

“I had a conversation with Dale yesterday. He was... very much intoxicated. He didn’t make a lot of sense so I had to piece together what little snippets he gave me.” I took a deep breath. “I think you and

Dale used to be quite fond of one another, but then for some reason, he gave you the task of driving the Stagecoach. I believe you're turning into a not-actor... or rather becoming one with this one here."

Nathan leaned back in his seat and pulled the smelly blanket closer around his shoulders. "That last part... it's true. All of it. But I don't know any more either."

"You don't?" I was a bit taken aback. He sounded like he was telling the truth, but I had somehow expected him to have way more insight. "Will you still tell me what you know?"

"Not sure if it'll be of much help." Nathan regarded me with a sad smile.

"I insist," I said sternly. "It will help, I'm sure of it."

The coachman's grip on the horses' reins tightened and he let out a soft sigh. "You said you had candy?"

I nodded and opened my backpack, pulling out a chocolate bar at random. I unwrapped it before handing it to him. The young man took a large bite out of it and began chewing. His expression softened. "Thanks. I didn't have anything sweet since... I don't know, to be honest. It's been that long since I last got off of the Stagecoach. I don't really need to eat at all anymore. Still nice having something that tastes good though."

I felt myself becoming excited in light of what I was about to hear, but decided not to interrupt him. Better let him take his time.

"Dale and I first met in high school, but we were just friends then. Later, years after both of us had graduated, we reconnected and decided to get some coffee together. We hit it off right away and that's kind of how we became a thing.

He was fascinating to me. He was always so emotional and contemplative. He was a bit of a mystery too. So sweet though. Really, really caring and

sweet. I had never felt safer with anyone else before. Dale truly cared about me. He never made a big deal about it either, it was just natural for him to be there for me whenever I needed him.

He had just taken over his dad's job as park manager and I was unemployed, so he got me a job as a waiter here at the park. It might seem weird to you that my boss was my boyfriend as well, but it was all pretty great. We were happy during that time, like, really happy. Until one day, he waited for me outside the restaurant I worked at after closing hours. He had tears in his eyes. He tried to hide it, but he looked incredibly sad. I asked him what was wrong, but he told me it was nothing and that he needed to tell me I was going to do another job at the park from now on. He said I was going to be an actor.

I asked him why and he told me he had gotten instructions to have me change jobs and that he had to follow them. See, I didn't know why he was so sad. I mean, it was strange, sure, but I didn't get why he was crying. He asked me to drop the subject and we went home. Back then, I used to live with him, you know. Even at home he was acting all strange and depressed and I didn't know what had gotten into him, I was worried sick. Anyways, I had promised to drop it so I didn't dare to ask any further questions.

Instead, I did my best to take care of him. Dale's always been so sensitive. I remember telling him that whatever he was feeling so down about, we would work it out together and that he could count on me. His response... I remember it like it was yesterday. He told me he knew and that that was why he was so sorry. He kept begging me for forgiveness. It was beyond confusing.

The next day he led me to the Stagecoach. I had seen it around before. It used to have another coachman, but he was gone all of a sudden. Never saw him around again by the way. Dale told me he had quit, but I have my doubts. He said that I would be the new coachman and when I told him I had never driven a carriage before, he simply said I'd learn it by myself in no time. He was right about that by the way.

Then he just suddenly pulled out a bottle of coke and handed it to me. He told me he had gotten it for me as a refreshment so naturally, I thanked him and started drinking it. The moment I took the first swig from it though, Dale started to weep. Like, really horrible, heart-breaking crying. I instantly attempted to comfort him. He was completely inconsolable though.

We sat down on the coachseat together and I hugged him while he cried. I finished up the soda few minutes later. I remember thinking it tasted weird. When Dale noticed I had emptied it, he took the bottle and stared at it for a while. "I'm so terribly sorry," he'd whispered. I was still taken aback, but I told him I loved him and then he kissed me. That was... that was the last time we ever talked.

It didn't occur to me he had poisoned me until later. I trusted him, I would have trusted him with my life. So when I started convulsing and everything began to spin around me, I was still like, it can't be, it can't be, he'd never hurt me. I had to face it though when I found myself unable to leave the seat of the carriage. I would instantly start to feel sick again whenever I did.

At first, I was still able to leave for the bathroom and to eat from time to time, but I felt it getting harder and harder day by day. As if it was slowly progressing. From the very first day, I found myself unable to leave the park. After two years, I wasn't able to leave Twin Vale Point. And then, three years ago, shortly before you started working here, I noticed that I wasn't getting thirsty or hungry anymore.

From then on, everytime I got off the Stagecoach for any other reason then to mind the horses or the carriage in any way, it started to hurt. It hurt so, so much that I just... stopped." Nathan looked up at me with tear-filled eyes. "I don't know why Dale did this to me. I'm sure he didn't want to. Someone forced him to do it, but I don't know who or how or why or..." his voice trailed off. "That's all I know. I've tried making sense of all of this more times than I can count, but it doesn't matter anymore."

"It does matter! I'll get you out of here," I promised. "I've been working

on figuring out a bunch of stuff! Once I've gotten it all together, I'll know a way to help you! Just hang in there, okay?"

Nathan smiled softly and shook his head. "No. I appreciate it, but it's too late for me." His voice had grown very quiet all of a sudden as he said, "I'm never leaving here."

I opened my mouth to protest but he shushed me. "I mean it," he whispered. The horses came to an easy halt and the coachman lowered the reins, pinning them between his knees as his hands reached up to slowly remove the smelly blanket draped around his shoulders.

The shirt he was wearing underneath was old, stained and wrinkly. He moved his hands up to unbutton it, revealing his chest. At first, I thought his skin looked like it had suffered a severe sunburn, but the closer I inspected it, the more I realized that amongst the innumerable large blisters, parts of it were overlapping as if they had molten into each other. It looked grotesque and strange, but above all else, extremely painful.

"When did this happen?" I muttered.

"It spreads everytime I get off the Stagecoach," he explained as he buttoned up his shirt and once again wrapped the blanket around himself. I imagined the secretions from the blisters popping trickling into its fabric and couldn't help but gag slightly.

"There has to be some way of stopping it," I professed, feeling a hint of desperation in my own voice.
"I don't think there is," Nathan replied as picked up the reins again. "You know," he confessed as the carriage set into motion again, "I didn't think I would, but I enjoyed talking to you. It's been a while. I've just lost track of everything over time. As I said, I don't even feel things like thirst or hunger anymore. In fact, I kind of feel... numb. I think that it's part of whatever transformation I'm undergoing here, to stop caring. I've come to terms with it."

I didn't know what else to say, so I kept quiet for a little while before asking, "Were Dale's parents against the relationship? It could have been them who forced him to... you know."

Nathan pondered for a few seconds before shaking his head. "I don't think so. If they did, they were never open about it. I only met them on very few occasions though, so I'm not sure."

"Where'd you get the blanket though?"

"I don't know. It was just lying next to me one morning when I woke up. Maybe Dale gave it to me."

"Any idea what could have been in that soda maybe?"

"No clue. I told you I didn't know much at all about the park. I only know what's happening to me, but that's already it." After a short pause, he added, "Would you like to keep me company some more?"

Of course I said yes. After we talked some more about unrelated things, Nathan decided to entertain us by having the horses speed up a little, then a little more and then a lot until we were basically flying over the streets of Twin Vale Point. We were both losing our shit and I was laughing like crazy. It was insanely fun. You'd never believe how fast this carriage could actually go. I felt the cool wind hit my face and tousle my hair.

As I was saying, I was enjoying myself until I found myself unable to hold on to my seat anymore. At first, Nathan offered me his arm as a means of support, but I had to let go of it soon since it was hindering him in steering the carriage. I felt myself steadily slipping off to the side and I called out to Nathan to slow down, but by the time the horses had taken on a safe pace again, I had already fallen off.

My contact with the dirty ground was more than painful. I landed flat on my stomach and continued to slide across the street a couple inches, just enough for road pebbles to pierce my shirt and scrape my skin. The

impact left a nasty graze on my chin and I later found that there were large bruises along my collarbone as well as around my hips and belly.

"ARE YOU OKAY?" I heard Nathan shout, but his voice lost itself in the distance as the horses continued to carry him off.

"I'M FINE!" I yelled back, hoping he would hear me. I didn't want him to turn back and get off the Stagecoach, knowing what I knew now.

It took me some effort to push myself up from the ground. Groaning and aching, I managed to rise to a sitting position, only to stop and pull up my shirt a little to inspect the burning scratches on my skin. Suddenly, a hand appeared in front of my face. I looked up to find the Laughing Cowboy towering over me. I quickly straightened out my shirt and grabbed his hand so he could pull me to my feet.

"Hey, just who I was looking for," I uttered, my voice still a bit agonized from the fall. "Say, how come you're always around whenever I need assistance?"

The question was rethorical of course. The cowboy didn't respond, he just smiled and lifted his hat to me before turning around and beginning to walk off.

"Wait a second!"

He halted, allowing me to catch up to him with faltering steps. I took off my backpack and began to rummage around inside until I produced the slim metal box of tobacco. "I don't know if you like this kind of thing, but I didn't really know what else to get you. I just wanted to give you a little something as thanks for being so nice to me. You helped my clumsy ass out so many times that I've stopped counting already."

I held the box out to him and he carefully took it from my hands, a pensive look on his face. He eyed it in what looked to be disbelief for a few seconds before tucking it away in one of his pockets. I smiled. We continued to stare at one another and I found myself unsure of what to

say. I watched the black saliva trickle from the corner of his mouth. It was almost hypnotic.

I finally remembered something. Reaching into my backpack, I took out the new laurel twig and held it out for him to see. “Do you know what this is?” I asked.

His eyes widened and without a warning, he raised his hand and smacked the twig out of my grasp. I watched it sail through the air and hit the ground. The cowboy turned back to me, flashed me his typical wide smile before lifting his hat once again and walking off.

I’m starting to think the pretenders really dislike laurel for some reason. Maybe I should have showed the twig to Nathan too, but after my tumble, I only wanted to get back home.

I already mentioned that my whole upper body still hurts quite a lot, which is also the reason why I won’t go to the park tomorrow. I have tasked Darius with feeding the sock puppet so I can take the day off to recover. I’ll still take the time to at least recount one or two of my older job experiences while my investigations are on hold for a bit.

I’m not entirely sure what to make of my exchange with Nathan. I feel so deeply sorry for him. He may have given up already, but maybe there still is a way to help him after all.

Now I hope you’ll excuse me, for I need to go get a fresh cold pack for my chin and shoulder. As I said, it hurts like hell, but the ride on the Stagecoach was totally worth it.

our manager has us do some pretty weird stuff on Halloween

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. Let me preface this by thanking those of you who have expressed their concern about me on my previous post and assuring you that I am feeling a lot better. I don't believe the Stagecoach has had any effect on me. My injuries have gotten better as well, even though I've discovered that I've twisted my ankle a bit and therefore have trouble walking, which is why I'll probably stay off work tomorrow as well.

What I'm about to tell you happened on Halloween. Fall is one of our busier seasons since Dale always has us go all out with spooky decorations once Halloween approaches. This of course makes work just all the more tiresome. However that's not the only thing making life for us actors harder than it already is around that time.

Come October, my manager gets into this very weird mood and starts acting atypically nice to us. On Halloween night, we close down a bit earlier, at nine pm to be exact. That of course is strange in itself, seeing as one would think that this would be the perfect occasion to keep the park open extra long. But it gets weirder.

After the park is shut down and all the other staff has left the premises, we, the seven actors, are tasked with completing a strange set of chores. Nathan is of course excluded from this matter, something that I didn't understand for a long time but makes a lot more sense to me after our conversation yesterday.

First off, we are not allowed to leave the park until midnight. That means we have three hours time to complete the tasks Dale gives us. They're different each year, and I feel like they get stranger every single time. Take last year as an example.

After the park was closed down and everyone else had left, the seven of us had gathered outside Dale's office like every year, ready to receive our instructions. Now, Dale always tells us that they're of utmost importance, but he has never given us any reason or further explanation. Sometimes, I really wonder if he just does it to mess with us. No one ever questions him though since he pays us extra on that night.

I remember it was a particularly cold and starry night. The moon was standing high in the sky and a cool breeze was ruffling my frilly black shirt. None of us had changed out of our costumes yet. I was hopping up and down a little to warm myself up. Darius offered me his blood-stained lab coat, but I politely declined. When Dale finally stepped out of his office holding a clipboard and a camera, we let out a collective sigh of relief.

"Been taking your time, boss," Maxine remarked.

"I do hope you'll forgive me," my manager replied sarcastically. "Are all the pretenders locked up?"

Each of us nodded affirmatively.

"So, what is it this time?" Mitchell urged him.

The girls and I exchanged amused glances as we thought back to the Halloween night of the year prior when Mitchell was ordered to strip down to his boxers, run around the Haunted Hospital-funhouse three times while singing the first song he could think of.

Caroline, Maxine, Anne and I had laughed at him like crazy. Admittedly, that had been a bit mean, but seeing your co-worker jog around in nothing but his underwear singing Bad Moon Rising was something none of us could take seriously. Darius, Oliver and Dale had tried not to make a big deal of it, but we hadn't been able to hold back. Anne stifled a giggle at the memory to which Mitchell shot her a death glare.

"Don't worry, sheriff," Dale assured him, "no one's gonna be forced to lay eyes on that soft belly of yours tonight."

A low chuckle rippled throughout our group. Mitchell cursed.

"No, ladies and gentlemen, tonight's task is one including every one of you. First, we will relocate to the candyland. No one's allowed to say a word on our way except me. Once we're all there, we gather on the main

plaza in a circle, you join hands and close your eyes. I'll be standing in the middle. It's important that you do as I say and only open your eyes once I allow you to." His voice softened a bit.

"And after that we'll just go and hang out in one of the restaurants in Hollywood until midnight. I got some donuts for you then," he added.

Anne, who was still in her clown's costume, raised her hand. "Is that really it? No weird stunts or publicly humiliating ourselves?"

Dale nodded. "Yes, that's all. Oh, one more thing, I'll be taking photos of each single one of you, so don't let the flash of the camera startle you. You have to keep your eyes closed once we've joined hands." He took a look at his digital watch. "Alright... we're starting our march to the candy-section now. Remember, I don't want to hear a single tone from any of you."

A few of us nodded affirmatively and we got on our way. I was quietly walking alongside Caroline, exchanging smiles and looks of equal confusion from time to time. When we had reached the plaza, we formed a circle around Dale, just like he had instructed us. Caroline was standing to my right. I could feel the warmth of her palm through her silk glove. Oliver, who stood to my left, shot me a shy smile before taking my smaller hand into his. His skin was a bit rough and calloused.

"Alright everyone, now close your eyes," Dale ordered.

I took a deep breath before doing as he told me. For a minute or two, everything was silent. I felt Caroline's fingers twitch slightly. Then, suddenly, I felt something... odd.

It was like I sensed a person standing right behind me. For a split second, I was almost certain I could even feel their breath in my hair. The sensation lingered for over a full minute. I know because I was counting the seconds in my head. Still, I marked my manager's warning and kept my eyes shut. I shuddered when they finally seemed to have moved past me. Oliver must have felt me shiver seeing as he gave my

hand a reassuring squeeze.

Only seconds later, Dale unexpectedly spoke up. His voice was low and very grave. “Don’t move.”

I took a deep breath. Caroline’s fingers were trembling ever so slightly. I could hear someone, presumable one of the guys, cough quietly. Dale hissed at his to shut up.

“Stay still,” he whispered. “Just a little longer now.” He then added something in an even more indistinct voice, something I couldn’t understand. It sounded like a question though.

“Alright, I’m gonna take your pictures now. Keep your eyes shut and stay still,” he commanded.

Moments later, I could see a camera flashing brightly through my closed eyelids. From the electronic beeping noise that followed, I assumed that Dale was looking through the photos. For a second it sounded like he was holding his breath before exhaling again.

“Okay, that’s all,” he finally told us. “You can open your eyes again.”

With a collective sigh of relief, we let go of each other’s hands. Looking around at my co-workers’ faces, I found every emotion ranging from confusion to unease displayed on them.

“There,” Dale said with a smile, “wasn’t that hard, was it?”

“Well, it sure beats last year,” Mitchell remarked.

“Let us take our coats though next time,” Caroline added. “I mean it, I’m freezing.”

As promised, Dale let unlocked the door to one of the restaurants in Hollywood for us and let us sit inside. He had apparently kept his promise seeing as there were two large boxes of donuts standing on the

largest table, waiting for us.

“Help yourselves,” he offered before turning to leave.

“Aren’t you joining us?” Oliver asked.

Dale smiled bitterly. “I think you’d have more fun without your boss in the same room. I’ll be dropping by at midnight to let you guys out.”

With that, he left us by ourselves. We spent the remainder of our night shift talking and playing more or less improvised games. The donuts were delicious and I think we were having a good time. None of us really commented on the Halloween task until I asked if anyone had been able to understand what Dale’s inaudible question from earlier.

“What question?” Mitchell inquired, the piece of donut in his mouth muffling his voice.

I frowned. “I’m pretty sure he said something, I just don’t know what. Did no one else hear it?”

The others shook their heads.

“So, what do you guys think this was? Some kind of séance?” Anne inquired. “I felt kinda weird when we did it... almost like...”

“Someone was walking around behind us,” I finished her sentence.

My friend nodded eagerly. “Yes! Exactly.”

“I liked last year’s task better,” Oliver chimed in, amicably nudging Mitchell who was sitting next to him. “At least that gave us something to laugh about. This was just plain unsettling.”

“I didn’t mind it, actually,” Darius remarked. “It felt kinda cool doing this thing as a group. There was, like, this sense of unison to it.”
We continued to ponder about the background of the annual chores

some more before coming to the conclusion that it was all probably harmless and that the extra pay was worth it and that was that.

While I have never been able to make any sense of this odd tradition, it's pretty obvious that it has something to do with the park. I wonder if someday, when I've got all of this figured out, I'll understand why Dale took our pictures last year, had Mitchell run around naked in 2018 and the lot of us square-dance for one hour on the Hollywood plaza in 2017.

the restroom

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. After things were rather boring yesterday, I can hardly put what I experienced today into words. I am not quite sure anymore where all of this is going, but even though uncertainty has taken its toll on me these last couple hours, I'm determined to see this through to the end. No matter where it might lead me.

When I arrived at the park today, it felt like the premises had been awaiting me. There was a fresh breeze blowing and the air smelt strangely nice. It was almost welcoming.

There was nobody by the employee entrance and on my way down the streets to the cage of the sock puppet in the horror-themed section, I did not encounter a single soul. Once I reached the funhouse however, I spotted Darius standing beside Mr Scratch's shelter. He noticed me approaching and walked up to me, looking both happy and concerned at the same time.

"Hey there!" he greeted me. "Good to have you back. How are you doing? Still mortally wounded?"

"Eh, I think it looks worse than it actually is by now," I told him, my fingers instinctively wandering up to my chin to touch the prominent, scabby remnant of the abrasion I had suffered when flying off the Stagecoach. "How's my fuzzbutt?"

"I took good care of him. I think."

I stared at my colleague with an unsettled expression.

"Well, he's not dead or anything! But what do I know about how he's doing, I'm not his owner. He probably misses you or something. He just lies around all day. Doesn't really do much."

I wasted no more time and ran up to the sock puppet's cage. The black beast inside sluggishly lifted his head. When he recognized me, he jumped up and hurriedly came scrambling outside.

“Hi baby!” I squeaked as I buried my face in his fluffy fur. I couldn’t believe how much I had actually missed him. It’s true, he really is like a dog to me. There’s no sense in denying it.

Darius was watching us with a disturbed look on his face. After I had caught up with my not-actor, fed and played with him a bit, I went to sit with Darius. I told him what I had already told Caroline the day prior and his reaction was pretty much the same. I then asked if anything odd had happened during my absence. Darius assured me that I hadn’t really missed anything, although Mitchell, Anne and Maxine had been dropping by to ask about me when they had noticed me amiss.

Soon after, I went to see Nathan. I found his carriage standing in the shade of a larger booth in Twin Vale Point. When I called his name to get his attention and came walking up to him, he looked up at me with a dumbstruck expression on his face.

“It’s you,” he said.

“Uh... yeah? Can I come up to you?”

He nodded and moved over on his seat, patting the free spot next to him. I hopped on and sat down beside him.

“Are you alright? Should I leave?” I asked.

“No! No, I just... uh... I didn’t think you’d come back.”

I regarded him with slight confusion. “I figured you’d like some company. And I brought you some new clothes. You know, like... ones that don’t smell as much.”

“For real?”

I nodded and opened my backpack to give him the clothes. I stepped back off the Stagecoach and turned my back to him while he changed.

“You can look now,” he said softly after a while.

I smiled at him and climbed back onto the coachseat. “Do they fit?”

“They do, actually. They’re really comfortable... thank you.”

“You’re welcome. I got some more candy and some sunburn lotion, too,” I told him as I emptied my backpack next to him.

He stared at me in disbelief. “That’s very nice of you,” he muttered in a monotonous voice.

“Dude, I told you I’d help. This is the least I can do. Would you like me to bring you a new blanket as well? Or wash this one?”

“No,” he replied with a surprising vehemence. “I like this one,” he added, more softly this time.

“Because it’s Dale’s?” I assumed.

He didn’t respond, just nodded and wrapped the blanket around his shoulders once again. “I like having it around,” he finally explained.

“So... since you drive around here all the time... did you ever notice that the four plazas of each section kind of, like, make a circle together?” I asked.

Nathan shot me a confused glance. He picked up one of my chocolate bars and began removing the wrapper. “I’m in this section most of the time, so I don’t really think about stuff like this. But now that you’re bringing it up... well, I guess they do? Maybe? I don’t get why this is relevant though.”

I leaned back and stared up at the sky. “Do you know where I could get a map of the park? Like, not one of these cartoony ones we hand out to the visitors, but like a detailed one.”

“I’m sure Dale would have one in his office,” Nathan suggested, taking a bite from his candy bar. The way he pronounced his former lover’s name was weirdly stoic.

“You think he’d give me one if I asked though? He’s told me he doesn’t care that I’m snooping around. Says I’ll never figure it out anyway, whatever he means by that. So maybe he would, right?”

The coachman shrugged. “Not sure. Just try it. What’s there to lose.”

I turned to him, smirking. “Ah, I love talking to you. So captivating.”

“Sorry. I kinda forgot how to...” his voice trailed off when he noticed that I was grinning. He chuckled and playfully slapped me on the arm.

I was a bit surprised. This was the first time I had seen him this lively. Or any kind of lively for that matter. I stayed with him for a little while longer before getting on my way to try my luck in regards to the map.

When I arrived at Dale’s office, I found the door halfway open. My manager was sitting inside, seemingly immersed in a book that wasn’t work-related from the looks of it. I cleared my throat and he glanced up at me, only to redirect his gaze to the pages of his novel once again.

“Dale,” I said firmly.

“What is it now?” he asked listlessly, not looking up.

“I was wondering if you had a detailed map of the park I could have.”

My manager sighed. “For fuck’s sake, Leah. Just stop. You said you’d leave me alone.”

“Well, I was lying, obviously. Plus, I don’t need your help. I just want a map. Come on, you gotta have one lying around here.”

No answer.

“Dale. Ignoring me won’t make me go away.”

Still nothing.

“Nathan would give me the map, you know.”

Dale straightened up, glaring at me with tight lips. He then slammed his book down on his desk, bent down to rummage about in one of his drawers before producing a folded piece of paper which he threw in my direction. It sailed through the air and landed on the floor right in front of my feet.

“There, go fetch,” he hissed, but the meanness didn’t really deliver since all I had to do was bend down to pick it up. “By the way, stop getting on Nathan’s nerves,” he added, but I could sense a rather unhappy undertone in his voice.

“Right,” I retorted. “He’s got enough on his mind as it is after all.”

Dale stared up at me in both shock and disbelief.

“Thank you.” I smiled, waved the map at him and stepped back outside.

Darius was waiting for me on a bench in the ghosttown. I had told him to stay nearby since I still wanted to try out a few things. Initially, I had been planning on showing the laurel twig, iron nail and sliver bracelet to some of the pretenders to see how they would react. After all, these things are said to have a certain effect on supernatural beings, so maybe it would help figuring out their nature. But now that I had the map, there were more important things to do.

I quickly explained my plan to Darius. We unfolded the map and spread it out on the ground in front of us. After a bit of rummaging, I produced a used up pen and a small ruler from my backpack. I always carry around some drawing and writing materials. They don’t take in a lot of space and you never know when you might be bored.

We first located the four main plazas. Then, we used the ruler to connect the specific sections that were more or less placed across from one another. The four lines crossed in one point in the middle of the circle the four plazas produced. Our sketch was crude and messy, but according to the map, there was actually a building in that intersection. It was a visitors' restroom. Darius and I exchanged excited glances. He was the first one to mouth our suspicion.

"If you're right about the thing with the circle, then there might be something really important in there."

I agreed and we got on our way. The restroom was apparently located on the outer edge of the Hollywood section. It didn't take long for us to reach it seeing as it was pretty close to our part of the park. I remember noticing that I was feeling a bit off when we arrived in front of it. Like I had eaten something bad.

"It's locked," Darius remarked after trying the door.

"That was to expect. There's no visitors at the moment after all."

We rounded the small building until we found a window high up in one of the outside walls of the men's part of the restroom that had been left open. After a bit of contemplation, Darius lifted me up so I could climb inside. He himself was too broad to fit. I squeezed myself through the small opening and landed ungracefully on the cold tiled floor. I slowly rose to my feet and glanced around. All of a sudden, the sick feeling in my stomach had intensified.

"Can you try and open the door from inside?" Darius called out to me.

The moment he finished this sentence though, the room began to spin around me. The gray of the separate stall doors started to blur, before it finally changed to black. I felt my body hit the floor mere moments before I fell unconcious.
I instantly knew what I was seeing when I was out wasn't real. For some

reason though I wasn't sure where to place it. Was it a hallucination? A dream? A nightmare caused by my pre-existing fear of the Sugar Plum Fairy? Or maybe, just maybe... a vision of sorts?

What I saw felt unsettlingly familiar. I was standing on a meadow and a short distance ahead of me, there was a little girl in a light pink dress. She was sitting on a large stone with her back turned to me. Her shoulders were twitching ever so slightly, almost as if she was laughing... or crying.

I slowly, carefully began approaching her, my hand outstretched, ready to tap her on the shoulder. At least I believe that was what I was going to do. My hand was already hovering above her slender, sparsely covered frame, when suddenly, she spun around, her neck producing an unnerving cracking sound as it twisted in a way a human body shouldn't have.

She didn't have a face. Instead of eyes, a mouth or a nose, there was just a large, pale beak. A radula. She let out a sharp hiss before lunging at me. She pushed me to the ground, her hands on either of my shoulders. She hissed once again and specks of saliva came flying out of her beak, hitting my face.

Thank god I woke up before I could see what she would do next.

I came to with my head in Darius's lap. He seemed to have been patting my cheek and was staring down at me with deep concern written all over his face. When I finally raised my head, he let out a sigh of relief.

"Oh thank god," he muttered. "What the hell happened in there? Did you have a circulatory breakdown or something?"

"I don't know," I admitted. Darius frowned. I looked around. We were sitting on the ground outside the men's restroom again. I fumbled for my backpack only to find it lying next to me. "How'd you get me out?"

"I didn't. It wasn't me."
"What do you mean? What happened?"

“It... it was the cowboy. I called out to you and then I heard this weird sound, which was probably you falling. I got really worried, so I kept calling. But you didn’t answer. You were in there for like, fifteen minutes or something. I was already thinking of getting Dale so he could unlock the door, but then... he, the cowboy, he was just suddenly standing right beside me. Scared the crap out of me. He must have heard me call your name or something.

He motioned for me to stay by the window. He had me hold his hat while he jumped up... he didn’t even need me to lift him up, he just jumped up there and pulled himself in. A bit later, I saw that he was slowly lowering you out of the window, so I sat down his hat and caught you when you came out. He followed soon after with your backpack, but he didn’t stay or anything. He just put his hat back on and left. It was kinda cool to be honest.”

I stared down at my lap in thought for a while before Darius broke the silence once again. “Did he... uh... do you know if he, like, did anything while you were inside? Because he stayed in there with you a bit. And I heard, like, rummaging or something.”

I told him I didn’t know. My colleague took it upon himself to drive me home. We agreed not to tell Dale about what we had tried, even though that was pretty natural for both of us. Now, here’s the thing. I don’t have circulatory breakdowns. I don’t just fall unconcious for no reason. Both Darius and I know that and we believe that there was something in there that had done something odd to my head. Even though we both aren’t sure why it only affected me. According to Darius, he was feeling perfectly normal.

At home, I investigated the contents of my backpack. I still had the map with me. But I think I know why the cowboy didn’t bother to stay around.
The iron nail, silver bracelet and laurel twig I had taken with me were nowhere to be found.

I passed out again

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. Even though I fainted yesterday, both my colleague Darius, who was with me at the time, and I agreed to further investigate the restroom. If we are correct in our theory, it is the heart of the amusement park. If there is one place to look for the truth, it's in there.

Which is a weird thing to say seeing as it is a restroom I'm talking about.

Before I headed out to meet with my co-workers today, I packed some more laurel from my neighbor, who I believe I'm starting to really weird out at this point, another iron nail and a pair of silver earrings. I really have to be careful with my usage of the latter. I can't tell where I'll get more silver if I were to lose these. I most certainly don't have the financial means to just buy it.

One thing I completely forgot about last time was the key the Nurse had more or less given to Darius. I had already been able to use it for the file cabinet in Dale's office, so I guess I just ruled out the possibility of it fitting the restroom door as well. It appears we could have avoided quite a few difficulties if either of us had thought of this sooner.

Darius and I had gathered the other actors around the restroom and told them all about what we had found out. When we had done everything we needed to catch up, we focused on the issue at hand: the restroom, presumably the centre of the park itself. Perhaps it was just another meaningless location amidst all the funhouses, rollercoasters and booths, but for that it was simply a tad too conspicuous.

I remember feeling a little sick once again, a notion that only intesified the closer I got closer to the small building. I produced the Nurse's key from my pocket and held it up for my co-workers to see. I then carefully inserted it into the restroom door's keyhole. The other six watched in awe as it slid inside effortlessly. I turned it and the door sprang open. It fit. It actually fit.

"Can I just say, Anne and Darius, great job on checking every door you could find," Mitchell remarked sarcastically.

Anne stuck out his tongue to him and Darius sighed. “Look, we tried, okay?”

“Yeah, whatever...” Mitchell’s voice trailed off in my head. I blinked a couple times and rubbed my eyes, trying to ignore my rising unease.

The restroom was empty, of course. We went for the men’s part first, seeing as that’s where I passed out last time. The first things that stood out to us were the iron nail, laurel twig and silver bracelet I had brought in yesterday strewn across the tiled floor. Darius was the first one to reach them, the rest of us still waiting outside. He knelt down and gathered them up in his hands, taking them back outside to show me.

“They weren’t like that yesterday, were they?” he asked, holding them out to me.

The nail was showing clear signs of rust, the silver bracelet looked tarnished and way more worn than I remembered and the bright green leaves of the bay laurel had wilted, shriveled down to sad, brown shreds.

“No,” I replied, reaching out to take them from him. I tucked them away in my backpack and sat it down on the ground outside before proceeding into the small building. After all, it was now obvious that whatever was inside that restroom had damaged the charms. It was rejecting them. Perhaps me carrying them around with me was what had caused me to collapse yesterday.

It worked. When entering the dim, gloomy looking bathroom, I felt perfectly fine. Even though the others had been reluctant at first, they soon joined in on the search. It didn’t take long for Oliver to find something out of the ordinary.

“Hey guys! One of the stalls is closed off,” he called out.

We gathered around the door in question. There was a hand-written sign reading Cleaning Supplies fixed to it. The sign itself was strange enough. The paper that had been used to make it looked really old and

the writing on it was faded.

All of the toilet stall doors in the amusement park reach all the way down to the floor and up to the ceiling, so there is no way of seeing what's on the inside if you're standing in front of one. None of us actors ever use the visitors' restrooms, meaning that we had no idea of there being a locked room. We probably wouldn't have payed any attention to it either if it weren't for us specifically looking for it.

We tried to use the key on it once again, but for some reason, it didn't fit this time.

"What kinda shit is this?" Mitchell complained loudly. "Fuck Dale, seriously. That guy uses one and the same key for the mystery restroom and the file cabinet in his office, but not for this thing?"

"Well, maybe it is just a regular supply storage," Maxine suggested. "We should keep looking around. We might be missing what's actually important here."

We continued to search, but we found absolutely nothing. Eventually we had to realize that whatever was special about this restroom was lying behind that locked stall door.

"Does anyone know a member of the cleaning staff by any chance?" Oliver asked the group. "They might know something."

Caroline perked up and nodded. "Just a second," she muttered as she fumbled for her phone. After shortly glancing down at it, she frowned. "There's no reception in here. I'll try outside." With that, she rushed out of the restroom.

"It's weird that there's no reception in here. I know for sure there is in the employee restrooms," Mitchell stated.

"How so?" I asked with a grin.
He shrugged, avoiding my questioning stare. "I get bored when I have

to go for bigger business, okay?"

"Alright, no cell phone reception, the place clearly rejects otherwise protective objects and can even cause their bearer to pass out. There's obviously something sinister going on in here," Anne concluded. Side-glancing at me, she added, "How are you feeling, by the way?"

"I'm fine, I guess. I think it's because I left my stuff outside," I replied.

"Well, good, but as soon as you start getting drowsy or anything like that, tell us, okay?" Anne patted me on the back and was just about to turn her attention back on the locked door in front of us when she let out a startled gasp.

Everyone immediately turned to look at her and ask what was wrong, but all she had to do was hold up her hand. There was a large red stain on her palm.

"Leah," she whispered. "You're bleeding." She took a step back to take a look at my back. "Holy shit... it's all over your shirt."

It was only then that I noticed a sense of wetness on my skin, as if someone had splashed me with water from behind. I craned my neck to try and see what she meant. I could spot prominent streaks of red out of the corner of my eye. I rushed to the bathroom mirror and turned so I could get a better look at myself. Anne was right.

I never mentioned this before because I obviously didn't think it would be relevant, but I have a few tattoos on my back. It's mostly just aesthetic stuff and symbols or phrases from franchises that I like. For example, I've got the Moon Stick from Sailor Moon and a couple of lavender roses on my left shoulderblade.

Then, on the small of my back, there's a lettering reading "No Return" in a pretty bold, basic font. This is the only tattoo that has more of a personal meaning to me, but that's a way too long and boring story to explain.

What I saw was completely unexplainable to me. I have had all of my tattoos for a really long time and there had never been any issues with them. But now, regarding my pale back with all of its colorful markings in the mirror, I found that their edges were bleeding. Thick drops of red had formed on the black outlines, some had already soaked into the white fabric of my shirt.

I let out a gasp and frantically tore it off, carelessly tossing it to the ground. Bending my arms, I carefully touched the lines that were still oozing blood. To my surprise, I felt nothing. There was no pain, not even a slight sting. When I pulled back my hand, my fingers were coated with dark red.

I continued to stare at myself in the mirror. I didn't even notice my gaze becoming transfixed and the concerned voices of my co-workers slowly fading into the background. I had stopped observing my back and was just looking into my reflection's wide, disbelieving green eyes. For some reason, I got the weirdest feeling. For a split second, it was like it wasn't me I was seeing, but rather the image of a stranger, a woman unfamiliar to me. I think I looked at her for just a few seconds longer before everything around me grew black.

It was almost like last time. I was aware of the state I was in, I knew I was sleeping. I could even hear my colleagues talking somewhere in the distances, but I couldn't react to what they were saying. It was like their voices and words just flew past me. I felt weirdly entranced. I heard them call my name a couple of times. Then, they suddenly started to sound really frightened.

"What are you doing?"

Was that Maxine speaking? It was definitely one of the girls, but I couldn't tell for sure.

"What the hell...? Stop! You're hurting me!"

That sounded like Mitchell. Someone else added something in a

similarly petrified tone, but I couldn't understand them.

"I'm trying! Oh, fuck! Pull her off, help me!"

I suddenly felt myself being yanked back by my hair, a sharp pain shooting through my scalp. That must have snapped me out of it. All I knew was that all at once, everything was bright again and I was staring up at the unsettled faces of my friends.

I found myself sitting on the cold tiled floor. My co-workers were standing above me. Mitchell, who looked sort of disheveled, extended his hand to me and pulled me to my feet. I squinted. There was blood on his face.

"Your... your lip is busted," I mumbled.

He quickly wiped off the blood with the back of his hand. Him and the others exchanged uncomfortable glances. Finally, Darius cleared his throat.

"Do you know what just happened?" he asked sternly.

I frowned and shook my head.

"Leah, honey... you were standing in front of that mirror for twenty seconds. Mitchell turned you around and you just... you lunged at him," Maxine explained, her voice low and hoarse.

I stared at her in disbelief, then over at Mitchell. "I... I can't... I swear I didn't know what I was doing, I..." my voice faltered as I fumbled for words. "I'm so sorry," I added breathlessly.

Mitchell shook his head and cracked a forced smile. "Don't be, I always wanted to wrestle a topless lady," he joked. "Come on. We should get you out of here."

For the second time these last few days, it was Mitchell who drove me

home. During the car ride I sat in the back, blankly staring out the window. Mitchell glanced over to me in the rearview mirror from time to time, only to smile reassuringly everytime our eyes met.

"Caroline called her friend who's on the cleaning staff by the way," he told me after a little while. "She says they got no idea about the locked stall either. Dale never gave them a key for it or anything."

I didn't reply. I wasn't sure what to say. I just nodded slightly and turned back to face the window.

"If you ask me, there's gotta be something really insane behind that door," Mitchell went on. "Like, maybe it's a portal to hell or some shit and that's where he pulled out the not-actors. That'd be crazy, right?"

I still couldn't bring myself to answer. I could barely look him in the eyes for that matter.

Mitchell sighed. "You don't have to feel bad because of my lip or anything. Hey, maybe it'll become a scar! That'd look pretty cool, right? Like, tough."

I swallowed audibly. "Did I hurt you?" I asked. "Don't lie to me, please."

"Okay, well, it wasn't pleasant, that's for sure. And it was kinda creepy, to be honest. I could barely get you off of me. You were too strong. It was Oliver who pulled you away. If he hadn't... well, I don't know. But don't mess yourself up about it! Let's stay positive, okay?"

I sighed. "Mitchell. I think something's happening to me. I'm not sure what, or if it's just my imagination... or if I should be worried at all. But I feel like this won't end well."

Mitchell parked his car in front of my apartment building, reached for my blood-stained shirt which was lying on the passenger seat and handed it to me. "Even so, that's just all the more reason to keep investigating, right? We'll figure this out somehow."

I requested for him to come inside with me to keep me company for a little while. He thankfully complied and we spent some time watching TV together. I was glad he wasn't upset with me, but I was even more relieved that I didn't have to be alone after what had happened. I felt like crap. On top of that, I had forgotten my backpack in the park. I figured I would just have to get it back tomorrow.

Eventually, Mitchell had to leave. He once again assured me that everything was going to be alright and to call him if I needed anything. Only ten minutes after he had left, my phone rang. When I picked up, I was more than surprised to hear Dale's voice on the other end.

"Hey," he said. Nothing else, just hey.

"Hi."
An awkward pause followed before I spoke up again. "Why are you calling?"

"I was wondering if you could come over tomorrow."

"To your office?"

"No," he replied, fumbling for words before adding, "To... uh, to my place. I'll give you my address. We can drink. Or maybe we shouldn't, after what happened last time. Actually, I just want to talk."

He sounded sheepish and uncertain. I wasn't sure what exactly came over me that caused me to say yes, but well... I did.

"Good!" he sounded relieved. "Awesome. I'll see you tomorrow at... uh... how about eight? In the evening of course."

"Um, yeah. Eight's good. I'll be there."

Without losing another word, he hung up. I'm really not sure what to make of all this. I feel like things around here are getting weirder and weirder by the day. I guess I'll see how it goes

Twenty Questions

After yesterday's chaos, my time at work today was surprisingly peaceful. However the knowledge that I would be meeting my manager later on hung over me like a spectre.

On my way to the sock puppet's cage, I picked up my backpack which I had left next to the restroom's door yesterday. I by no means wanted to go in there alone, so I just hurriedly snatched it up from the ground and got on my way. After my routine with Mr Scratch, I went for the Stagecoach to see Nathan.

I have noticed that whenever I would come to visit him, he would drop his usual gloomy and grim demeanor and take on a more lively personality. I've grown very fond of him over these last few days. He's a huge motivation for me to keep doing what I'm doing, and even though he keeps denying that there's a way of saving him, I've made it clear that I won't stop trying. I brought him some candy, as always, and a book for him to entertain himself.

"You're spoiling me," he said with a grin as he unwrapped a piece of bubblegum. "No, but seriously, thanks. You don't always have to bring me stuff though, you know. I appreciate the company most."

I smiled at him before, in a more serious manner, informing him about Dale's invitation. Nathan thought for a while, pensively chewing on his gum. I looked at him attentively. Just sitting and talking to him, it's pretty obvious to me why Dale would like him so much.

Nathan might be disheveled and smelly due to him being forced to stay on the carriage, but it doesn't obscure his good looks. He is very handsome in a fragile, soft way. I know it sounds stupid but I cannot stop comparing his eyes to that of a cow. They look so gentle and soulful. Something about him makes me feel like if I touch him, he might shatter like a piece of very fine, thin glass. He's the kind of person one cannot help but feel protective of, there's no use in denying it.

I was torn back into reality by a loud pop. I flinched and Nathan grinned at me as he licked up the remains of the gum bubble which had burst

on his face. “Did that startle you?” he asked with a mischievous smirk.

“A little bit,” I admitted. “So... what do you think?”

He leaned back in his seat and sighed deeply. “If you’d asked me before this happened, I would’ve probably said there was no need to be worried. But... it happened and I’m stuck here. We both know what he did to me. I don’t know him anymore. Maybe I never did. I can’t tell if he’s gonna try and do something to you, but it’s definitely possible. Don’t be like me and let your guard down.”

I nodded. “I won’t,” I uttered dryly, staring off into the distance. “Could you do me a favor?”

“Sure,” Nathan replied, chewing with an open mouth. “What is it?”

I took the laurel, iron nail and silver earrings out of my backpack and handed them to him. “Please hold these for a little while and tell me how they feel.”

Nathan looked a bit confused but eventually nodded. He fondled the bay leaves for a bit, turning the twig to either side as if to study it. When he was done, he focused on the nail, pinching himself with it a couple times before putting it aside to examine the silver. “They’re pretty,” he said, holding up the earrings. “They look like tiny leaves. That’s cute.”

“Did any of these... hurt you in any way?” I offered.

Nathan shook his head. “No. Why would they? It’s just some twig, a nail and some earrings. Is there, like, anything special about them? Did I miss it?”

“No... no, they’re fine,” I muttered. This didn’t make any sense.

“Although... I might be reading into it too much, but when I held that twig, I kinda wanted to break it for a moment,” he added with a pensive look on his face. “Don’t ask my why, it was just like... like an instinct or

something."

At exactly eight pm, I rang the doorbell to Dale's apartment. It was in a nice, large building which in a way reminded me of my own home, except that it was way more spacious and clean. One could immediately tell whoever lived in there had money. I had taken all possible precautions. I had informed every single one of my co-workers of where I would spend my evening, bought a bottle of whiskey at the convenience store where I already got the chocolate and tobacco a few days prior and even brought my own reusable plastic cup, just in case I'd need it.

My manager opened only seconds after me ringing the doorbell, almost like he had been standing right behind the door, waiting for me to arrive. He was looking less uptight then usual. Maybe the alcohol he had quite obviously already been consuming prior to my arrival had made him loosen up a bit, but he actually greeted me with a smile.

"I can't believe you actually came," he said, sounding genuinely surprised. "I thought you'd stand me up, I really did."

"I'm a lady of honor," I replied. "I keep my promises."

He stood by and gestured for me to come in. His apartment was roomy, but kind of empty from the looks of it. Dale had always struck me as a simple guy, so it didn't come as a shock to me that he had no use for all this space. Remembering that according to Nathan they had once lived in here together, I couldn't help but wonder if it had actually felt alive and homely at some point.

Dale led me into the living room where he invited me to take a seat. I plopped down on the large, black leather couch he had pointed at, placing the whiskey I had brought on the small table in front of it.

"Hey! Awesome," Dale muttered at the sight. "I'll go get some glasses."

"You'll only need one for yourself," I stated, producing the plastic cup from my bag.

“Classy,” he commented with a smirk. He vanished into the kitchen for a few seconds before returning. “Well, I get it. You have been spending an awful lot of time with Nathan after all.”

He sat down and placed the glass he had brought on the table before, with some effort, opening my whiskey bottle. I watched attentively as he poured each of us a drink and then placed the bottle back on the table. Had he tampered with it, I would have noticed. Dale raised his glass to me before emptying it in one swift gulp.

“So, why am I here, exactly?” I inquired.

“We’re going to play a game,” he said, grabbing the bottle to refill his glass once more. “We’re going to play Twenty Questions, but I’ve changed the rules a little bit. You may ask me absolutely anything.”

My eyes widened. “Like, yes or no questions or will I be getting actual answers?”

“Depends on the question. Also, there’s another option. Can’t tell. You ask me something and I either respond with yes, no, a more detailed answer or by shaking my head. That would mean that I am unable to give you any answer at all, so it means neither yes nor no nor anything in between. Oh and by the way, the same rules apply for me. I can also ask you stuff. That clear?”

I nodded, still speechless.

“Sweet. Should we do a test round or jump right into the serious business? That’d be your chance to ask something silly.”

“Test round,” I quickly replied.

“Okay, fair. You start.”

“Oh. Alright. Uh...” my voice trailed off as I tried to think of a good first

question. This was awesome, but I had a feeling I shouldn't start with anything too heavy. Anything funny would do.

"Six inches," Dale suddenly said before taking a sip of his whiskey.

It took me a while to catch on. "Dude, I wasn't gonna ask that and you know it," I hissed. "How much did you drink already?"

"Good question," my manager muttered. "Now, to be honest, I don't know, but there's an empty wine bottle in the trash... so that should tell you quite a lot. My turn." He thought for a few seconds before asking, "Do you like Nathan?"

"Yes," I replied, nodding.

"Yeah, right. Who doesn't. Okay, should we get started for real then?"

I nodded once again and Dale motioned for me to begin. "Have you in the past or at any given point in time tried to poison me or succeeded in an attempt to do so?"

Dale smiled softly. "No," he answered.

I was a bit taken aback, but also relieved. I guess I really can't hold my liquor. Swallowing my apprehension, I uttered, "Okay... your turn."

"What's your name?"

I frowned. "Leah... you know it's Leah. Why would you ask that?"

"To check if you know. My turn. Why do you have the words No Return tattooed on your back?" I shot him a weird look, but before I could ask how he knew of my tattoo, he added, "I found an older photo of you in a bikini in a participation register for a swimming contest. I research all of my employees' backgrounds extensively. So?"

I sighed. "It's a long story..."

“The night’s young and I’ve got time, don’t make up excuses.”

“Well, alright. I used to be a complete crybaby. The tattoo is to remind me that whining is useless once a certain point has been reached. You know, how like when you’re going to ride on a rollercoaster and you don’t actually want to, but there’s people in line behind you so you just sit down in the wagon and all you can think about is how scared you are, but you can’t go back out. You’ve missed your chance to chicken out because now, the thing is starting to move. Then you realize it’s pointless to be frightened now, because now, whatever is going to happen will happen. There’s no escape, you know? No return.”

Dale was staring at me with an intensity I hadn’t thought him to be capable of. “You keep saying you, but you do mean yourself, right?” he asked in a surprisingly gentle tone. “Is that how you stopped being afraid? You were sitting in a rollercoaster wagon, knowing that you can’t stop anything from happening to you anymore, so you just decided to... enjoy the moment?”

I shrugged. “I think so. There was this feeling of inevitability, you know. Something about it was insanely thrilling. Apparently, that’s what it took for me to realize that sometimes, things that seem scary aren’t actually a threat.”

“You know it works the other way round too, right?”

For some reason, that sounded like a warning. “I do. Also, you just wasted two questions. The next thing I want to know is who forced you to poison Nathan.”

Dale stared into his glass for what seemed like an eternity before slowly shaking his head. “Can’t tell,” he said huskily.

“Okay then, next one. What’s stopping you from telling me these things?”

To this, he actually responded. “Something terrible would happen if I

did. I mean, something really, really, really bad. I can't tell you what, but you can just about guess how bad it would be."

"Bad enough to force you to poison your lover," I muttered.

Dale nodded. "My turn. Why are you so obsessed with finding out what's going on here? I mean, you could hand in your notice to quit tomorrow, get the fuck out of here and never come back."

"I'm too invested," I stated truthfully. "I want to help Nathan. I think there's a way of saving him, I can sense it. I also want to help all the others. Plus, I'm curious. I think... I think I've reached the point of no return, is what I'm saying."

"You haven't," Dale muttered sternly.

I ignored him. "So. Next one. How many people have you turned into pretenders already?"

"Just one. Just... just Nathan, no one else."

I raised a brow. I had not expected that. However, Dale wasn't done yet. "If you were to ask me how many got turned by the ones before me, the answer would be a different one."

"Yes, but I know that there's eight pretenders. So it'd be eight people, right? If we're counting the coachmen as only one person."

Dale slowly shook his head. "Can't tell," he whispered. Now I truly was beyond confused. "My turn," he added. After a short pause, he asked, "Did you notice anything changing about yourself lately?"

I nodded. "I did," I answered in a quiet voice. Dale let go of a soft sigh and for a split second, he looked like he was going to say something, but he simply motioned for me to take my turn.

"What's behind the locked door in the men's restroom on the outskirts

of Hollywood?"

Dale shook his head and took a sip of his whiskey. "Can't tell," he mouthed.

"Fine, well, how do I get in there then?"

"If I were you," he began, leaning forward and looking me in the eyes, "I'd pray it never comes to that. To be honest, I'd never thought you'd find out about it at all. Snoop around the rest of the park as much as you want, but stay the fuck away from that door. It's for your own good." In a lighter tone, he added, "Also, that was my turn just now. Let's see... is there a person in the park you really care about?"

"Yes, I mean, obviously. I care about all of my co-workers... and most of the pretenders, too."

"I see. What about the Laughing Cowboy?"

"What about him?"

"Dangit, we just wasted one question each," Dale groaned in frustration. "This is hard when you're tipsy."

"Tipsy? Dude, you were already tipsy when I got here, now you're simply hammered."

"Yeah, you're right. What I wanted to ask was... do you care about him?"

I frowned. "Weird thing to ask. Yeah, sure I do. But not any more than for the other pretenders."

"Are you lying?"

"No... I have no reason to."

Dale looked at me with narrowed eyes. "I really do think you're lying."

“Yeah, um, whatever man. That’s another question gone, by the way, so it’s my turn. Why do you never talk to Nathan? He deserves closure in my opinion.”

Dale suddenly grew very stern. “He deserves so much more than that. But see, when you’ve stolen a person’s entire life, from someone you love at that, you don’t want to think about it and you most certainly don’t want to look them in the eye. At least I don’t. He wouldn’t understand, but back then, I just, there, there...” he began to stutter and his voice trailed off. “There was no other way,” he finally whispered before raising his glass to his lips and gulping down its remaining contents. “What do you think of me?” he then asked, looking up at me with weary, bloodshot eyes.

I took a deep breath before answering. “I think you’re not what you seem. I think somewhere deep down, you’re a good person. Nevermind, scratch that. Maybe not good, but like... chaotic neutral or something. You hide behind booze, your douchey attitude and dirty jokes, but you do it all to uphold your smug, tough, devil-may-care front.” I let go of a sigh and tilted my head. “All in all, I do think you’re not a complete asshole. Even though you’re not making it easy.” I swallowed before asking my next question. “Am I right?”

Dale stared at me for a little while. “You are,” he finally said. “But you forgot something really important. I’m a guy who follows orders. Also, I’m a family man. Make of that what you will.” He straightened up in his seat. “I’m next. When looking into a mirror, is it your reflection you see or someone else’s?”

“I... uhm...” I didn’t know how to answer. I instinctively remembered the strange incident yesterday and how for a second, the reflection in that bathroom mirror had not felt like my own.

“You’re hesitating,” Dale remarked.

“It usually feels like mine, but yesterday... it was different for a moment,” I finally replied. My manager nodded. He reached out to grab the bottle,

but I quickly pulled it away from him. “Let’s take it slow for now,” I told him and to my surprise, he listened and sat back. “Why are you asking me these weird questions?” I inquired.

“To find out if it’s started yet,” he said dryly, quietly. Something in his voice sent a shiver down my spine. “It shouldn’t have,” he went on. “I did nothing to trigger it. But for some reason, you’re affected, be it only in a very subtle way. And don’t waste a question on what kind of process it is I’m talking about. You know.”

He was right. I knew.

“Am I going to be okay?” I asked, finding myself afraid of the response.

For the first time since I had met him, Dale gave me a genuinely reassuring smile. “That depends. But I’ll try my best to keep you... the way you are right now. Feel free to keep on investigating. I can assure you it’s got little to do with it.” He closed his eyes, taking some time to think. “Do you have a history of getting screwed over by people or is this the first time?” he suddenly asked very bluntly.

I flinched. “Wh-what?” I stammered. “I don’t understand...”

Dale shook his head. “Nevermind, I shouldn’t have asked that. It’s still my turn, I think. Could you give Nathan something from me? It’s... it’s his plushie. He’s had it since he was a kid and it’s still lying around here. I want him to have it back. Maybe it’ll help him feel less lonely... at the very least, it’ll stop staring at me with its hateful, accusing little eyes.”

“Sure, I’ll bring him the plushie,” I said, unable to suppress a slight smile.

Dale got up and walked over to the pantry, returning with a stuffed stork which he threw at me. I caught it mid-air and he sat back down. I admit I was a bit worried. He had seemed rather wobbly on his feet.

“Why are you helping me all of a sudden?”

“Isn’t it obvious? It’s about Nathan. As unlikely as it seems, you might find a way to release him. After all, you did find out about the restroom. Who knows what you can do? I’m unable to help in any way. As I said, stuff will happen if I try. But you... you’re not bound by anything. I watch him, you know, and I see you when you come to visit him. Whatever it is you’re doing... I think it’s working. At least one thing’s for sure. The more you know, the more confident you are that there’s a way of saving him, and this confidence is what makes him happy. So please, for the love of god, keep it up.”

This had caught me off guard. I stared at him with wide, incredulous eyes. “How do I know I can trust you?”

“You don’t. Still, I hope you will. It’ll be much easier for both of us. Also, you’ve got only four questions left. Can you try to use them a little more wisely?”

I nodded and bit my lip. “Who was standing behind me on Halloween night last year?” I uttered, holding his gaze expectantly.

“Upper management,” Dale said with a dry chuckle.

“We who now claim ownership of this land are aware of and willing to pay the price. What does that mean?”

“I... I can’t tell you exactly. But it means I have to obey. It means everyone in my family has to.”

“Is there something in the park I should be particularly scared of, that I should avoid?” My voice had grown low with nervousness.

“There is, but I can’t tell you what.”

Suddenly, I noticed something weird. “Why are we even playing this game? I mean, you could just answer my questions the normal way.”
“Upper management would know. I’m not sure how, but they always know what I’m doing. They’re watching me when they think I might do

something stupid. But for some reason, the concept of games is beyond them. When I say that something's just a game they'll think nothing of it. That's because everything that can be said in a game could simply be a lie. Half-truths and lies confuse them, so... yeah. I still have to be careful though, that's why I can't answer all of your questions."

My last question. "Is there anything else you think might help me? Like, some useful piece of advice?"

Dale gave me a thin smile. "Iron, laurel, silver, sage, salt and red verbena. Those are your best friends."

We continued to stare at one another for a little while before my manager spoke up once again. "You seemed to be really into this, so I didn't wanna interrupt you, but I've got like five more questions. There isn't a lot I want to know though. Just one thing." He paused and I tilted my head.

"What is it?" I breathed.

Dale had taken his empty glass and was now fumbling around with it, tracing its brim with the tips of his fingers. It was almost hypnotic.

He finally looked up at me and asked in a slow, empty tone: "Do you know that you're being watched whenever you're at the park?"

I didn't know how to respond. I stared at him in shock and confusion before finally regaining my composure. Surely, being watched was not the most absurd thing out of everything I knew happened around the park. So why was I so unsettled by that thought?

"I see," Dale finally said. My reaction had apparently been enough of an answer. Suddenly, he grew very silent. His expression darkened. He murmured something about excusing himself to go to the bathroom. I merely nodded and stayed in my seat.

I remember thinking that he sure was taking some time. Then, only

seconds after I had finished that thought, I heard the gunshot.

The moment the sound pierced my ears, I entered a weird, surprisingly controlled state of panic. I was scared shitless, but I wasn't frozen in place. I shot up and ran to the door I had seen Dale enter only a few minutes ago. I tore it open and found my manager cowering on the floor inside, a gun lying next to him. He was bleeding from his upper arm and pressing his hand on the wound, his face contorted in agony.

"What did you do?" I shouted, rushing up to him and heaving him to his feet. He was heavy and I had trouble holding him upright, but at least he didn't fight it. "Holy shit! Fuck! Where's your car keys? We need to get you to a hospital!"

Dale groaned in pain, but vehemently shook his head. "No! No hospital... my parents will freak out if they find out about this... please, just... take me into the living room."

I complied and carefully walked him over to the couch. He slowly lowered himself down on it.

"What the hell was that just now?" I hissed. My hands were coated in his blood and I was shaking. I hated Dale a little for being so calm.

"I'll... I'll explain later... you've got to help me take off my shirt, I need to check if the bullet's stuck in my arm."

I shook my head in disbelief, but eventually assisted Dale in pulling his long-sleeved cotton shirt over his head. The moment it came off and revealed his upper body though, I couldn't help but let out a sharp scream.

The skin of his chest, left arm and stomach were covered in large, long cuts in various stages of healing. Some were fresh, red and scabby, others looked like they had already healed years ago as there were nothing but thin, white scars left of them. The gashes even overlapped in several places. Still, the words they were forming were legible. It was the same

sentence, carved into his flesh over and over again.

My name is Dale.

He looked up at me with glazed, hooded eyes. “In case I forget,” he mouthed.

The rest of the night pased in a bit of a daze. I found that the bullet in fact wasn’t stuck in his arm, for it had only grazed him. I later discovered it stuck in one of the bathroom walls. He told me where I could find his first aid kit and I spent about fifteen minutes carefully bandaging his arm.

When I asked him why he had wounded himself, he told me he didn’t know. Apparently he had lost control over his body in front of the mirror for a second, and the next thing he had known was that he had a bullet wound in his arm, presumably having acquired the gun from its usual spot in the dresser outside the bathroom door. He seemed disturbingly unfazed by this and when I asked him why, he said something about how this happened quite a lot amongst members of his family.

He had returned to his quiet former self, the talkative Dale from earlier having vanished. I asked if it was “upper management” who did this to him, but he just chuckled dryly without giving any definitive answer. I urged him to at least see a doctor in the morning to which he thankfully, albeit reluctantly, complied. I really hope he’s going to be alright until then.

According to Dale, this had only happened to him once before, namely when he had lost control at the age of sixteen and ended up stabbing his hand with a fork. I wonder if these fits are a way of “upper management” to punish people whenever they’re giving out too much information about them. Whatever these beings are that are controlling him and his family, they have to be pretty damn sadistic to do this to them.

I waited until Dale went to sleep before getting on my way home, not before taking another look at his arm though. To my relief, we found that

the bleeding had stopped. We had agreed that I would take the gun with me and return it to him at the park the following day so he could keep it in his office for emergencies. He said he really didn't want it around his home for a couple days, which I found perfectly understandable.

Before I left however, Dale told me one last thing. "Check the dresser in the hallway. There's a present for you in there," he mumbled into his pillow. "I want you to have it."

"What is it?" I inquired.

"You'll know it when you see it. You've seen it before, I know you have..." He paused to let out a yawn before adding drowsily, "Little birdie told me."

I did as he told me. At first, I couldn't spot anything familiar in any of the drawers, until I came across a certain object lying on top a bunch of magazines in the lowermost one. It was the old, wood-handled revolver.

I had arranged with Mitchell to pick me up after two hours. I had figured that would be enough and it turns out, I was right. When I stepped outside Dale's apartment building, I found his car parked right in front of it on the sidewalk. I got in and plopped down on the passenger seat, sinking into the cushions with a deep sigh.

"Your ride's been awaiting, milady," my colleague greeted me jokingly. "I was getting a bit worried already. Seriously, I'm basically your personal chauffeur at this point." He instantly fell silent when he laid eyes on the red stain on my shirt. "Holy shit... what happened, are you alright?"

"It's not my blood," I explained. "Before you ask, Dale's fine as well. Okay, maybe not entirely, but that's not 'cause of me."

I was too tired to explain everything that had happened to him in detail, but I gave him a vague run-down of what had happened. Mitchell's main concern was whether I was feeling okay after all this stress, but I assured him that I was alright and that my manager was the one to

worry about. I didn't tell him about Dale's gift or Nathan's stuffed animal though. Perhaps it was because I was too exhausted, or maybe I simply wasn't in the mood to hear his opinion.

In hindsight, I would have loved to ask Dale so many other questions. It feels just like taking a test, the best things always coming to mind when it's already over. Maybe I'll get another chance to ask him these things on a different occasion. Then again, who knows if he'll answer. Either way, I returned home with a borrowed gun, a stork plushie and the mysterious ornate revolver. I think I've never gotten this much out of any of my interactions with my manager before.

connections

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. After I acquired a certain revolver from Dale yesterday, I spent the remainder of the night staring at it. I played around with it a little, harmlessly imitating some rather cool Western scenes. I admit that didn't help me making any sense of it though.

Either way, when I finally went to bed, I took it with me and placed it on my nightstand. For some reason, I felt like I wanted to keep it close to me.

The revolver has a standard six slot cylinder. When I checked it, I found that there were five rounds in it. This was unsurprising seeing as back in the day, cowboys wouldn't load them fully. From what I know due to my extensive "research", and by that I mean hours and hours of watching Westerns, that is because these early revolvers did not have any safety mechanisms and their hammers would always be resting with the striking pin right on the cartridge.

This meant that a small bump on the hammer would be sufficient to trigger an accidental shot. If one chamber is left empty though, it can be turned to be right in front of the hammer, avoiding the revolver firing on accident. Other than that, I found the adornments in its handle to be quite intriguing as well. While most of them seemed to only serve aesthetic purposes, I also discovered the letters C and M carved into the shiny, polished wood.

I figured they must be its former owner's initials. The only person I know with their last name to start with an M is Dale, but of course I won't say his full name on here. This led me to believe that the revolver must have once belonged to one of his ancestors. I imagine it was handed down over the generations, but for it to be such a valuable heirloom, he sure was suspiciously eager to get rid of it.

Whether he gave it to me as a means of protecting myself against "upper management" or with some other hidden intention is beyond me, but I guess I have enough time to find out. After all, Dale and I are now officially on the same side, even though I admit that that gets me

thinking: If him and I are in the same boat, then who's in the other one?

The more I keep thinking about it, the more it confuses me. I believe I should really focus on the facts.

The first thing I did after getting up this morning was to gather the items Dale had advised me to keep on my person. Iron, laurel, silver, sage, salt and red verbena. Now, I'm not stupid. I am well aware that all of these items hold supernatural meaning. I myself barely have any clue about the occult, but the great thing about having a lot of friends and acquaintances is that there's always this one person who's got just the thing you need.

In my case, this person's name is Clara. Clara and I met in high school. We used to be pretty close back then and I helped her study from time to time, an act of cordiality she apparently never forgot. When I called her this morning to ask if she could hook me up with some things I needed, she was more than happy to help. Clara has practiced paganism for a long time now, and if there's one person who I know will take me serious when showing up on their doorstep asking for sage and red fucking verbena, it's her.

Long story short, I drove over to her place, we had breakfast together and enjoyed some small talk before cutting to the chase. She disappeared into her bedroom for a few minutes before returning with a satchel, a weird looking bundle and a small jewelry box. She placed the three items on the table in front of us and sat down next to me.

"Okay, first things first," she began, picking up the small bundle and holding it out to me. "This is sage. It's mostly used for cleansing rituals, basically the go-to thing if you want to rid a place of negative energy."

"And how do I do that? Do I just... leave it there or...?"

Clara chuckled and shook her head. "You burn it, silly. Next up," she held up the satchel, "red verbena. Freshly picked from the pots on my balcony. It offers protection from the evil eye."

Whatever that is, I added in my mind. “What’s in the jewelry box?” I inquired.

Clara smiled mysteriously. “I’m glad you asked. See, when you mentioned the silver and iron thing, it reminded me of a certain accessoire I’ve had lying around here for ages.” She picked up the box and opened it to produce a shiny, ornate necklace with a heart-shaped locket attached to it. “Now, the chain itself is iron, but the locket is silver. Great for protection, but sadly not my style, which is why I’ve decided that you may have it. You seem to need it more than I do after all.”

“For real?” I asked, taking the necklace and carefully opening and closing its locket.

“Yup! But the best is yet to come.” My friend opened the satchel and took out a couple of bright red blossoms which she stuffed into the silver locket. She motioned for me to turn around and went about fixing the piece of jewelry around my neck. “This way, you’ll have some silver, iron and red verbena with you wherever you go!”

I smiled at her. “Thank you so much... I don’t know what to say.”

“Then shut up!” she replied and we started giggling and high-fived. We had made this joke all the time back in our school days.

“About the salt, you can simply use your own. You know, plain salt you use for cooking, it’ll do. I don’t have any bay laurel around, but I know that when burned, it’s good for cleansing and purification rituals. Also, it’s known to be useful for breaking curses and hexes,” she explained.

I thanked her once again and got ready to leave, but she held me back. “One more thing. So, if I got it right, you don’t know what you’re dealing with here, but you do know the means of protecting yourself from it. Of course, I’m not in your place and you should always proceed with an open mind, but you should probably know that... iron and red verbena are specifically linked to the fae. They repel faeriefolk.”

Clara gave me a moment to process her words before continuing. “Most say that they dislike iron because it’s a material forged by humans while faeries themselves are creatures of nature, but I’ve also heard of another belief claiming that the faeries once made a deal with the iron and didn’t hold up their end of the bargain, so the iron is still angry with them. Who knows. My point is that what you’re describing sounds an awful lot like them.”

“Alright... do faeries not understand games and half-truths by any chance?”

Clara frowned. “No. Actually, they’re known to be tricksters. You’ve got to be crazy careful when talking to them since they tend to play around with exact wording and stuff to screw you over. It’s very important not to offend them. They’re spiteful little...” she lowered her voice, “bastards. You never know when they might be listening.”

“Now you’re just trying to scare me.”

Clara winked and opened the door for me, seeing me out. “You should come back sometime to chat some more,” she called after me cheerfully and I gave an affirmative thumbs-up as I ventured down the stairs in her apartment building’s hallway.

My next stop was once again my neighbor’s place. The elderly lady opened the door for me with a knowing smile. “Well, if it isn’t Leah. Need some more laurel?” she offered with a grin.

“Yes, actually I’ve been thinking... could I buy one of your potted bays maybe?” I inquired, fumbling for my wallet.

The lady was a bit taken aback, but willingly went for her living room and came back with a small laurel tree in a pot. She had some trouble dragging it to the doorstep, so I quickly took it from her, lifting it up with ease. I gave her thirty bucks for it. She had only asked for ten, but I told her I had to make up for all the inconveniences my pestering for twigs had caused her these last few days.

Later, I covered up every mirror in my house either by removing them and turning them around or by cloaking them with bedsheets and the like. My reasoning behind this is that whatever came over me in that restroom happened after I was staring at my reflection for too long, so I should probably avoid seeing it for a little while. Normally, I'd think that what happens in the park stays there, but after the incident with Dale yesterday, who says that upper management isn't able to influence me at any given time and place?

I went to work today wearing the verbena locket, my backpack filled with iron nails, bay laurel and cooking salt I had refilled into a small jar. There was one more thing I did though before getting on my way: I called Anne.

She greeted me as cheerfully as ever, as if the creepy bathroom incident had never taken place. "Hi! How are you doing? Still violent?"

I grinned. "No, no, I'm fine. Hey, is there any chance I could see the Mime today?"

"Ah, sorry, but I'm not in today. I'm at my mom's, it's her birthday... but I'd gladly get you to him tomorrow!"

I told her that would probably do and thanked her, figuring I'd focus on the Aged Diva and the Pianist for the time being. I was less than willing to face the Mime by myself, but the pretenders from the Hollywood section aren't nearly as threatening in my opinion.

I got to the park at around eleven. After minding the sock puppet, I went back for Hollywood. I had never really noticed how creepy it looked with nobody on the streets. The only sound that broke the silence was the quiet melody of the piano, which grew louder and louder the closer I got to the restaurant the Pianist resides in. Looking in through the building's glass front however, I stopped in my tracks. I could not only see the man in the white tuxedo sitting on his stool as usual, there was also another pretender present. The Aged Diva.

I had never seen the two of them so close to one another before. The woman was elegantly leaning against the piano, cigarette in hand, watching her companion play. To my surprise, he wasn't completely ignoring her either, in fact, he would glance up at her with a smile from time to time. I squinted. This was very unusual. They looked so natural together, almost like they were two normal people interacting. But even more interestingly, they looked like they knew each other.

If I'm correct in my assumption that all the not-actors used to be human at some point, then these two must have had a shared past. This got me thinking. If the Pianist knew the Diva and the Diva knew the Laughing Cowboy, would that mean that all of the pretenders' lives used to be connected in some way?

I decided to think about it later. For now, it would be best to take this opportunity and talk to them. If you can call that talking, that is.

I pushed open the door and stepped inside, causing the elderly lady to whirl around. The Pianist however didn't even look up at me.

"Um... hello," I greeted them awkwardly. "Sir... and ma'am."

The Diva caught herself pretty quickly and straightened up. "Why hello, darling! So nice of you to come by and visit us," she said in her usual, exaggerated manner.

"Us?" I inquired. Her usage of this word had immediately struck me as off. Us.

She tilted her head, ignoring my question. "Won't you sit with me?" she offered, pointing at a table nearby.

"Gladly," I replied, sliding onto the bench and waiting for her to sit down across from me. Opening my backpack, I took out the iron nail and held it out for her. I'm not sure what I was expecting, but she simply took it out of my hand and inspected it for a while before giving it back to me. She didn't say a word, just kept smiling. I cleared my throat. "Anything

weird about that nail?" I offered.

The Diva looked at me like I was stupid. "Why, is there?" she asked.

I shook my head. "Uh... no." Seeing as I already knew how she reacted to the bay leaves, I handed her the silver earrings. She seemed to like them a lot better, holding them up against the early noon sunlight streaming in through the window.

"Why, aren't they lovely! You sure have a good taste in fashion, dearie," she praised me before dropping them into my hollow hand again.

Well, that was underwhelming, I thought, but decided to simply move on to the Pianist. He didn't react to any of the items except for the laurel twig. When I held it out to him, he promptly turned in his seat. He kept playing the piano eagerly, but leaned away as far from the bay leaves as he could. It was sort of entertaining and I couldn't help but play around with this effect a little, sticking the twig out to him from either side just to see how far he could lean over without ceasing to play.

I finally decided that enough was enough and put the laurel twig away. I wasn't ready to leave though. It was weird how aware the two had seemed of one another when they had been by themselves. So I asked, "Not to be intrusive, but are you two together or something?"

The Pianist didn't react, but the Aged Diva instantly looked up. She opened her mouth as if to say something, but the only thing that escaped her lips was a dry, throaty choking noise.

"We..." she cawed, before suddenly throwing her head back and gagging. "We..." she pressed out, "dear... ie..."

I took a step back. I hadn't seen her like this before. "What's... happening to you?" I stammered, unsure of what to do. Normally, her face would melt off, that I was used to. But this?

I was almost relieved when I saw her wrinkled skin slowly flow

downwards, her scalp following soon after. Then a loud pop, and she was gone. I stared in shock at the glittering spot where she had just been standing. It was like she had been trying to tell me something this time. I shuddered and backed out of the restaurant, for some reason not daring to take my eyes off the Pianist. For a split second, I thought I could see something glinting in the corner of his eye.

I made my way over to Dale's office. I wasn't sure if he was in already, but to my surprise, I found him leaning against its door from outside, sipping from a bottle of what looked to be ice tea.

"There you are," he greeted me, cracking me a half-hearted smile. "Took you long enough."

"It's good to see you too, Dale."

"Right. Hey, now that we're best friends and all that shit, there's one more thing I wanna show you," he explained. "Um... before you give me back my gun," he quickly added.

I nodded and he came a bit closer to me. He sat down his water bottle and pulled up his left sleeve. There was another carving in his lower arm. This one wasn't as deep as the My name is Dale ones though. It looked to be pretty fresh, there was even a bit of blood dripping from one of the cuts.

3/8.

"Three out of -" I was just about to say it out loud, but before I knew it, Dale was pressing his hand onto my mouth.

"Ssh!" he hissed. "Will you shut your ass up? Fucking hell."

"Sorry," I mumbled into his palm. He rolled his eyes and slowly removed it from my lips. "But what does it mean?" I asked under my breath.

Dale motioned for me to stay quiet. "Can't tell. All I want you to know is

that you need to keep your mind, like, wide open. Don't generalize, stick to what you know. And be careful. I can't believe I'm saying this but..." he paused to let go of a soft sigh. He looked genuinely worried. "I'd hate for you to get hurt."

Suddenly, he began to fumble in his pocket only to produce his keys. His eyes had become glazed and empty and I watched in shock as he proceeded to lift the sharp object and slam it down onto his left palm with such force that it pierced the flesh. He regained conciousness soon after, told me to leave him alone and that he would take care of it.

After this rather bizarre conversation, I gave him back his gun and went for the last thing on my to-do list for the day.

I found Nathan slumped over in his coachseat, fast asleep. The horses were calmly standing in the shade of the entrance to the wooden rollercoaster in Twin Vale Point. I swung myself onto the seat next to him and quietly said his name in an attempt to wake him up, but was unable to receive any reaction apart from the occasional snore.

He looked peaceful and I didn't really want to startle him, so I merely took the stork plushie out of my backpack and placed it in his lap, right next to where his hands were resting. To my surprise, his fingers almost immediately curled around it. I couldn't help but smile at the sight.

the thing about iron

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. I arranged a meeting with the Mime yesterday, under my friend and co-worker Anne's supervision.

When I entered the park this morning, I wasn't sure where this would get me except maybe to a hospital, but one thing was for certain: I was already scared shitless before I even entered the park.

I had to delay my routine with Mr Scratch seeing as I had told Anne I would meet her at nine. I arrived at the park at eight thirty, but I knew that the sock puppet would keep me occupied for well over an hour. Therefore I decided to visit Nathan again.

He was just driving by the entrance to Twin Vale Point when I reached the western town, but stopped the carriage as soon as I came into sight. How times change... He looked rather upbeat and happy to see me and when I approached him, he held out his hand for me to climb aboard. Once I had sat down next to him, I immediately spotted the stork plushie's head peeking out from under the collar of his shirt.

"So I won't lose it," Nathan explained curtly. "Hey, uhm... thanks for bringing it by. I like it a lot. It's... uh..." his voice trailed off and he blushed.

"It's your stork, I get it. Dude, I keep a bunny plush in bed with me, I ain't judging you." I grinned. "By the way, why were you asleep yesterday? I thought you didn't need to do that anymore."

"I do it quite a lot actually. Not because I'm tired but, like, whenever I feel bored or numb, I make myself fall asleep to... you know. Get away from it all for a bit. Sometimes I even have dreams in which I'm not stuck. I love having dreams," he muttered.

"It's like eating candy then?" I inquired.

"Yeah. Kinda like that. I'm really surprised Dale gave you the plush by the way. I thought he'd... I don't know. I thought he'd have thrown it away by now." He suddenly sounded very gloomy again.

“Nathan... I think Dale loves you. I believe he’s never stopped loving you. He knows you’re suffering and it’s killing him, inside and out. I’m still trying to find out what made him do this, but I can assure you that he did not want it to be this way. Maybe I’m just a hopeless romantic, but I refuse to believe he doesn’t care about you.”

“Yeah, I mean... I guess. But, like, life goes on, right? Life goes on for everyone except me. The thing is, nobody outside of this park cares for me, and inside the park... who is there really except you? Even if Dale cares, he doesn’t show it. One day, you’ll probably be gone and I will still be here. And then no one will be left at all.”

“Don’t you have, like, family or something outside the park who miss you?” I asked.

Nathan grunted and shot me a grim glance. “My parents stopped giving a shit about me when they caught me making out with my quote unquote best buddy. That was long before Dale. They kinda threw me out. I mean, I managed on my own, but... you get what I’m saying. My folks wouldn’t care if I was dead in a ditch. That leaves only you and storkie here in my boat.”

As sad as this was, there was no way of proving him wrong. It made sense and even though the thought was incredibly depressing, I could see where he was coming from. Still, I assured him I wouldn’t let it come to that. I wouldn’t let him die alone.

Soon after, I went to meet with Anne. She was waiting by the entrance to the candyland. She looked very casual in her baggy shirt and sweatpants, her black hair up in a loose bun. She’s right though, why bother with clothes if no one’s gonna see you anyways?

“Good morning,” she greeted me with a happy smile, immediately going in for a hug, squeezing me way too hard. “Aw, it’s been so long since we last had some time to talk! Like, without the others around. I was totally gonna tell you about this cute guy I met a few days ago, but I didn’t because seriously, I do not want Mitchell or Oliver knowing.” She let go

of me and grinned. “Those two are je-erks!” she added in a sing-songy voice. “I just now they’ll talk their asses off behind my back. Like two old ladies.”

“If you say so,” I offered with a helpless smile.

“So, why do you wanna meet the Mime anyway?” Anne asked. “I thought he scared you.”

“He does, he totally does. But he’s kinda special and I wanna see if I can get something useful out of him. He seems to be smart, so... I don’t know. Can’t hurt to face your fears.” I grinned, trying not to look as nervous as I actually was.

“You’re so brave,” Anne praised me jokingly, pulling on my ponytail. “I like the new necklace by the way.”

My fingers instinctively wandered to my neck to touch the silver locket. “Thanks,” I muttered. “I got it from a friend.”

“Okay, listen. There’s a small problem here. To talk to the Mime, we need to find him first and if I’m being honest, I don’t know where he hangs out these days,” Anne explained apologetically, letting her gaze travel over our surroundings.

“I saw him near the Sugar Plum Fairy’s stage the other day,” I remarked.

We agreed to go and look there first, but to our disappointment, the only thing we found was the young girl herself, dancing undeterredly as always. Anne suggested we should split up, but I reminded her of the last time we had done so and how well that had worked out for us. We began to search each of the rides in the candy section.

I believe I’ve mentioned before that this section caters mainly to children. This means that most of the rides here are pretty small and cutesy as well, but also that there’s more of them than in the other sections. We checked each of the rides’ entrances as well as the empty wagons waiting

in vain to be set into motion, but we couldn't find him anywhere. That was until Anne suddenly tapped me on the shoulder and pointed at the large chain carousel ahead of us.

"Look," she whispered, "there he is!"

She was right. The Mime was hanging on the chain of one of the swing seats upside down, his neck craned and his eyes transfixed on us. He was watching.

"Okay, so... how do we get him down there?" my friend asked quietly.

"I'm just gonna go up to him. Try to reason with him, you know," I replied in an equally low voice and Anne nodded. "You're coming with me though, right? He likes you way better than me."

"Sure," she muttered.

We slowly, carefully began approaching the swing, gazes fixated on the pretender. However as soon as we reached the swing he was hanging from, he let out a low hiss and scurried further up the chain.

"Wait! Please," I called out, raising my hands.

"Yeah, can we, like, talk? Maybe?" Anne asked.

The Mime however didn't react. He only continued to cling onto the chain, staring at us with narrow, menacing eyes. His lips parted slowly, and the corners of his mouth were pushed up by the spider-like like fangs protruding from it. The sight sent a chill down my spine.

"Remind me why you're so fond of this monstrosity," I whispered and Anne shrugged.

"Look, I'd really like for you to help us out here," she pleaded with the pretender.
The Mime remained in place, hovering several feet above us. His fangs

almost seemed to glisten in the sunlight. Thick drops of saliva were dripping down from them, silently hitting the ground to our feet. Then, ever so slowly, he began to descend. His hands reached out to grab onto the chain below him again and again, his clawed fingers tightening around it with an unsettling skillfulness as he climbed down. Bit by bit, he got closer to the ground until he finally swung himself off the chain and stood in front of us.

I held my breath. It looked unnatural, seeing him stand upright with his fangs showing. I regarded him attentively, almost expecting him to get down on all fours and lunge at us or scuttle away again. Anne however seemed less alert.

"Thank you," she said, smiling brightly at the not-actor.

I couldn't tear my eyes off of his painted face, this surreal, never-fading smile plastered across his already contorted expression, the chalk-white skin and the large dots below his eyes. Anne nudged me in the side and I finally caught myself again. What did I want to ask him anyways? I suddenly couldn't remember. Why was I doing this? My heart was hammering in my chest. I admit that for a moment, I just wanted to run.

Instead I took a deep, shaky breath and shrugged off my backpack. Without breaking the pretender's gaze, I opened it and began to fumble for any of the items I had taken with me. My fingers cramped around the first thing they met with. The iron nail. I pulled it out and held it out for the Mime to see.

I'm not sure what I was expecting, but what followed was most certainly not it. The not-actor instantly backed off and opened his mouth to let out a startled hiss that quickly took on a threatening tone. Gripped by a sudden boldness, I took a step forward, attempting to prick him with the nail. He instantly fell silent and let out a whimper of fear as the nail only missed his arm by a few inches.

He leapt up, grabbing the chain of another one of the swing seats and hurriedly started climbing upwards. When he had brought a safe

distance between himself and the iron nail, he stared down at us with a panicked malice like a cornered animal. Anne shot me disapproving look while I was still standing there, completely speechless.

"What the hell was that for?" she asked angrily. "You scared the shit out of the poor guy!"

I turned to her, eyes wide. "He's afraid of the iron," I uttered breathlessly. "Anne, do you know what that means?"

She frowned in confusion and I shook my head before turning around and dashing off. I just wanted to get away, back home where there were no Mimes. My head was spinning, trying to process this new discovery. The Mime isn't like the rest of them, he never had been. Was this what Dale had meant when he had told me not to generalize? I passed by the cage of the sock puppet and immediately halted in my tracks. Sometimes, I feel like I get so caught up in trying to figure this thing out that I forget I have an actual responsibility here.

Mr Scratch was idly lying in front of his shelter on the naked ground. When I turned and walked back up to him, he lifted his head at me, only to let in sink again right away, as if to convey his disapproval of me almost forgetting about him. I plopped down next to him and began running my fingers through his fur. It felt comforting. I slowly started to regain my composure, my mind stopped racing and I was once again thinking a bit clearer.

I let go of a soft sigh as I buried my face in his warm, fluffy neck. Suddenly, I noticed a shadow out of the corner of my eye, like that of someone standing behind me. I straightened up and turned around, half expecting it to be my manager, but to my surprise found the Laughing Cowboy towering over me. He looked me up and down before holding out his hand to me. I swallowed, then slowly laid my fingers into his palm and let him pull me to my feet.

"Long time no see," I stammered.

He nodded, but there was no smile on his lips. He seemed unusually stern. I took a tiny step towards him, but he instantly backed off. I tilted my head. "Are you alright?" I asked. "I... uh... didn't expect to meet you here. Is this part of the park making you uncomfortable or something?"

No reaction. I bit my lip. This was starting to unsettle me. Then I remembered something. I bent down and picked up my backpack, opening it to produce the old, wood-handled revolver.

"Is... is this yours?" I uttered, holding it out for him to see.

He stared at it for a moment, his eyes widening and darting from me to the revolver resting in my palm, then back to me. He seemed apprehensive, or perhaps even... afraid. I took a deep breath and, in a shaky voice, asked, "Did someone hurt you with this?"
He opened his mouth and I could see his black tongue nervously licking over his teeth. His gaze was now fixed onto the weapon. He stood as still as a statue for around five seconds, then he suddenly spun around and took off.

"Wait!" I called after him. "I wasn't gonna hurt you!"

I quickly shoved the gun back into my backpack before sprinting after him. I felt genuinely terrible. I had not meant to upset him in any way, I hadn't expected him to react like this. He was running towards the entrance to Twin Vale Point. I tried to follow him, but suddenly became aware of the agonizing pain in my side. Against my every urge, I had to stop chasing after him. I was left standing alone in the middle of the street, my hand pressed against my side, trying to suppress the stinging. I swear, this job is going to drive me crazy some day.

I called Mitchell to let him know that I had upset his not-actor. He told me it was probably no big deal and that he would take care of it once he would return to the park the next day. Afterwards, I went about the rest of my duties with Mr Scratch and then returned home sometime in the afternoon.

I'm wondering if the Mime is a faerie. It sure would fit in my opinion, with the fear of iron and his irritability and all. I mean, there has to be a reason for him acting so vastly different from the other not-actors. Then again, I always imagined the fair folk to be... less animalistic, if that makes sense.

I'm also starting to believe that their response to iron truly is what differentiates the pretenders from one another, even though I'm still not sure of how to interpret this aspect. A little later in the evening, I got a text from my manager.

It read, "Hi." Nothing else, just hi. I don't think I'll ever get used to this casual tone we have newly adopted.

"Hi back," I responded. "What's up?"

"Not much. Just wanted to know if you figured out that pretenders aren't actually a monolith already."

"Is this about the Mime? I don't think I understand yet," I texted back.

The messenger displayed him typing for about five minutes straight, but when he finally responded again, he just did so with one of these emojis that roll their eyes. "You better start making sense of it then. There's only so many hints I can give you and that limit's been reached for today, I think." His text was followed by an image of his open mouth. I grimaced when I noticed that his tongue was bleeding.

I don't really want any more clues from Dale. If I don't figure this out on my own, who knows what they'll have him do to himself next. The poor guy is enough of a threat to himself as it is. I need to speed this up somehow. The prospect of maybe having to get even closer to the not-actors frightens me, but then again, I've got my necklace, my whip and my revolver, so what's the worst thing that can happen to me?

This sort of makes me wonder. I mean, for real, what is the worst thing that could happen?

I got fired

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. Ever since my interaction with the Mime yesterday, I haven't stopped wondering about what sets the not-actors apart from one another.

After a while, the numbers scratched into Dale's skin came back to me. 3/8. I have started to believe that three is the number of pretenders, of actual pretenders, that is. Those who react to iron. I'm not sure what exactly that means in regards to upper management since I can hardly imagine the Mime being part of it, but if my theory is correct, that means that there are two more of them.

I didn't know what I would achieve by figuring out which ones are which, but I was sure it would help somehow. The whole iron-thing would indicate that contrary to my former belief, not all of the not-actors used to be humans who got turned. I think that some of them, the three in question, are and always have been of another nature, that they never were human to begin with. It still feels weird to type it out, but I guess that would make them faeries, or maybe something different yet.

That's at least what I was thinking before my conversation with Dale at work today. Not that it would matter anymore. But first things first.

The dancing squid-beaked girl, the Sugar Plum Fairy, was named after the ballet dance by Tschaikowsky. This is something that Maxine told me when we first met. She also confided in me that she had never met her former handler. To this day, she doesn't know anything about them. This greatly unsettles both of us, seeing as even though they could of course have merely quit or gotten fired, it's well possible that they didn't make it. Thinking back to what happened to Joshua, it's more than likely that a creature as aggressive as the fairy might have gotten rid of her pesky actor entirely.

I believe I mentioned that Maxine and I were looking for a new enclosure for the Sugar Plum Fairy a while ago. Mitchell's dad, his name is Mike by the way, met with us today to seal the deal about the trailer he had

been offering us. We inspected it and it really is very nice and spacious, as well as a lot more modern than that old shack she currently lives in. It offers enough room for her to move about and dance whenever she wants to.

We transported the trailer to the park with the help of both Mitchell and his father. Once we were there, Dale did as promised and paid his part of the price for the enclosure, Maxine and I covering the rest. After Mike had left and we had set up the fairy's new home in the back of the candy-section, the four of us began to discuss how we should rehouse the not-actor.

On a side note, I truly admire how Dale can keep up his douchy act in front of my colleagues. You wouldn't think the two of us had ever talked privately from the way he treats me when we're not alone. I think the correct word is... aloof. Then again, I did catch him smirk at me when we were installing the lock on the door of the new trailer and Mitchell ever so gracefully managed to trip over the entrance step. I guess it's not much of a surprise though. If I were Dale, I'd probably want to uphold my reputation as well.

"We should take things slow," Mitchell suggested. "Let's give her the time she needs. She'll come around sooner or later."

"Nonsense," Maxine replied, shaking her head. "She's been on that stage dancing for the last three weeks." She paused to think for a second. "Actually, I think it's been even longer than that. Well, my point is that she's not going to get curious about the trailer, like, ever. We have to introduce her to it somehow. I mean, if she doesn't learn that it's better than the old one, what's the point?"

"Maybe we should capture her and lock her in for, like, a day or two. She'll notice eventually that it isn't so bad and then she'll get used to it. We just need to... you know. Push things a bit," I explained, looking at my co-workers faces expectantly.

"Sounds good," Dale said.

“You think we can do it?” I asked.

My manager chuckled and shook his head. “Hell no, but it’s gonna be fun watching you three get chased by Madame Squidbeak. So do go ahead.”

“Actually, I think Leah’s right. It’ll be hard catching her, but... we’ve done it before. We’ll manage,” Maxine said, sounding affirmative.

Dale shrugged. “Hey, this was your braindead idea, I’ll stay out of it. You ladies can do whatever you think works, but... uh... just try not to make too big of a mess, okay? I don’t really want to bother the cleaning staff at the moment, they’re probably at home enjoying their leave. They won’t wanna deal with your guts all over the place,” he explained casually. I knew he was exaggerating.

“You’re just trying to scare us,” Mitchell remarked coldly.

Dale laughed and patted him on the back. “Of course I am!” Then, just before turning to leave, he added, “Or am I...?” We heard him giggle to himself as he walked off.

“Ugh. I know Dale’s just being a dick, but he got me,” Maxine admitted, shuddering. “Kinda makes me wonder what happened to my predecessor.”
“Don’t worry about it. Let’s just try and figure out how to go about this,” I told her, squeezing her shoulder reassuringly.

The three of us made our way over to the Sugar Plum Fairy’s stage. She was dancing as raptly as ever, not paying us onlookers any mind. We stood and stared at her for a little while, each of us contemplating about the best way to get her down there and into her new home.

“It’d be best if we could lure her away somehow,” I remarked. “She’s only dangerous when her beak is out. It’d be perfect if it didn’t have to come to that.”
“She feels threatened so easily though,” Maxine argued.

“A net would come in handy right about now.”

Maxine and I turned to look at Mitchell.

“What? I’m just saying. If we could catch her like a fish or something...” his voice trailed off when Maxine rolled her eyes and I shook my head at him.

Suddenly, I remembered something. My hand wandered up to the locket dangling from the iron chain around my neck. I carefully took it off and slowly began approaching the Sugar Plum Fairy. I felt my co-workers confused stares on me, but swallowed my apprehension and, with some effort, heaved myself up onto the stage. I was standing right next to the not-actor now. She still wasn’t paying me any mind. Fingers cramped around the necklace, I lifted my arm and held it out in front of me.

Her reaction was instantaneous. She spun around and stared at me with her dark, large human eyes. She was still standing on her tiptoes, frozen in place and glaring at the locket seemingly in disbelief. I took a step towards her, the locket swung forward and missed her face by mere inches. The Sugar Plum Fairy stumbled backwards, a motion so atypically ungraceful and inept that I almost felt a bit sorry for startling her.

Then, slowly, the skin of her face began to tear. A large, disgusting red rip formed right in its middle, parting her mouth and nose from her eyes and forehead. She wasn’t even using her hands to take it off this time, the two pieces of skin simply peeled off on their own and with them her lips and eyes. The gross, fleshy mass hit the floor with a “splat” and I watched as the squid beak began to form on her newly exposed face.

She slowly opened it and let out a low, throaty hiss. I took another step forward, holding out my locket in front of me like a shield. She once again hissed and continued to back off. Step by step, I drove her closer to the edge of the stage until she was finally forced to jump off.

Mitchell and Maxine had quick-wittedly positioned themselves below her and once she was on the ground, they both grabbed either of her arms and began to drag her off to the new trailer. I quickly put my necklace back on and hopped off the stage, hurrying after them. Together, we shoved the hissing and struggling not-actor into her new enclosure. Maxine locked the door behind her before turning to face me.

"What was that just now?" she asked sharply. "What's with that necklace?"

I was about to explain to her, but changed my mind. Maybe it was better to keep this to myself as long as I wasn't sure of where this would lead me yet. I just murmured something incoherent in response. We waited outside of the enclosure for a few minutes. From the sounds of it, the Sugar Plum Fairy was throwing herself against the door in an attempt to break free, but she soon stopped and the noises from inside the trailer ceased. There is a tiny window in the back of it and a quick glance inside revealed that she had started to dance again.

Later that day, I was heading over to Dale's office. I wanted to ask him about the 3/8 again since I was apparently still way too stupid to understand what it meant. Sure, the Sugar Plum Fairy seemed to have proven to be fae, but something about it didn't feel right. Like, I was missing something really important. Plus, I felt like I couldn't see the woods for the trees, if you get what I mean. I've mentioned it before, but I still wasn't sure what knowing about upper management would get me.

I found Dale in a nervously excited state. He was pacing to and fro in his small office, mumbling to himself. He hadn't bothered to shut the door but I didn't want to startle him by barging in either, so I just stood in the doorway for a while, awkwardly staring at him. When he finally noticed me, he nearly jumped, but quickly regained his composure and urged me to come inside. He closed the door behind us.
"Something wrong?" he stammered.

“Yeah, well... I got a question, but first... what’s going on?”

Dale bit his lip, then looked me in the eyes and slowly reached up to rest his hands on my shoulders. “They know.”

“What?” I stared at him in confusion. “What do you mean?”

“I thought they were gonna leave it be, I thought they weren’t gonna bother, but they know, they know and they’re fucking angry.” My manager’s voice sounded almost desperate. “I thought you could figure it out in time, but it’s too late, they know.”

“Yeah, um, about that. I mean, you said finding out about all this would help, but I don’t really understand how.”

Not removing his hands from my shoulders, Dale leaned in and, in a hushed tone, began to explain, “It’s all about knowing who they are and what they are. Knowledge is power here. If two people make a contract, there are always certain stakes. Don’t ever think both sides are equal, one of them always holds the shittier end of the bargain. However if there’s a third party, a third person, who knows about the contract and the stakes and the bargain, that’d mean that they’d have power too. At least in this case. And maybe they could pressure the one with the better conditions into making things less awful for the other ones.”

“You wanted me to blackmail upper management?” I inquired with wide eyes.

“Yes. Basically. But it’s too late for that, I, I... they just talked to me and... they always talk to me, I hate it when they talk to me...” his voice trailed off and he took a deep breath. “Tomorrow is the last day you’re coming in to work. That’s so you can have some more time with Mr Scratch. You like him and... I know that. So you have one day to say goodbye properly, but that’s it.” He swallowed hard. “I’m firing you.”

I stared at him in shock for a few seconds, uncertain of what to say.

“What about Nathan?” I finally stammered.

“Fuck Nathan!” Dale whined, but from the look of his face I could tell that he regretted it almost instantly. “I’m serious, this is about you and whether you’re going to survive. I thought you could help, but you can’t! Please, don’t try anything else. I don’t want to have your blood on my hands.”
I could feel tears begin to form in my eyes. “Dale...” I whispered, but my throat felt too dry to say anything else.

My manager looked at me, his gaze genuinely deeply concerned and pleading. Then he leaned in closer, wrapped his arms around my shoulders and pulled me into a hug. I stood there, sobbing into his shirt.

“Thank you,” he breathed. “You were trying to help and I appreciate it. It just didn’t work out.”

“Is this my fault?” I whimpered. This was so incredibly sudden. I felt like a total crybaby again, but I simply couldn’t keep it in. “Where did I mess up?”

Dale’s arms tightened around me. His voice broke as he muttered, “You didn’t mess up. You tried your best and it’s my fault. It’s all... it’s all my fault, it was selfish to try and make you... make you do this. I get that now. I’m sorry.”
I didn’t know what else to say, what else to tell him. I couldn’t believe it. We stood there for around another two minutes before Dale let go of me. I have never seen him get so emotional before. I remember I cried all the way home. I could barely see the road through the tears in my eyes. Wouldn’t surprise me if I ran over a stop sign or something.

Either way, I’m at home now and I have calmed down a little bit. At least I stopped crying. I think the realization just hasn’t quite started to set in yet. Again, I cannot believe that this is it. For the past three years, this job has been everything to me.
I guess I’ll just have to enjoy my last day with the sock puppet tomorrow. It will take some time to get over this.

kiss, swallow, turn

First off, I'd like to say that I'm sorry for not responding to any of the comments on my last post. I was feeling rather sad and decided it would be better not to spread my bad vibes. Then again, I cannot claim that I'm doing any better at the moment.

As of me writing this, I'm riding shotgun in my manager's pick-up truck. Dale hasn't said a word in two hours, he's just staring at the road ahead of us clutching the steering wheel so hard his knuckles have turned white. He's muttering incoherent stuff I can't understand, but I keep hearing the words "Shit" and "Fuck" amidst his ramblings, so I assume the rest is PG-13 as well.

I don't feel like cursing. I don't feel like much of anything at all. I recognize this to be the same sense of emptyness and numbness that Nathan had described to me. Thankfully, I've stopped convulsing about an hour ago. It was really hard throwing up without leaving the truck and at the same time trying not to stain the seats. I ended up having to stick my head out the window because Dale couldn't stop driving every time.

To be honest, I didn't even know he owned a truck. I mean, what does a guy like Dale even need a colossus like this for? I guess it really isn't that important though. I should probably explain how we got here... and why we're on the lam.

When I woke up this morning, I really tried to hide the way I was feeling. Standing in front of my bathroom mirror, I took care of the brown bird nest that was my hair after I had tossed and turned all night. My eyes were bloodshot and my cheeks swollen with tears. I had been crying myself to sleep.

I fixed myself a bowl of cereal for breakfast and sat down with it on the couch, still in nothing but a top and underwear. I watched TV for a little while. There was a rerun of one of the earlier seasons of Hell's Kitchen on and I believe I've mentioned before that I like that show, but this morning, not even a bunch of chefs being yelled at could cheer me up. And here I was thinking it'd always do the trick. At around nine,

I couldn't take it anymore. I got dressed and set out for the park. This time, the only protective item I took with me was my locket.

The theme park is a beautiful sight when the sunlight hasn't quite reached its every last corner yet. The ferris wheel stood unmoving above all else, towering over the other rides not unlike a cathedral of sorts. The glow of the morning sun reflected off its shiny surface, making it gleam and glisten like a diamond.

I walked through Hollywood's sparkling streets and stood still for a while to listen to the Pianist's quiet music coming from inside his restaurant. It truly is quite soothing. The horror-themed section was lying in utter silence. I found the Nurse standing in front of her funhouse again, staring off into the distance. I waved at her, though I knew she couldn't see me.

Mr Scratch was sitting outside of his shelter. It was as if he had been expecting me, as if he knew something was wrong. I hugged him. I squeezed my fingers underneath his metal collar to scratch his neck. I patted him on the head between his two horns. I stroked his black fur. He seemed a bit put off by my bleak demeanor, and when the tears began rolling down my cheeks again, he pressed his head against my side as if to comfort me.

"Good boy," I whispered, my voice shaken by sobs.

I fed him one last time. I had brought him a lamb shank I had bought on my way to the park. He tore it to shreds and gobbled it down, just like he had on our first day. I watched, barely able to comprehend that I would not be seeing him again. Maybe I would if I ever were to come to the park as a visitor, but it wouldn't be the same. I knelt down beside him and leaned onto him.

"That next handler of yours is gonna be one lucky bastard," I muttered into his fur. "I'll totally beat them up if I'll ever meet them."

My heart was heavy in my chest when I left the horror-section for Twin

Vale Point. How I was going to miss this beautiful, dry place. I found Nathan, the Stagecoach, the horses and the stork resting in the shade of the old wooden rollercoaster's entrance. Nathan appeared to be happy to see me at first, but once he noticed that I had been crying, the smile quickly faded from his face.

If saying goodbye to Mr Scratch was hard already, saying it to Nathan was even worse. Like, so much worse.

"See? Now I really am going to die alone," he sobbed, wiping the tears from his eyes. "I'll miss you... I'll miss you so, so much..."

"I'll tell the others to come by and check on you. Maybe you'll get along with them too," I offered in an attempt to comfort him. "They'd make good friends as well."

"But I already have a good friend! I don't want anyone else!" He sounded like a little kid. "You don't deserve to be sent away. You worked so hard and now... it's just not fair!"

I hugged him and told him it'd be alright. I could barely bring myself to leave, but there was still one person I had to say goodbye to.

On my walk through the western town, I took some time to take in everything I had grown so fond of over the years for one last time. My necklace was bouncing up and down on my chest as I began to jog a little, just for fun, and eventually its fastener got tangled up in my hair which I was not wearing in a ponytail for once. I had to stop and carefully remove it, but of course it put up a fight and ripped out some of my hair when I pulled it out. I cursed and decided to just keep it wrapped around my left wrist like a bracelet for the remainder of my walk.

I found the Laughing Cowboy relaxing in the large saloon my co-workers and I had used as a meeting room a little while ago. He was simply sitting on a bench in the back, his feet casually resting on top of the table in front of him. He immediately swung down his legs and sat

up straight when I entered.

“Hi,” I greeted him. My voice was raspy and my throat sore from all that crying. “I just... I just wanted to say that I’m not gonna come back here. This is my last day at the park.” I swallowed hard. “So... thank you. For everything.”

The cowboy stood up. His eyes were wide and incredulous, he tilted his head as if to ask if I was serious.

I nodded, a bitter smile on my lips. Parting with him really hurt for some reason. I watched as he slowly approached me. He carefully reached out to touch my face, just like he had on that day when I had been drunk on Dale’s whiskey. He wiped off a small tear that had not yet dried on my cheek with his thumb. His fingers were as clammy as always, but somehow, it was comforting. His cold on my burning skin... it felt incredibly soothing. So I let him.

“Thank you,” I uttered.

We stood like this for what felt like an eternity, him not once breaking my gaze. I finally slowly reached up to remove his hand from my face as gently as possible. I hadn’t realized it was my left hand.

He glanced at the necklace tied around my wrist and before it could even make contact with his arm, he pulled back, an alarmed look in his eyes.

It took me exactly three seconds to comprehend what he had just done.

I was staring up at him in disbelief and he stared back, realization had not yet set in. I was stunned.

Then he shoved me, hard, and I stumbled backwards. I didn’t have enough time to brace myself for the impact. The back of my head collided painfully with the wall and I let out a cry of shock.

He lunged at me with an inhuman speed, one of his hands seized my lower left arm, the other one quickly grabbed my throat. His fingers cramped around my neck as he pressed me against the wall. I gasped for air. My mouth being wide open, he took his chance.

Before I knew it, his lips were on mine. My eyes widened in disgust and I let out a muffled shriek as he slid in his wet tongue. My vision blurred, but I could hear him retch. It was only when I felt his thick, black saliva trickling onto my tongue that I realized what he was doing.

I struggled, trying to break free, but his grip on my arm and throat only tightened. He was too strong, way stronger than I had expected. I tried to shove my free hand in between us to push him away, but the moment I did, his grasp onto my neck grew so firm that I couldn't breathe again. He was choking me. He closed the distance between us, pressing his chest against mine, forcing me to stay still. I tried to kick him, ramming my knee into him again and again, right between his legs.

He ignored me, he just kept... spitting his disgusting, foul-tasting saliva into my mouth. Then, all of a sudden, the possibly grossest idea I've ever had came to my mind. I tensed up my jaw and bit down on his tongue with all my might.

He let out a muffled howl of agony and instantly stepped back, but before I could spit out the black liquid that had gathered in the back of my mouth, he had already placed his hand over it, his palm forbidding me from parting my lips. Despite the obvious pain he was in, the fingers of his other hand remained firmly locked around my lower left arm. Pressing my chin up and squeezing my lips closed, he let out a low hiss. His narrowed eyes stared at me scorningly.

Even though his voice did not form a single word, I knew what he wanted me to do. I shook my head against his fierce grip, whimpering quietly through forcibly clenched teeth. A smirk crept across the cowboy's lips as he reached up and used two of his fingers to pinch my nose closed. Now I really couldn't breathe anymore.

My mind was racing, but I could no longer refuse. I needed to breathe, I needed air. Despite my every need to retch, to get rid of this despicable flavor on my tongue, I pressed my eyes shut and swallowed.

As soon as I had done so, he let go of me and I sunk to the floor, gagging and gasping for air. I couldn't see clearly, my head was spinning and my throat was burning. I tried to get up, but the moment I did, I felt his boot press down onto my shoulder, forcing me to stay in place.

He was smiling again now, a cold, cruel smile I had never seen on him before. He slowly increased the pressure of his foot on my shoulder, causing me to sink to the floor once again. I attempted to touch him with the locket, but when I tried to raise my arm, he stomped on it with unsettling precision. I let out a whimper of pain as he dug his heel into the soft inside of my elbow. I let my head drop to the floor in resignation.

"WARIN!"

The cowboy instantly stumbled back, the painful pressure of his boot lifting from my arm. I pushed myself up with effort only to see Dale standing in the doorway. He was holding his gun, aiming it at the pretender.

"Warin, get away from her, now," he commanded very calmly.

The cowboy backed off. Dale nervously ran his hand through his sand-colored hair. "Leah, come here," he ordered, not once breaking the cowboy's gaze. I slowly rose to my feet. My knees felt like jello. I quickly stumbled over to my manager, grabbing onto his arm for support. The Laughing Cowboy stared at us with hateful eyes.

Mouth agape, I turned to face my manager. This couldn't be happening, I remember thinking. Dale growled and shook his head. "Shit..." he muttered under his breath. Then, he pulled the trigger. He shot the cowboy four times, then spun around and shoved me outside.

"Run! RUN!" he bellowed, but upon realizing how wobbly I was on my

feet, he grabbed me by the wrist and pulled me along. We ran, or rather stumbled, all the way over to the employee entrance.

"The revolver!" he gasped. "Leah, where's the revolver I gave you?"

"At home," I stammered.

"Fuck. We need to get it first. I'll explain everything as soon as we're away from here. Now come on, go!" With that, he ushered me over to a small car standing in the back of the employee parking lot. We got in and he drove me home, telling me to grab only my most important belongings, the revolver and a change of clothes. He waited outside while I got my stuff and then, we drove over to his place. There, we changed cars.

And here we are. On the road, in Dale's black pick-up truck. A backpack holding my clothes, revolver and whip is resting between my feet. I've stopped asking my manager to explain what happened. Partly because he kept telling me we weren't far away enough yet and partly because it's all slowly falling into place on its own.

Dale just told me we would take a break at some rest stop soon. He's been driving for hours now. He's probably starting to get tired. I would offer to drive for him, but he won't tell me where it is he's taking me. I have some many questions.

The foul taste of Warin's saliva hasn't faded from my tongue yet. I wonder how Nathan could simply overlook it when he drank it with his coke all those years ago. I'm dazed and confused. I keep looking at myself in the rearview mirror to see if anything has changed about my face yet, but everything appears to be normal for now. I have no clue why. I hope Dale will clear this up too once he'll finally talk to me again.

I wonder when it will start.

Dale's bedtime story

Officially, I'm fired now, but then again, I've spent the last twenty-four hours or something driving around with my manager, so that really doesn't matter all that much.

Dale drove all day and all night. When we finally pulled over at a rest stop, he told me to stay in the truck and went outside to get himself some coffee.

I did as he told me. My seat had gotten all soft and weary and my butt hurt from not having stood upright for so long. I almost felt like the car was absorbing me. I leaned over to take a look into the rearview mirror. My hair was matted and my eyes bloodshot. Ever since we had fled from the park, I hadn't been able to shake that feeling of my reflection not being my own. Don't get me wrong, it's no one else's, it just... isn't mine. It feels like I've distanced myself from it.

Dale had told me not to look into the mirror as much. He had said it wasn't dangerous, but that it would do nothing but drive me crazy. Still, I couldn't stop sneaking quick glances at it. Everytime, I was scared to find something new, something that might have changed about the way I look, but there was nothing there yet. I wondered if that was a good or a bad thing.

Dale returned a little later with a large cup of coffee for himself and a cupcake for me. He handed it to me and squeezed my shoulder, awkwardly trying to comfort me.

"Figured you could use some carbs," he said softly. "I always eat when I'm sad. Not good for my body, but it helps temporarily."

"Won't I get crumbs on the seat?" I muttered wearily.

"I don't care. Make as big as a mess you like. Crumbs aren't vomit, so..." his voice trailed off. "It's fine is what I'm saying." He took a sip of his coffee.

I carefully unwrapped the cupcake and took a good chunk out of it. It

was soft and sweet. There was pink strawberry cream inside and white chocolate on top. The two sugary flavors mixed on my tongue, banishing the foul taste of Warin's saliva. "Thank you," I whispered, but my voice broke again. I quickly took another bite of the cupcake, then another, then stuffed the whole thing into my mouth.

Dale regarded me quietly from the driver's seat. The look in his eyes was as unfathomable as can be, but I believed to recognize genuine sorrow somewhere within. "I think you should try to sleep a little."

"I can't rest like this, Dale. Please, tell me what's going to happen to me. Or where you're taking me. Or anything at all."

The blonde man let out a soft sigh as he leaned back in his seat. "If it puts your mind at ease, be my guest. But maybe I should start at the beginning. What do you think?"

"The beginning?" I repeated questioningly.

Dale nodded. "The very beginning. How the park came to be in the first place. Would you like to hear that?" His voice was incredibly soft and gentle. Even on his friendlier days, I had never heard him speak like that. He was talking to me like a father would to his frightened child.

"Yes," I breathed, curling up in my seat.

"Well then. Think of it as a bedtime story. That's how it was taught to me. My mother and father were always very eager to prepare me for the kind of life I would be leading. Me and my siblings too, of course. They would come to our beds every night and just before letting us go to sleep, they would tell us this story. The same one, over and over again. It burned itself into our young minds, it shaped us. Made us wary of what was to come once we would become grown-ups.

Sometime during the late eighteen hundreds, my family's ancestors decided to settle down on a patch of land. They hailed from, well, basically everywhere. Some of them came from Texas, others from

further up north, but they all gathered to mend their bond as distant relatives because they wanted to make money. That might have not been the most honorable goal, but at the time, none of them were wealthy, not by any stretch of the word.

They figured that maybe, if they would all join forces, they could build up something. A brand, perhaps. I'm not sure what it was they had in mind exactly. Either way, it took this scattered bunch nearly a full year to get together again, but once they were all reunited, they got on their journey. They settled down on a really large clearing in the middle of a forest. They began by building a single large cottage for them to live in. At first, everything was fine. Things were looking up for them.

However they soon came up with the idea to turn their land into a fairground since there were many townships in close proximity to the woods. So they started chopping down trees. That's when the nightmare began. The settlers had thought that the woods were not populated and that they didn't belong to anybody. On the paper, they didn't, but the truth looked a bit different.

It started with Faith, a younger, at the time pregnant woman who had been traveling with her husband who was part of the clan, suffering a miscarriage. When the first tree fell, she went into labor. It was way, way too early. She was bound to her bed for two entire days, screaming and crying in agony, while the men outside continued to clear the forest. Her child never lived to see the light of day.

Of course, my ancestors didn't immediately draw the connection. How could they have? They merrily continued to cut down the trees. Just one week after Faith's miscarriage, Lawrence, the six year old son of one of the couples vanished from his bedroom without a trace. The next child to disappear was a girl called Millie. And that's when the family began to catch on.

See, Millie was just five when she disappeared, but she had an older half-brother in his early thirties. His name was Colt and you should probably know that he had a cleft lip. Now, Colt wasn't the type to sit

on his ass while his little sister could have been taken god knows where. He was one of those who hailed from Texas and he was your typical cowboy. He did care a whole lot about manners and etiquette and all that shit, he was a true gentleman. Swearing he would not leave Millie hanging, he set out to look for her.

The family told him it was useless. After all, they had already searched the whole woods and the neighboring towns when Lawrence had gone missing, but Colt wouldn't listen. He went for the woods and he was out there for days. Just when he was about to give up, he found... a hole. There was a hole in the ground, right next to an old, fallen tree. And on the remains of that tree sat a man dressed in nothing but rags.

The man was holding a child, a little girl who seemed to be fast asleep. Colt immediately recognized her, it was Millie. He pulled out his revolver and aimed at the man and he screamed at him to let her go, but the man just smiled at him and asked him what his name was. For some reason, this question struck Colt as off, so he decided not to answer. He approached the man on the fallen tree, warning him once again that if he wouldn't hand over the girl, he would shoot him. The stranger however remained unfazed, grinning with black teeth.

For the next bit, you need to know that Colt was a bit of a craftsman. He was a firearm fanatic and due to not always having the money to buy ammunition, yes, they were that poor, he would sometimes try to make his own. These hand-made bullets would hardly ever fly far. They were pretty much useless, but Colt insisted that they were better than nothing. He made them from iron, you know. I heard he melted old nails and stuff, but whatever. At the time, there were five bullets in his revolver, two normal ones that were made of lead and three of his hand-made iron ones.

The man on the fallen tree laid Millie down on the ground. She was unconcious, didn't even know what was going on around her. He slowly started to walk towards him. Colt began to shoot at him. He fired two shots at him, both hitting him in the stomach. He stopped for a few seconds, appearing to be in pain, but to Colt's shock and astonishment,

he just straightened up again and continued coming closer. The wounds where the bullets had sunken into his flesh had vanished.

So Colt fired the remaining three shots in his revolver. The stranger was just close enough for the iron bullets to find their target. He shot him right in his chest, three times, but this time, the stranger let out a cry of agony and fell to the ground. Colt grabbed his sister and ran back home while her kidnapper was still writhing on the ground.

That same night, as soon as the sun had set, a group of the strangest creatures emerged from the treeline. They surrounded the cottage and waited for the family to come out. Of course, Colt had told them all about what had happened when he had brought back Millie and they had prepared themselves for battle. But when they came outside, only the man with the black teeth stepped forward, the one who had held the little girl.

Even though there were three bullet holes in his chest, he stood upright and when he spoke, black drool came dripping from his mouth. And in the sharpest of voices, he offered Colt a deal.

"We started taking your young ones when you began to destroy our home," he told him, "but we will return them to you. We will even help you with your endeavor to reshape our land, however we will do so under the one condition that you treat our every wish as your command."

Of course, Colt was less than happy with this suggestion, especially since it was so vague it could mean anything. Still, he struck a bargain with the black-teethed man, but only after they had worked out a certain set of stakes. You may have already guessed most of them.

The creatures would help the family to gain money. They promised that they would personally see to their success, no matter the changes to the woods this would require. There would only be three of the creatures to stay on the surface, the rest of them would move underground into a certain realm that appeared to be accessible by the hole in the ground where Colt had found the black-teethed one. These three would provide

the humans with each of their names, granting them a certain power over them.

However they would demand sacrifices of unspecified nature which the humans would be bound to provide, but they also assured them that they would use the sacrifices for the refinement of the fairground. Those were the basics, but there was one last oath Colt made them take. He had noticed that during their consultation, the creatures had kept trying to screw them over by using very vague phrases and careful wording. He figured that since it was so dangerous to talk to them, it would be better if they couldn't talk at all. He forbade them from speaking. Only the ones who would stay on top though, of course.

The black-teethed one introduced himself as Warin and the other two that would stay on the surface as Mulberry and Moth. Nowadays, you know Mulberry as the Sugar Plum Fairy and Moth as the Mime.

My folks probably noticed that they had made quite a shitty mistake right away, because right after the contract was sealed, Warin snapped Colt's neck and took on his form. The only thing he couldn't replicate were his white teeth and normal saliva, but I guess he didn't really need to since he... well, I guess you know what he uses it for. The three holes in his chest from the iron bullets stayed as well."

Dale ended his report with a soft sigh and I stared at him incredulously. "That all sounded like a fairy tale," I remarked.

"Well, that's what we've all been told. Maybe it happened like this, maybe it didn't. But the important thing is that with the creatures' help, the clearing was turned into a fairground, and when the time came, it was changed into an amusement park. The one you now know. Every single thing in the park was built by them. Sure, we were able to make additions and renovations to it, but it was them who laid the foundation. Don't ask how they did it. I never quite understood it myself.

Either way, the creatures lost their names and ability to speak, but while we gained wealth, we also lost our privilege of freedom. We have to give

them what they want, no matter what it is. If we don't..." Dale paused to swallow audibly, "they will not only tear down the park, but probably come for our young ones again."

I held my breath. Dale continued. "Warin, Mulberry and Moth were tasked with staying on the surface to enforce the contract, but let's be honest here... Warin is the only one who takes it serious. He chose every single one of the sacrifices. Mulberry gained a certain passion for dancing so she just does that all day, and Moth never cared much about anything. He's more like an animal, I think."

"Are they... faeries?" I asked.

"That's the thing. We don't know. We believe them to be, but they're not exactly like the ones you'll find in literature. They enjoy mischief and follow certain rules, they even react negatively to most of the same materials. Plus, they are able to change shapes. See, Millie died of some illness in her teen years, and Mulberry took on her outward appearance. I'm not sure how they do it, maybe they can only change into people who are dead. But there are obvious inconsistencies that set them apart from the traditional faerie folk. My folks and I... we call them the Wild Ones."

"The Wild Ones?" I repeated.

"Yeah. That includes those who live underground."

My head was spinning. I still had quite a lot of questions, but before I could say anything, Dale went on.

"We need to focus on Warin though. He's the park's guardian, the enforcer of the contract. I won't go so far as to say that he's upper management, but he... he communicates with the ones underground. They discuss who or what it is that they want, but in the end, he's the one who'll make me do it. Fun fact, the ones underground... they weren't forbidden from speaking. And sometimes, when they want me to... I can hear them. I hate when they do that.

Warin is also the one who designs the Halloween tasks. I mean, square dancing and his handler humiliating himself... he uses them to mess with us a little. And most importantly, he's the one who is trying to turn you into a not-actor. I'm sorry if my account just now sounded like a jumbled mess. You don't even need to care about the contract anymore. I've breached it. I... I denied Warin his sacrifice."

I wasn't sure if I actually wanted to know the answer to the question burning on my tongue, but I asked anyways. "Why me? How did he... when did he decide?"

Dale bit his lower lip. "He let me know he wanted you last Halloween. But if I'm being honest, you were doomed the moment you walked your happy ass into the park for the first time.

It was just the same with Nathan, even though I think he simply had me do that one because he's never liked me all that much. I still remember it like it was yesterday. He came into my office that one morning. There was a framed photo of Nathan and me standing on my desk, and he took it and looked at it for a little while. I was like, what's going on? What do you want? And he just... he just pointed at him in the photo and grinned. He took the one thing that made me happy, like, truly happy that day."

"So... what now? Do we kill him?"

Dale chuckled. "I'm totally on board with your enthusiasm, but I don't know how. That's why I'm taking you to meet my family. Perhaps we can come up with something together. We need to get ourselves out of this mess somehow. The contract's done for... that means Warin might... you know. I'd just hate to imagine anything happening to them."

I still had quite a lot of questions, but I felt like I had heard enough for the day. I curled up in my seat and shut my eyes. I don't know how exactly I managed to fall asleep with the truck driving, but somehow, I did.

It's kind of strange. I haven't really done anything all day, but I feel terribly exhausted.

it runs in the family

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. Do I though? Should I say I used to instead? Scratch it, it's unimportant. After what I learned yesterday, I feel like I couldn't take it all in if I tried.

I woke up when the first bright beams of morning sunlight found their way through the windscreen of Dale's pick-up truck. Slowly opening my eyes, I couldn't remember where I was at first. Then, everything came rushing back to me and I admit I felt like throwing up.

"You're awake," Dale remarked from beside me. "How are you?"

"Awful," I muttered, rubbing my eyes. "Were you awake all that time? How long was I out for?"

Taking a look at the car radio's display, he replied, "Six hours I think. And no, not exactly. I pulled over soon after you fell asleep to take a short nap, but I couldn't really rest, I'm... a bit of an insomniac anyways. And I called the others and told them to stay away from the park."

"What did you tell them?" I asked.

"I didn't really explain anything, I just told them not to come in or to leave instantly. Mitchell kind of knows what's up anyways. Had to make an exception for Caroline though. I told her to rush in in the afternoon, ask her question and then book it. I don't think the laws of the park are in place anymore, but I don't want to take any chances. After all, the Pianist is a ticking time bomb. Courtesy of Warin, by the way. That fucker placed him there as a reminder for me and my folks not to forget about the Wild Ones."

I frowned. "Makes sense," I muttered before once again burying my forehead in my palm.

"Are you okay?"

"No... Feeling kinda dizzy," I replied before perking up. "Wait, did you

just say Mitchell knows what's up?"

"Yeah. Well, not exactly. See, I had to assign actors to everyone and I figured I could have Mitch keep an eye on... you know who. I never told him who he actually is and what purpose he fills, but I did tell him to watch him, like, intensely. Said it was very important. Also, I asked him to pay special attention to his interactions with you."

"What is it that he wants from me anyways?" I hadn't asked him this before, mainly because I hadn't expected him to know, but also because I was slightly afraid of the answer.

"I'm not sure, to be honest," my manager answered. "But it's... um... it's personal."

"What do you mean by that, personal?"

"Okay, so... when you first came to the park, I noticed that he began to watch you. Like, pretty much right off the bat. A week or so later, he showed up on my office doorstep and he... he wanted your name. So I showed him how to spell it. To them, names really do have power, but I'm not certain in what way that counts for humans, so... ugh. I can't look into his head, you know."

"I get that," I muttered.

The atmosphere in the car remained tense until we left the highway and entered a town. The neighborhood Dale finally pulled into looked suburban and wealthy, with large, colorful houses to either side. We drove along the street for a couple minutes, me staring out of the window in silent awe at the idyllic scenes we passed. There was a couple sitting outside on their front lawn in folding chairs in front of one of the residences, another had three rather alike-looking children throw around a ball between them and there was a lady sunbathing on the porch of yet another one of these buildings. It looked picture perfect, like something out of a movie.

Dale pulled up by a house on the very end of the street. “We’re here,” he aid curtly. We got out of the truck and walked up to its porch. The house was huge. Of course, that wasn’t too much of a surprise, but I hadn’t expected it to be this pretty. Lush, green lawn reached from the edge of the sidewalk all the way up to the porch. The yard held a swingset, a tall tree and a trampoline. Three small children were happily jumping around on the latter while another one was sitting on the swing.

“They’re my brother’s,” Dale told me, looking over at them with a fond smile. As we got closer, he called out to them. The kids immediately stopped their playing and came bounding over to us, gathering around my manager. None of them were even tall enough to reach up to his waist, but they grabbed onto his arms anyways.

“Uncle Dale!” one of them, a petite blonde girl greeted him. “Mom didn’t tell us you were coming over!”

“Yeah, well, it’s a bit of a surprise visit, Courtney,” Dale explained, awkwardly trying to take a step forward with the four kids blocking his path. “Sweetie, I gotta talk to grandma and grandpa... you guys really have to get out of my way, I’m stumbling... Dallas, can you please not pull on my pants, thank you...” He shot me a pleading glance. I couldn’t help but giggle at the sight.

Suddenly, the front door was thrown open and a tall, blonde man stepped out onto the porch. He looked around, then spotted Dale and the children. His eyes lit up and he ran over to us. The kids quickly made way and he wrapped his arms around my manager and heartily patted him on the back in greeting.

“DUDE! I had no idea you’d drop by, how are you? Who’s the lady?”

Dale was looking extremely uncomfortable by now. His face had taken on the color of an overly ripe apple and he gently attempted to remove himself from the man’s embrace. I remember suddenly noticing that they looked very alike, the same sandy hair, the same square jaw, the same brown eyes.

“Hey... Dean. I’m fine. Dean, this is Leah, Mr Scratch’s actress. Leah, this is my younger brother Dean.”

Dean cracked me a wide smile and shook my hand. “So, what are you guys doing here? Everything alright at the park?”

His face fell when he noticed Dale’s grim expression. “Well, fuck me,” he muttered.

A little later, we were sitting at the table in Dale’s family’s kitchen. Their home was just as pretty from the inside as it was out. I had been thoughtfully introduced to Betty and Rick, Dale’s mother and father, as well as to Bridget, Dean’s wife. She is a beautiful red-headed woman hailing from Ireland, as openly proven by her strong accent.

Dean and Bridget’s children were playing tag outside in the backyard. I could hear them giggle and shout through the open window. Rick was leaning against the kitchen cupboard. Ever since we had told him what had happened, he hadn’t stopped shaking his head in disbelief and distress.

“This is beyond confusing. The contract has been violated by both sides, if not broken entirely,” he stated in his gruff, hoarse voice. “Warin... he wasn’t meant to take you on his own. Let’s see. I think it’s pretty obvious that the ones underground started to dislike ever since you began to threaten Moth and Mulberry physically.”

“They were mad as fuck,” Dale agreed from his seat on the kitchen counter. “But they were mad at me too. For giving you the revolver.”

“Yeah, um... why did you give it to me anyways?” I asked.

“It works like a protective charm. Warin hates it. I admit, that wasn’t very well thought through seeing as I think that’s what pushed them over the edge, but whatever. I tried. I fired you because the ones underground wanted to see your guts spilled. That wasn’t really a breach

of the contract yet though. I mean, it's Warin who brings the news about the sacrifices, so I was just like, his loss. He hadn't said anything yet so I figured it'd be my last chance to get you outta there. I hadn't expected... that to happen, you know."

"What we need to do is figure out if we can mend the contract somehow," Rick explained. "I admit I'm tired of it too, but we can't just endanger the kids. Maybe we can cancel it on peaceful terms." He reached out to pat my shoulder reassuringly. "We'll get you fixed somehow, don't you worry. Warin has acted on his own this time. That's... not explicitly forbidden, but it also isn't allowed. After all, the employees kinda count as our belongings."

"Thanks," I said softly, and Rick smiled.

"But what if it doesn't work out?" Betty argued. "We should prepare ourselves for things to get violent. What happened can't be undone, and technically, Dale wasn't completely true to the contract either. One could even argue that he was more in the wrong. I mean, there were indications that the Wild Ones wanted Leah for... whatever reasons. All I'm saying is that they might not be happy about it, perhaps they'll even be angry enough to... fall back into certain older schemes."

"If it comes to hurting them, iron seems to work really well. But like, is it even possible to kill them?" I inquired, nervously caressing my locket.

No one seemed to know the answer. Betty and Rick exchanged contemplative glances while Dean shook his head. "Don't think so. One thing's really confusing to me as well. So far, the Wild Ones mostly chose their sacrifices to make us feel shitty. It's all a huge power play to them."

"Say, who even were the previous sacrifices?" I asked curiously.

Betty sighed. "Oh, dear. Where to even start? The first sacrifice was a Wolfhound which belonged to one of the first settlers. The Wild Ones had the guy kill the poor thing by having it drink Warin's spit and then they... they did something weird to its body. They changed it. Made

it big, strong and monstrous. When the fairground still existed, the settlers exhibited him as a real-life demon or devil. That's how much they mauled him.

The next thing they asked for was a Stagecoach. Warin liked Colt's attitude. He was into the whole Western style, and he wanted the carriage as his plaything. The horses were fed with his secretions and he chose a settler to drive it around.

Then, for a really long time, they didn't ask for anything else. Until Rick's grandaunt and granduncle were chosen. His grandaunt's name was Grace. She was a theater actress, but she only ever starred in small plays, nothing too big. Her husband, Robert, led the fairground for a pretty long time. He was a really artistic guy, very musical. Him and his wife would do small shows on the fairground from time to time.

I don't know why it was these two that Warin chose. Maybe he saw how happy they were and wanted to destroy it. Perhaps it was in a twisted sense of humor. As in, make the show go on for eternity. It was heartbreaking to see them turn.

The worst thing though happened just twenty years ago. There was this actress, Laila. Laila was very disrespectful towards the not-actors. Treated them like animals, all of them. But she didn't deserve what he did to her. Though Warin would probably beg to differ." Betty bit her lip and lowered her eyes. "So, all in all, there's a whole lotta differences between you and those others. I mean, you didn't do anything wrong until very recently, and you're not part of the family."

"That doesn't have to mean anything," Bridget suddenly spoke up. "Your story reminds me of something, actually. Back when I lived in Ireland, my home was close to a faerie ring. Sometimes, some of them would come out to see the light of day... I'm certain I even saw some of them a couple times. But my older sister actually got chosen by one of them." Her voice had shrunken into a secretive whisper. "I noticed her acting strange. Like she was high or something. She would go outside everyday and every time, she'd be gone for a little longer.

Then one day, she just didn't come home at all. We asked the neighbors who lived a little closer to the ring and they swore up and down they saw her with a man with the head of a dog. They described her to seem weirdly enchanted by him. It's obvious that he took her. I haven't seen her ever since. I've read about a ton of such incidents. Fae sometimes... take a liking to humans. Ones they find pretty or appealing. They train them to follow them around, they drug them with their magic... they keep 'em like slaves or pets."

I dared not break her gaze. I swallowed. "Well, I don't wanna be anybody's fucking pet," I said, trying to sound firm, but my voice faltered and broke.

"You won't," Dean assured me with a warm smile. "We'll work this out somehow. Let's just stay positive, okay?"

"You said you had a breakdown in the men's restroom," Rick muttered, a deep frown on his face. "You can probably figure out on your own what it is we locked away in there."

"The entrance to the underworld," I breathed.

Rick nodded. "See, there's something way off about that breakdown. Let me get this straight. You fell unconcious and Warin got you outta there, but not before removing the protective charms from your possession. I believe the presence of the charms, which are strongly rejected by the entrance, caused you to pass out. But that other fit of yours, the one where you attacked your co-worker... that shouldn't have happened. There's no explanation for it."

"Unless of course you had already started to turn," Dale interjected offhandedly.

The room fell silent. Dale's eyes widened when he realized what he had just said. He cleared his throat. "For how long did Darius say you were in there?"

“He... he didn’t specify,” I stammered. I felt like throwing up.

“Alright, alright, dear, calm down,” Betty said softly, placing her hand on my shoulder. “The turning process takes nine days at the very least, and all those who have been turned beforehand had to stay in the park while it happened. Plus, you’re still wearing that necklace. Seems to be pretty helpful. We have enough time to sort this out. Let’s just focus on what to do next.”

“Right,” Rick muttered. “I’m thinking that we’re gonna have a visitor pretty soon.”

I spun around to look at him. “What? You mean he... he’s followed us here?”

Rick nodded. “I imagine he’s on his way. He is the enforcer of upper management’s rules after all, even though he acted against them. It’s his job to set this straight. Not sure how he travels, but probably underground. He was never completely bound to the park, you know. And now that the contract is on thin ice, he’s got more freedom than ever. Chances are... chances are he’s even got his voice back.”

“Well, great. Judging from how much the others talk, he probably won’t shut up either. It’ll probably help with the negotiations though,” Dale remarked. He was trying to sound lighthearted, but I could hear the strain in his tone.

“Are you the only one who can hear those underground?” I asked.

Dale nodded. “It’s always the one in the manager’s position who can hear them.”

We then went about making preparations for Warin’s arrival. Dean explained that we would have to offer him hospitality if we wanted to settle the matter peacefully, however hard that might be for us. Betty sent me outside to bring in the children.

I watched them run around in the backyard for a little while. Courtney, the little blonde girl, seemed to be "it" at the moment. She deliberately chased after a chubby ginger-haired girl, who in turn seemed to try to reach the large tree in the back of the yard in time. Courtney's hand came into contact with her the same moment her fingers touched the bark of the tree.

"You're it!" Courtney shouted. "Whitney, you're it!"

"No, I'm not! I got to the safety tree in time! See? I'm touching it!"

"Yeah, but I got you first!" Courtney insisted. "If you cheat, the people underground will come for you!"

The people underground will come for you.

They're taking the rules of the contract and turn them into a game. I remember thinking it was morbid.

"Hey, you guys! Your mom wants you to come inside!" I called out.

The four kids stopped goofing around and obediently came trotting over to the back door. They cracked me shy smiles as they walked past me into the house. Betty gathered them in one of the top floor rooms. The room was completely empty, and Betty spread salt around its edges, encircling the space the kids would be staying in.

"Leah, pay close attention now. This is the safe room. It's high up from the ground, making it more uncomfortable for any of the Wild Ones to reach. They like to stay as close to soil as possible. That's why we keep it unoccupied, so we can use it as sort of a panic room. The salt keeps the Wild Ones from entering. When Warin arrives, we will have to face him together, but if anything goes wrong, you can always come up here and join the kids."

"Thank you," I muttered.
Betty smiled at me. "We'll make it through somehow," she assured me.

“I’m sure it’ll be fine.”

When the sun set, we had all gathered in the living room. Bridget had thankfully allowed me to take a long, relaxing shower using her shampoo and washing gel, which actually helped me take my mind off of things for about fifteen minutes. I had changed into some fresh clothing and went to join the others in watching TV. Even though the kids were still with us and there was a cartoon show blaring at full volume, the tension in the room was palpable when I entered.

Betty, Rick, Dean and Bridget were sitting on the couch while the children had snuggled up on the carpeted floor. Dale was sitting on the floor as well, a little off to the side. He looked up to me and gave me a weary smile and waved me over. I plopped down next to him. I had taken Colt’s revolver with me and the locket was dangling from my neck as usual.

We sat like this for about an hour. Apart from a few occasional giggles from the kids, none of us said a word. Then, all of a sudden, the strained atmosphere was broken by the sound of knocking at the front door. The knocks came slow and hard, three times, each one a little louder than the last.

Bridget instantly scrambled to her feet and shooed the kids upstairs while the rest of us went for the door. I hid behind Dale, feeling a tad foolish for not standing up for myself. My sweaty fingers cramped around the revolver’s handle. The bullets inside it are made of lead, but I hope that he hates the thing itself enough to make him stay away from me.

Rick was the one to open the door to him. “Good evening, Warin,” he said, his frame blocking out the newcomer from my view.

My heart stopped for a second when a voice, an actual voice, replied to him. It was sharp and cold. There was an almost mocking tone to it. “Greetings, Rick. It has been a while, has it not?”

A short pause followed, nobody saying a word.

“Will you not invite me inside, old friend?”

Rick sighed deeply. “Come in then.”

He stepped aside to make way for the park’s guardian. For a split second, Warin’s eyes met mine, just before I could duck further behind Dale’s back. The corners of his mouth stretched into a wry smirk. My heart was pounding in my chest.

“Actually, I feel very tired. I wish to... rest. If you allow me, I shall retire in your back yard.”

“If that’s what you want. But I do not want you sneaking in without knowing. This is our home, please remember that.”

“I would never.”

Right now, I’m lying in bed in the guest room. I’m alone and everything is silent, uncomfortably so. But the worst thing is that there is a window to the backyard. It’s right above the bed and whenever I lift my head, I can see him.

He’s standing upright in the garden. It’s too dark to tell if he is looking at anything, but I feel like he’s watching me. I know he promised Rick not to come in, but that isn’t really helping.

I’m scared to fall asleep.

unsuccessful backstabbing

This last night was simply awful for me.

The moonlight coming in through the window which had neither curtains nor blinds was just bright enough to add to my already persistent unease. I tried to cover it up with my blanket and pillow, but they simply wouldn't stay in place. Then I tried to sleep with my head resting on the other end of bed. That actually helped for a little while, but the knowledge of me being at the mercy of strangers and the shapeshifting monster standing outside staring voidly through the window kept me anxious and on high alert.

Every creak of a floorboard, ever gust of wind that hit the roof from outside made me jump. At first, I tried to occupy myself by rewatching some cartoon episodes I had downloaded on my smartphone. Somehow, things that are meant for kids always manage to soothe my nerves. Not this time though. A few minutes after midnight, I started to sob into my pillow. Suddenly, I heard the doorhandle to my room being pushed down with a squeak.

"Leah?"

I shot up. Had I not pressed my hand in front of my mouth, I probably would have screamed.

"Shhh, it's just me."

I sighed in relief when I recognized the voice to be that of Bridget. I listened as she quietly came over to me and lowered herself down onto the mattress. The moonlight shining in through the window illuminated her shiny red locks and pale face. She was smiling sympathetically. "I didn't mean to startle you, I'm sorry," she whispered. "God, I'm stupid. You must be losing your shit. I heard you crying so I thought I'd come check on you."

I wiped a tear from my eye and tried my best to smile back. "That's... very nice of you, thanks," I said, my voice hoarse and low.

Bridget softly cleared her throat. “I think... I think you should know something. I’m not supposed to say, but... well, no one’s keeping me from it, but it’s hard for me to say since... nevermind. So, what I’ve been meaning to tell you is that I’m on your side.”

“What do you mean?”

“If I’m being completely honest with you, I don’t know if Betty and Rick won’t try to use you as a bargaining chip.” She sighed. “See, what speaks in their favor is that they never needed to sacrifice someone important to them. During Rick’s time as the manager, the only victim was Laila and she wasn’t too close to them. Still, if I remember correctly, that really brought them down. They didn’t want to do that.

What I’m saying is they never lost all that much, meaning that they’re soft. They’re definitely not willing to just hand anyone as if it’s nothing at all, but still. They might... I don’t know. Better to be on the safe side.”

I swallowed before muttering, “And Dale? Do you think he would...?”

“I’m not sure. I’ve never known him all that well. He’s kind of hard to read, but I want to believe in him.”

“Does the name Nathan ring any bells?”

“Of course. The coachman. He was Dale’s boyfriend, wasn’t he?”

“Wait, you knew that?” I was astonished.

Bridget chuckled lightly. “We’re not that estranged. We did meet up a couple times.”

“Right.” I remembered Nathan telling me something along those lines as well. “I was wondering... why did he just obey Warin when this was about Nathan? Sure, he would have risked more, but...”

Bridget interrupted me. “Because the contract wouldn’t allow it. Warin’s

behavior allowed Dale to use that loophole and get you outta there. This time, he actually had the opportunity to resist without anyone getting hurt. All he did was take it." After a short pause, she added, "At least I hope so."

"But you are definitely on my side?" I inquired.

"I see why that may seem odd to you. I admit I don't know you. Dean and I always stayed away from the park's... business affairs, but I have experience with the fae. The Wild Ones aren't exactly like them, I know, but they're similar. I lost my sister to a faerie, and I refuse to sell anyone out to these creatures. Therefore, I want to make you an offer."

I looked at her expectantly and she leaned in closer. "Everyone else fast asleep. We are the two only ones awake right now, and we both know what's on the line. I can't see negotiations getting us anywhere, so what do you say we try and end it while we can?"

"I don't really understand..."

Bridget smirked at me. "Let's kill Warin together."

I stared at her with wide eyes, at a total loss for words. "But what about your kids?" I stammered.

"Psshh, don't you get it? Warin doesn't have the right to harm them. He violated the contract as well, remember? He only let on he wanted you, if he had wanted all the rules to stay in place, he shoulda told Dale! His loss. On top of that, he's been selfish. The Wild Ones promised they'd use the victims for the park's improvement. I don't see how what he's been doing helps that.

Now that the contract's wearing thin, we should take our chance. Technically, you have the right to do whatever anyways, and I do think that I have, too. At least for now." Bridget reached out and squeezed my hand encouragingly. "Come on. Let's do this! We only have until sunrise."

She stood up and gently pulled me to my feet. A quick glance outside the window told me that Warin had sat down in the grass, cross legged, his hands and hat in his lap. His head had sunken down and this time, he appeared to actually be resting. Even in this demure, calm position, there was something watchful about him. Like a predator feigning dormancy only to lunge at his prey the second it would dare to come close enough.

I grabbed my revolver and put on my necklace, then quietly followed Bridget downstairs. We sat down at the kitchen table and I laid down the revolver in front of me.

"First off, you don't happy to have iron bullets around for this thing, do you?"

"Sadly not. They're hard to make. I guess we could try and melt a panhandle or something, but that would take a bit too long for tonight. Plus, we only have one chance. We need to get it right the first time," she explained. "We can't allow ourselves any mistakes."

"That's... actually super risky what we're doing here, isn't it?"

Bridget swallowed and lowered her gaze. "I'm afraid so. Let's just... not think about it too much. Sure, it's a risk, but one I'm willing to take. I mean, think about it. If Warin's gone, not only would you be out of danger, but this whole contract-crap would be over too, meaning that my kids wouldn't have to do this awful job ever. I get that it was irresponsible to have children in the first place, but... but..." her voice trailed off and she fumbled for words.

"It's fine," I assured her, noticing that we had gone off topic. "You don't have to explain yourself."

She smiled. "Okay then. How do we go about this? I say first off, we should make sure he's alone out there."

"Wait, you think Mulberry and Moth could be with him?"

I asked, taken aback.

“Possibly. Been worrying about that all night. Warin said he wouldn’t come in, but that doesn’t mean they couldn’t, right?”

“Well, fuck. Are all the windows shut?”

“You bet. At least we’ll hear when someone breakes in. Back on topic, we know he dislikes laurel, red verbena, salt, iron and silver and sage should be helpful too, I think. Maybe we could somehow combine them?” Bridget thought out loud.

“Yeah, but like, how? I got my locket, but that’s only for protection. It’s not much of a weapon.”

Bridget perked up. “I think I got something that’ll do. Nowadays, knife blades aren’t normally made of iron anymore, but I have this really old hunting knife, and I’m like, ninety percent sure it’s made of iron.”

“So we stab him with the knife but at the same time feed him sage, salt, laurel and red verbena?” I asked sceptically. “How is that supposed to work?”

Bridget sighed. “Alright, I have an idea, but you’re not gonna like it.”

About half an hour later, Bridget and I were standing in front of the back door, the red-head’s one hand hovering above the doorknob, the other one firmly clutching the revolver. “Alright, so as soon as you go out there, I take position at the window. If anything goes wrong, I’ll try to shoot him. That’ll at least buy you some time to get back inside. Are you ready?”

I nodded, clenching my teeth, trying to ignore the potpourri of flavors in my mouth.

“Okay. Good luck. Ready... set... go,” she whispered as she opened the door for me to step outside.

The cool night air hit me like a splash of water. It felt strangely soothing on my burning cheeks. I slowly began approaching the cowboy, or rather Warin. He instantly seemed to awake and rose to his feet. I stood still as a statue, waiting for him to say or do something, anything, the silence drove me mad.

What was I actually doing here? Who said he would even try it again?

Shoving the leaves I was chewing on further into my hollow cheek, I took a deep breath. I could feel Bridget's hunting knife which I had tucked away in my waistband uncomfortably press itself against my back.

"Hello," I uttered, my voice ever so slightly muffled by the contents of my mouth.

"I knew you would come out eventually."

His voice sounded like metal scraping on metal. I flinched slightly at its cold undertone. There was something incredibly sickening about it. I could hardly put my finger on it, but it almost made me feel nauseous, as nonsensical as that may sound.

"I don't want this to go on any longer. End it."

Warin smiled dryly. If one could call that a smile. He waved me over and I reluctantly came closer. I shut my eyes, took a deep breath and ignored the tears beginning to fill my eyes.

I will not go into much detail regarding what happened then. But I believe you can guess by yourselves. Either way, the moment I had the opportunity to do so, I leaned in and pushed the bits of sage, laurel, red verbena and salt into his open mouth. He let out a muffled growl and pulled back instantly, attempting to spit them out, but I quickly pressed my hand over his mouth just long enough to grab the knife from my waistband. He was still standing close enough, so I reached behind his back and rammed it into his flesh with all my might, making him stumble against me.

I let go of the knife, stepped aside and shoved him to the ground. He landed flat on his stomach. Raising my foot, I stepped down on the knife's handle, causing the part of the blade that had not yet buried itself into his back to sink in completely. His body went limp. He was just... lying there, still and unmoving.

I couldn't believe it. I felt my lips stretch into wide smile. Looking over to the window, I could make out Bridget's incredulous face. She stared out at me with wide eyes, then gave me thumbs-up and rushed to the door. She came bounding over the lawn to my side.

"You did it!" she uttered. Then, happier, she added, "Oh my god! We actually did it! I can't..."

I think she meant to say that she couldn't believe it, but she had no time to finish her sentence.

Warin let out a low groan, it was quiet and sounded pathetic, but also very much alive. Bridget and I stared down at him. I can hardly describe what we saw. He slowly began to... change.

I noticed his vest slackening first. Its fabric sunk to the ground as if the body inside wasn't broad enough to fill it anymore. The next thing to change was his hair. It was paling, blanching until all that was left of its former dark blonde color was a sickly, unnatural white. He slowly, ever so slowly continued to push himself off the ground.

Bridget and I instantly backed off, unable to take our eyes off the scene but both of us knowingly staggering into the rough direction of the back door.

As he rose to his feet, I could hear his bones snapping. We watched as he threw back his head and bent his arms, we saw him grow taller and gaunter. His face seemed to stretch, his jaw cracking as if it were being broken. He opened his mouth to let out a low growl and streams of black saliva came flooding out. And then he was suddenly complete. He was standing upright in the grass in front of us, glaring at us. His

familiar clothing was hanging off of his sickeningly lean frame like oversized bags. He reached behind his back and pulled out the knife, quickly dropping it to the ground so as to avoid contact with the iron blade.

Bridget grabbed me by the wrist and hurriedly dragged me inside. She threw the door shut behind us and both of us ran to the window. He was still standing there though, he wasn't moving. Just staring at us. My mind was racing. I remember grabbing Bridget by the shoulders and shaking her, whimpering something along the lines of, "What the fuck is that thing?" over and over again, until she gently but firmly removed my hands and squeezed them.

"That's him," she uttered. "That's Warin."

After that, I think I started to cry. Bridget hugged me and guided me up the stairs and into the bedroom, repeatedly telling me it was going to be alright. Maybe this is a gift that comes with one's experience as a parent, but I actually believed her.

Once I was in the relative safety of the bedroom, Bridget went about waking up the others. This was such a stupid idea.

As of me writing this, the sun has already begun to rise. I have watched Rick go outside to talk to that thing and everything seemed to be normal. He didn't make any moves or anything, he just stood there and spoke to the former manager. A little while ago, Dale came up to my room.

"You do realize that that was incredibly stupid?" he inquired in a surprisingly gentle tone.

I nodded into my pillow. "I'm sorry," I whimpered.

"Hey, it's fine... I hope. Well, I get the idea. It's the good intention that counts. So... my dad went outside. Warin told him he didn't blame him for that weird assassination attempt. They will still try to negotiate later. But there's one thing he's demanded." Dale paused. "He wants to talk to

you first. Alone."

I shot up. "No! No, please don't... don't leave me alone with him!"

"Sshhh, shh, calm down! Here's how we'll do it. You two will be sitting in the kitchen and we'll be waiting right outside the door. I'm not sure what he wants to tell you, but... whatever. We'll see." He patted on the back and told me he would come get me when it was time.

I do not want to talk to him. I do not want to be anywhere near him. But I have to make up for my mistake. It could have gone much worse. The fact that he's still willing to take the peaceful approach has me hopeful but... I feel nauseous.

The worst thing is that I have gotten even more of the black milk into me. My theory is that it accelerates the process of turning. Judging from how I'm feeling at the moment, it can't be long until I'm a walking corpse.

I'm exaggerating, but I have to. Either that or I'll start crying again.

on a mission

After the horrors of yesterday night, I tried to get at least some rest in the early morning hours, but laid wide awake. At around ten, when the sun was already high in the sky, Dale came knocking on my door.

He greeted me with a forced smile, obviously trying to appear confident. He looked like he hadn't gotten a wink of sleep either. "Are you ready?" he asked softly.

I swallowed and bit my lip. "I don't want to do this," I confessed.

"I know," Dale muttered. I remember thinking there was something off about him. As if he was quarrelling or struggling with himself. The frown on his face looked deeply conflicted.

Ever since I arrived here, I found it hard to trust anyone in this home. For all I know, it's like Bridget said, they could most certainly sell me out. I'm not even sure if it was smart to trust her. Then again, while trying to kill Warin was not successful, I'm glad I tried. For a very short moment, I had been certain he was dead, and those were some of the happiest few seconds of my life. I still hoped Dale would remain honest with me though. Up to that point, he had not really given me any indication that he wouldn't.

I straightened up and got out of bed. Dale nodded at me and held open the door. I grabbed the revolver and fixed the locket around my neck.

"He's in the kitchen," Dale uttered.

I followed him downstairs. My heart was pounding in my chest and my stomach felt uncomfortably light, almost as if I was drunk on nervousness. Bridget, Dean, Rick and Betty were standing in the living room. The red-haired woman shot me an apologetic glance.

"Watch what you say," she whispered as I passed her. "Be careful."

I nodded and proceeded to lean around the corner to peer into the kitchen and there was Mitchell, sitting at the table, a plate and a glass

of milk in front of him. Why did he look like Mitchell? The same broad frame, the same dark brown hair, the same large face.

A terrible thought crossed my mind. It took all my strength to swallow my apprehension and set foot into the small room. The second I entered, his head jerked around and his eyes fixated on me. I quickly glanced back at Dale who was standing right behind me. He made a half-hearted attempt at a reassuring smile. I bit my lip and stepped forth.

Not-Mitchell didn't budge when I approached. He remained seated, waiting for me to pull out a chair and sit down across from him. For a few seconds, I held my breath, not daring to break his gaze, not daring to say a word. I watched as he took the piece of bread on his plate and slowly tore of a piece of it. He dropped the smaller piece and continued to halven the remaining part, all the while glaring at me with narrowed eyes.

I opened my mouth to say something, but nothing but a low cawing noise came out. I was almost relieved when he finally spoke up, that awful, unnatural voice of his making me shudder.

"Do you happen to be cold, Leah?"

My lips were unable to form any words, not even a short "no" left my mouth. Instead, I lowered my gaze and shook my head.

"Are you certain? You can tell me if you are cold, Leah."

"I'm not," I breathed.

A sardonic smile crossed his lips. "Strange. I could have sworn I saw you tremble just now."

Another pause followed. Warin grabbed one of the bread pieces and slowly brought it up to his mouth, letting it vanish behind a row of black teeth.
I realized that I had never actually seen him take in any food before.

He immediately picked up another piece and carefully tore it in half.

“Is Mitchell alright?” I managed to ask, my breath shaking.

“I can take on the forms of those who are alive just as easily as of those who have deceased.”

“Is Mitchell alright?” I repeated.

Warin looked up from his plate. “He is.”

I swallowed hard. “I would like it better if you weren’t using his form.”

Not-Mitchell raised his eyebrows, before slowly, his face began to contort. His jaw cracked as his mouth stretched almost all the way up to his ears, baring his ashen teeth. Saliva instantly began to run down his chin. His eyes grew smaller and more narrow until they were nothing but thin, menacing slits. His fingers started to stretch, growing longer, slimmer, his nails growing pointed and sharp until they resembled claws more than hands.

The dark hair I knew so well from my co-worker and friend took on a ghostly white color. His skin had become so pale and ashen I was certain I could see the veins pulsing underneath. Once again, his clothing slackened as it adapted to his lean, starved body. I think I can by now fathom his appearance a little clearer. He looked sort of like these modern artworks depicting skinwalkers, just more... human. But by no means any less predatory.

I took a deep breath, trying my best not to seem frightened. It was almost impossible though. I felt my hair stand more on end with every second that I held his gaze.

“Are you mad at me?” I finally managed to press out.

Warin shook his head. “It was not your fault that you attacked me. You were coerced into doing it after all. You are delightfully trusting. It is

endearing, really, but you have to stop listening to dumb people. Too bad that trait has never acted in your favor before."

The way he spoke made me shiver. Every word he said was drawn out, slow and deliberate. "Is there anything you wanted to tell me... or...?"

Warin shot me a thin smile. "There is. I would like to know just what it is that you are doing here. You do not belong here. Not with these greedy, gullible, treacherous people. They are just waiting to throw you under the bus, you know?"

I gulped, reaching up to grab at my locket. I had placed the revolver in my lap, its weight reassuringly pressing down onto my thighs.

"Stop being so immature," Warin told me. "Take that locket off, will you?"

"I don't want to," I replied, wrapping my fingers around it even tighter. "Why would I believe you of all people?" I added.

"I admit I was not always upfront with my intentions towards you. Still, I do believe to be the lesser evil," he replied.

"I don't think so," I hissed. I wasn't even sure what he meant to be honest, but I didn't want to listen to him either.

"What a shame." He regarded me with an unreadable expression. Or maybe it was just his twisted face that made it come off that way. "You should still listen to what I have to say though."

I averted my eyes, nodding for him to go ahead.

"I fancy a wager."

I couldn't help but immediately look up at him, growing attentive at these words.

“I believe I overheard you promise a certain doe-eyed man that you would free him from his misery. I want you to know that that is nothing you could ever do on your own. But I could.” He picked up a piece of bread and nibbled on its crust, black goo soaking into the dough.

“And at what price?” I inquired.

“You sound more apprehensive than expected. Maybe I should negotiate over Nathan’s life with someone who cares a bit more?”

“I do care, I just want to know what...” My voice trailed off as I followed Warin’s gaze to the doorway. I turned to see Dale peeking in at us with a frown.

“This is not the time to be shy, Dale. Come in. Join us. Tell her the truth for once,” Warin said in a way too cheerful tone, cracking me a sanguine smile.

My former manager slowly trotted inside. He looked over at me with sad eyes, as if begging for forgiveness. “I’m sorry,” he uttered, his voice cracking.

“I don’t... what’s going on?” I stammered, my gaze darting between smirking Warin and sheepish Dale.

“He said he wanted to help you, right? I am sure that was true at first, at least until he realized what there was to win back. I overstepped a couple boundaries. My mistake. Even though I can hardly say I regret it. Still, there was no real reason to drive you all the way out here, was there? Do you want to know what I think? I think Dale heard the ones underground cursing you out, so he fired you, unsure of what might happen to you. Soon after however he realized that he had lost a valuable bargaining chip. As an employee of the park, he had a certain authority over you. But he fired you. The only way to regain some authority would be to make you his and his family’s guest. Stupid to lure me over to a place where the family’s young ones are at, but at this point we both know that Dale acts before he thinks.”

I turned to face Dale. “Is that true?” I whispered, my voice faint and quiet.

Dale bit his lip. “I’m so sorry. I swear, this whole time I wasn’t sure if I’d go through with it, I never wanted to, I swear. I just... I...” He stopped and ran his fingers through his hair, pure desperation written all over his face.

“There you have your trustworthy friend.”

I spun around once again, only to behold Nathan’s soft, handsome features. Warin’s chin was resting on his fist as he smiled up at Dale with twinkling brown eyes. I felt sick at the sound of the Wild One’s cold, metallic voice coming from my friend’s mouth.

“Stop that,” Dale uttered huskily. “Don’t do that!” he added, more ferociously this time.

Not-Nathan let out an eerie chuckle, fully baring his coal teeth. Warin began to turn back to his true self, still laughing. Suddenly, I spotted something in the back of his throat. I watched in horror as two thin, black insect legs emerged from within his maw. Another two pairs soon followed as, slowly and deliberately, a large cockroach pulled itself out onto his lips, crawled all the way up his face and vanished in his white hair. As his cackles grew louder and louder, two more bugs scurried out from hid mouth only to disappear on his head. I felt like gagging.

“So. Are you willing to listen to my proposal? Or do I have to enlist your pathetic acquaintance’s help?”

“Go ahead,” I muttered.

“I will release Nathan from the Stagecoach if you make it back to him in the span of two days,” he said curtly. “You have to be in time. Also, I will most certainly join in on the fun. Think of it as a larger version of a game of tag. I will grant you a head start of, say, ten hours maybe. I am a gentleman after all. If you do not make it back to him in time or I

manage to find and catch you before you have reached him, you lose."

I swallowed. "What happens if I lose though?"

"I am very glad you asked. If you lose, I want you to get rid of that awful necklace of yours and that revolver too. No more silver, no more iron, no more laurel, sage or red verbena."

I frowned. That would render me completely powerless. Still, there was something incredibly tempting about this offer. Two days... I could make it in two days, right? I could try my luck with hitchhiking. It should not be that hard. "I still have a few questions though," I interjected.

"Ask away," Warin offered, plucking apart his bread once again.

"Why me?"

"Because chasing Dale around would not be any fun whatsoever."

"No, I mean... why me of all people in the park? Why are you so... so focused on me?"

Warin didn't respond. He just smiled dryly and shoved a tiny piece of bread into his mouth. That's when I noticed something. Three cockroaches had crept out of his mouth, there were three bullet holes in his chest, three Wild Ones in the park...

Swallowing my apprehension, I repeated my question. Again, I received no reply. I asked again and Warin shot me a displeased look, yet opened his mouth and answered.

"You stayed in the park on your own accord. Nobody ever forced you, and I am sure you were not in a beggar's position. Admit it. You found it exciting. You must have felt it too, I know you did."

"So did the others, what's your point?" I inquired.

Warin leaned a bit forward. “My point is I really, really like you. The others are alright. Mostly. But I like you most of all.”

The way he said this made me shiver. This answer was elusive and I can’t claim I really understood it, but it felt so... wrong. I didn’t actually want to know more, but I just had to ask. “What happened when you were alone in the restroom with me?”

No response. He merely sat and stared at his plate. I did the same as earlier and repeated the question twice. I wish I hadn’t.

“You were unconcious. I took your backpack and poured what was in it out onto the floor. Then I collected the things that I could touch without getting hurt and put them back inside. Then I opened your mouth. It was difficult since you weren’t awake, but -”

“That’s enough,” I muttered. I didn’t want to hear any more of this. At least that confirmed my suspicions. “Why is it that the other not-actors have to hate laurel too?”

“Because it is the one that hurts the most.”

Another elusive response. Admittedly, this one was a bit more useful.

“Have you made up your mind?” Warin inquired. I could sense that his patience was wearing thin. Instead of asking what the number three meant to him, I nodded.

“There’s one more thing though. You’re expecting me to play for Nathan’s sake alone, but if I lose, I have to let go of everything that protects me. If I win, I want my humanity back as well. I want you to... stop whatever weird shit you’ve started doing to my body. Is that clear?”

Warin chuckled. “Certainly. I thought that was just common sense.”

“Don’t pretend. You wanted to screw me over.” I got up from my seat. “I’m not gonna lose any time. I’m getting my stuff, and then we’re getting

started."

I shot Dale, who had been standing quietly in the corner of the kitchen up to that point, a short, void glance. He looked back at me with tear-filled eyes. I merely shook my head and went upstairs to grab my belongings. When I had gathered everything, of course including the locket and the revolver, I passed Dale's family once again in the kitchen. Warin was still sitting at the table, watching me with what I assumed to be amusement.

"The wager is on then," I told him firmly, hiding my sweaty palms in my pockets.

"See you soon," he said in a menacingly tranquil tone.

"Fuck you," I hissed, marching out the back door.

It was high noon when I left. I had first made my way out of the neighborhood of Dale's family home and wandered alongside the road for a little while. I had stopped near the edge of the woods adjacent to it and had just pulled out my cell phone to check my position. There had to be some way I could get back home. I figured I would just need to find the right route.

Suddenly, I felt a tug on my shirt. I looked down and almost jumped in shock when I laid eyes on... her. Right next to me stood a little girl, barefoot and in a simple light pink dress. If it hadn't been for her head being that of a rabbit but the size of that of a child, I would have never thought there to be anything off about her.

"Hello," the rabbit-headed girl greeted me.

It took me a while to calm down from my initial shock. "Hi," I uttered, mouth still agape.

"You're the one they're all looking for," she said. "Where are you going?"

“I need to... uh... I have to go back to the park... I...” My voice trailed off, losing itself in incoherent stammerings.

“I can help you! I know a shortcut,” she said, clutching my fingers with her tiny hand.

I was suspicious at first, very much so in fact. That was until she explained that she harbored a deep resentment towards the Wild Ones.

“Especially not Warin. I followed him here, you know. He’s a dingus.”

I chuckled a bit. I figured what the hell. Maybe this is another instance of me being too naive. Right now, we’re sitting in the woods, taking a break from walking. She says it’s okay, because once we reach the shortcut, we’ll be at the park in no time. I have yet to ask why she hates Warin so much, but I do think I can trust her. It feels right somehow. Plus, in the short time we have spent together so far, the little cutie hasn’t once asked me for my name. I think that’s a good sign.

I can’t believe I’m actually doing this.

down the rabbit hole

I used to work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. While I wasn't sure about this yesterday, trusting my gut and therefore the bunny-headed girl has actually paid off for once. I didn't enlist Dale or his family's help because by now, I trust them just about as much as, you guessed it, some random rabbit. That doesn't mean I don't understand where Dale was coming from. I do and I don't even blame him, but it's hard to stay rational when you realize a person would willingly trade you for another.

Calling a co-worker would definitely not have been an option, seeing as it took Dale over a whole day to get us here. So, if I had been to call one of my friends, they would not only have to drive all the way out here with no detailed knowledge of the location except maybe their navigation system, they would also have to take me all the way back, and that's not something I have time for.

Also, even though it hurts to say this, there's not too much I have left to lose anymore. I was at a point where my main motto was simply "fuck it".

The short break the rabbit-headed girl and I took from walking was spent on a small clearing in the woods. I was leaning against a tree. I had just relayed the details of the wager to her. She was sitting across from me with crossed legs, regarding me attentively.

"My name's Madeleine," she suddenly said.

"Uh... what?" I was a bit caught off guard.

"I don't need to know your name, but my name is Madeleine. It's the name my parents gave me. I'd like for you to call me that." I nodded slowly and Madeleine's ear twitched slightly. "We're pretty close now by the way. It's very important that you're well-rested. You need to be in your right mind for you to enter."

I had already strongly suspected this, but I still had to ask. "You're taking me to the underground, right?"

Madeleine nodded. “Yes. Are you, like... okay with that?”

“I am,” I replied with a soft sigh. “Nothing to lose here. So... why are you helping me exactly? Why do you hate the Wild Ones? Aren’t you one yourself?”

“I am, but I hate that too. The Wild Ones are bastards, the whole lot of them.” She cleared her throat. Her voice was faltering and squeaky. “About a year ago, they took me. I used to live with my mom and dad and my little brothers near the woods. These same ones right here, just way further up there.” She pointed behind us, roughly into a northern direction. “One night when I was awake, something came in through the window. It was summer, so I’d left it open.

There were like, two or three of them. One dragged me outta bed while holding my mouth shut. And then the other one... the other one just slid under the blanket and it suddenly looked just like me. The other one held me real close and I tried to scream, but... it didn’t let me. It jumped back out through the window and brought me you-know-where. It kept me there and... well. I’m actually not even allowed outside. No one is.

But when Warin came through, everyone kissed his ass of course. They all got out of his way, so I just... you know. I just snuck after him. No one watches out for the rabbit kid when that gross asshole is coming through.” She almost sounded proud of herself. “Everyone says he’s on thin ice for acting the way he did, but no one does anything. Not yet at least.”

“I’m sorry to hear that, about you being... exchanged,” I remarked, not quite sure what else to say. “But will going through the underground really help me get back to the park faster?”

“Definitely. Time works different down there, and space too. It’s hard to describe, but you’ll see for yourself. Everything that’s big up here is way smaller down there. But we gotta be real careful. I heard a lot of them talk about how you more or less attacked the ones in the park.”

“So, you’re telling me we’re going to a nightmare underground world where everyone wants to kill me? Isn’t that gonna get you in trouble too?”

“First off, it’ll be worth it. I hate Warin and I hate Moth and Mulberry. I just wanna see the looks on their dumb faces. The ones who can stay on the surface, they just...” She fumbled for words. “They don’t deserve it! They don’t even hide like the one who replaced me, they’re in plain sight of fucking everyone! I know it sounds stupid, but I hate them for it. Like, out of everyone down there, I hate them the most.”

I tried to smile at her. She was really being a bit childish, but if a grudge like that would be getting me back to the park, so be it. “Say, is there anyone who, like... makes the rules down there? You know... who runs this place?”

Madeleine thought for a while before answering. “I guess you could say it’s the old ones. Warin is one of them. The longer you’re around, the further up in the food chain you are.”

“Are there ones that are even older than Warin?”

The white bunny nodded. “There are, but there’s not too many of ‘em. Those are the ones who are so angry at him by the way. You don’t just break a contract, you know? You don’t do that down there. What makes it even worse is that the old ones are the same who see you as a pest as well. But don’t worry about them too much, I’m sure we won’t meet any of them. They’re too idle to ever leave their sleeping places, really. Can’t imagine one of them appearing in our way.”

I let go of a soft sigh of relief. That was indeed some reassuring news.

“I still gotta warn you though. Humans have trouble entering the underworld. I remember my first few hours down there... it was awful. It’s the air, you know? Do you have anything you can breathe into?”

I nodded and pulled up the collar of my shirt, pressing it over my mouth

and nose. Madeleine shrugged. “That’ll probably do, I guess. See, the air is... it makes you go woozy if you’re not used to it, so try not to breathe in a lot.”

“Won’t they try to attack me?” I asked.

“Not if they don’t notice us they won’t,” Madeleine giggled and gave me a mischievous look. “If I managed to sneak outside, who says we can’t manage to make our way through as well? We just gotta be real inconspicuous. Then no one will even care. If things do go south, you can still fight, right?”

I cracked the rabbit-headed girl a reassuring smile. “I’ll try,” I said, suppressing a chuckle.

“Okay, what else to know... stick by my side. Don’t eat or drink anything you find down there and don’t talk to anyone but me. Try and hide that necklace of yours, they’ll sense it. If I were you, I’d keep it on though. It’ll keep you from going weird,” Madeleine warned sternly.

“Going weird?” I repeated, just in the process of taking off my necklace and looping it around my wrist so I could hide it under my sleeve.

“Uh, yeah. About that... I don’t wanna scare you but... I’ve seen people being dragged into the underground again and again. They try to resist, but then, when they’re halfway through the changing process... they go all strange and it’s like they’re suddenly super happy and it’s plain creepy. I can’t remember if I acted like that too, but nowadays, it really freaks me out.” Madeleine stared at the grass in front of her.

“It’s odd you remember all that so clearly,” I remarked.

Madeleine simply shrugged and rose to her feet before helping me up too. “I never forgot who I am. That’s all. Let’s go now.”

She didn’t let go of my hand when we got back on our way. We walked a little deeper into the woods until we reached a large tree in front of

which the rabbit-headed girl came to a halt. “It marks the entrance,” she explained curtly, a bit breathless. She then led me around the tree.

On the other side of the trunk, there was a wide, pitch-black hole in the ground. My eyes widened as I stared down into the abysmal darkness. Madeleine must have noticed my worried expression since she looked up at me with wide eyes and asked, “Do you still wanna do this?”

“Yes,” I replied, swallowing my apprehension. A strange curiousity had gotten a hold of me. I somehow felt like being on a rollercoaster again, shivering with both excitement, fear and anticipation.

“Alright. Here we go.” Madeleine’s voice was firm and she lowered herself to the ground, getting down on all fours. “Stay behind me,” she ordered. I did as she told me and, once she had disappeared in the darkness of the hole, I followed her.

The soil under my palms and knees was wet and soft. I could feel it dampen my pants and I had to duck a little to squeeze my backpack inside with me. The light of the surface soon lost itself in the pitch-black tunnel.

“Are we even gonna be able to see anything once we’re down there?” I whispered, not daring to raise my voice.

“Yeah. There’s always a bit of light. There’s, like, tiny fires everywhere,” Madeleine replied calmly. I could see the faint white shine of her head bobbing up ahead of me.

We must have crept through the tunnel for minutes. I believe I held my breath for the longest time. My cheeks were tingling with nervousness, a sensation which intensified with every inch that brought me closer to the end of the passage. I could feel my heart pounding in my chest. Suddenly, I noticed the slight smell of flowers and rotten fruit join the fresh, brown scent of the earth. It got stronger and stronger the further we descended, and by the time Madeleine warned me that we would have to jump soon, it had completely filled my nose and throat.

“This is the end of the passage,” my guide panted. “Get ready for a bit of a tumble.”

With that, the white spot suddenly disappeared and I could hear a low thump coming from somewhere below me. Reaching out to feel my way about in the tunnel, I discovered that there was nothing there in front of me. I turned a bit so I would land on my feet, not sure how big of a fall there was to expect, then carefully pushed myself closer and closer to the edge until I felt myself slipping off.

To my surprise and delight, I landed safely. My feet hit the ground first and instantly sank into its coating, which I assumed to be foliage at first. Looking down however, I found myself standing in a sticky, gooey mixture of rotten fruit, definitely the source of the strange smell, decaying flowers and wilted leaves, all resting atop an unidentifiable greenish morass.

Glancing around, I noticed that we were in some sort of high cave, the walls of which were illuminated by dimly flickering makeshift torches that were mounted to them. Madeleine grabbed my hand. Her naked feet had sunken in all the way up to her ankles.

“Let’s go,” she whispered, gently pulling me along as she moved forward, a squishing noise accompanying each of her steps.

At the far end of the hall, the wall gave way to another passage, this one however large and easily accessible on foot. Before we had reached its end however, Madeleine gestured for me to stay back as she hastily leaned in to peek around the corner. “Alright, coast’s clear,” she quietly exclaimed, waving me over.

As we exited the passage, the first thing I noticed was the sound of water running. Upon looking around, I found myself standing in an even larger cave. There was what looked to be a spring in its wall, right next to where the passage ended. Murky, dark water was steadily splashing out of it, collecting itself in a ditch in the ground. I followed the canal with my eyes to find that it was running through the whole of the cave

like a small river.

Remembering what Madeleine had told me earlier, I pulled my shirt over the better half of my face so as to not breathe in too much of the fragrant air heavily hanging above us. The rabbit-headed child quickly proceeded to lead the way. I was surprised to find the tunnels and caves empty and was just about to ask why this was the case, when she suddenly halted in her tracks.

"Shh!" she uttered, even though I hadn't said a word. "Can you hear that?"

I listened intently, straining my ears. Somewhere ahead of us in distance, I could hear... murmuring. It was low and faint, but audible nonetheless.

"Okay, okay, don't panick," Madeleine stammered, even though it sounded more like she was talking to herself than to me. "We were bound to run into someone at some point. Maybe we can sneak around them."

We found the source of the whispers located in the room over. It was the largest cave yet. To my surprise, there were even trees and bushes growing inside of it. It looked like a small forest clearing, just... underground. The dark rivulet was running right through its middle as if parting the clearing into two halves.

There were two people, or rather two creatures lying next to each other on the ground. I squinted to try and get a better look at them. They both looked faintly humanoid, except that their limbs were unnaturally long. Neither their legs nor their arms had the same size. I couldn't help but think that it had to be nearly impossible to stand upright, let alone walk like that. They appeared to be quietly speaking to one another, their voices low and husky.

Madeleine gestured for me to follow her as she hurriedly entered the clearing and sank down behind a bush. I did as she told me, thankfully silent enough for none of the two Wild Ones to notice me. We began

to creep alongside the edge of the cave, hidden behind the thick green foliage of the hedge. As we passed the two resting creatures, I managed to pick up a few short snippets of their conversation.

To my bewilderment however, they weren't really talking. It was just words strung together in an unsensical manner. I thought I could hear things like "sleep" or "leaf" from time to time, but there was no way of being sure. It was grotesque.

By the time we had reached the end of the cave, neither of the two had noticed us. Madeleine quickly got up and began rushing into the next passageway and I hurried after her, the fabric of my shirt still pressed to my mouth. I almost collided with her when she stopped in her tracks, turned around and shoved me back into the hedge we had just emerged from. Covering my mouth with her tiny hand, she whispered, "Someone's coming!"

Cowering amidst the leaves and twigs, we watched as something large exited the tunnel. At first, I could only see its feet and hands as we were pressing ourselves to the ground and it was walking on all fours, but when I lifted my head a little, I could see the rest of it. I seriously wish I hadn't. The creature was knuckle-walking through the dirt. It looked like a mixture of a person and a large ape of sorts. That in itself wouldn't have startled me as much, but part of his face appeared to be... missing. It looked like half of its head had just melted into its skull.

I swallowed hard and Madeleine reached out to squeeze my hand. I shot her a grateful glance. When it had finally trotted past us, we got up again, quickly stumbling through the tunnel, me trying to catch up with my nimble guide. I noticed that we were following the little river. Every tunnel we passed, every cave we snuck through, the stream was always there. From time to time I would lose sight if it for a short moment, only to find it in the next room we entered. Occasionally, I would even spot entrances to smaller tunnels which appeared to be leading to the surface.

I remember thinking I would never be able to navigate around a maze

as complex as this, but Madeleine was nifty. She seemed to know exactly where we were headed, each turn and each step she took was decisive and determined.

I can hardly fathom the creatures we encountered on our way. None ever seemed to notice us, a lucky circumstance only explainable by Madeleine's skillfulness. The caves themselves were never too crowded. Sometimes, they would be completely empty, other times there would be up to five Wild Ones in them, but we never saw more than that at once.

The rabbit-headed girl appeared to be growing more and more confident. She had stopped frantically glancing around and checking if I was still behind her all the time. We were just walking through the probably twentieth tunnel, when suddenly, she froze mid-motion. "Oh no," I heard her breathe. Following her gaze, I almost instantly spotted the reason for her distress. Warin was standing on the far end of the hall we were heading towards, thankfully facing away from us.

He seemed to be talking to another creature, a smaller, stockier one. It too however looked distinctly humanoid. Madeleine quick-wittedly pulled me into the cover of a large, wide tree and I hid behind it as best I could.

"That's one of the elders," she breathed, deep concern in her voice.

We waited for a little while. I tried to pick up on what they were talking about, but I couldn't hear a thing. Judging from the look on Warin's already contorted face though, the conversation was getting a bit heated. Finally, the other creature disappeared into one of the smaller tunnels while Warin himself stomped off into pur direction. I held my breath and sank to my knees, pressing myself against the bark of the tree. Madeleine had laid down, pretending to be asleep. My pursuer strode past her without paying her any mind.

I was just about to let go of a sigh of relief, when suddenly, I felt cold, dry-skinned fingers wrapping themselves around my neck from behind.

The grip tightened and I was pulled up from the ground, only to be forcefully spun around and look right into Warin's ghostly pale eyes. His mouth had stretched into a wide, gleeful smirk.

"Hello."

He let out a loud, ferocious cackle and for a split second, I felt reminded of the Laughing Cowboy before I had known his actual name. I cursed inwardly at the realization that I didn't have my revolver at hand. It's funny how this came to my mind in such an unfavorable moment, but I really did like him a lot better back when he couldn't talk. I spotted a single cockroach climb out of his mouth and into his hair.

I bit my lip, struggling and finally managing to kick him in the stomach with all my might. He let out a startled gasp and let go of me and I took my chance to turn around and sprint towards the tunnel ahead. I didn't get too far though. I was rapidly pulled back and Warin shoved me to the ground, immediately placing a foot on my back. He pressed it right down on my spine, his heel digging painfully into the soft flesh right beside it.

Remembering the locket wrapped around my wrist, I lifted my hand and pressed it against his calf. Even through the fabric of his clothing, it seemed to hurt him, seeing as he almost immediately stumbled backwards. I scrambled to my feet, lifting my fists as Warin got ready to lunge at me again. I punched him in the chest, earning a satisfying whimper as I felt my hand make contact with the soft edge of one of the bullet holes. My success was short-lived though.

Before I could even pull back, he had already grabbed me by the arm, twisting it painfully. He tried to seize the other one as well, the one with the locket, but suddenly let out a cry of pain.

It was only then that I realized that Madeleine was not lying on the ground anymore. Instead, I found her large front teeth buried deeply in the flesh right above Warin's knee. She hissed as she whipped back her head, tearing out a small bit of flesh. She lunged forward, grabbed me by

the arm and before I knew it, we were on the run again.

I was sure I could hear Warin howl in fury when he took up chase again. We didn't bother hiding anymore. Instead, we dashed through the maze of tunnels and caves, side by side, both of us panting heavily. We didn't slow down though.

We passed multiple other Wild Ones on our way. Some didn't even realize that Madeleine was dragging me along, they seemed dazed and apathetic. Others however jumped to their feet and began to follow us. By the time Madeleine pointed up at a hole in the wall a little above the ground, I could hear their hurried steps and excited voices echo close behind us.

I jumped up first, grabbing onto the edge of the hole and pulled myself up as fast as I could. Not hesitating, I spun around and held out both my hands to Madeleine. She grabbed onto them and I heaved her up into the tunnel with all my strength. We hurried to crawl back out, the bright red light of the setting sun greeting us.

Rummaging around in my backpack, I produced a couple of leftover laurel and sage leaves. I sprinkled them around the entrance and added some red verbena from my locket. I even placed some of them in the hole itself.

"You think that'll keep them from coming after us?" I asked uneasily.

Madeleine nodded. "I for one don't wanna go near there now. Plus, we lost Warin anyways. I'm pretty sure we shook him off somewhere in there. The others aren't allowed outside anyways."

That was at least a little reassuring. I let go of a deep sigh, my sides burning and my legs aching. Still, we got on our way. We seemed to be pretty much in the middle of the woods, but those weren't the same ones as before. I could tell from the look of them. It sounded like there was a highway nearby, I could hear the growling of car engines and the screeching of tires. Naturally, we headed towards it.

“I’m sorry. I wanted to take you directly to the park,” Madeleine moaned, sounding genuinely disappointed. “Now I don’t even know where we are.”

“It’s okay, I’m just glad we...” my voice trailed off as we reached the side of the road. I knew this spot. Whenever I would drive out of town to visit my parents, I would pass take this exact route. From there to the park, it was only about a two hour long drive.

“We’re gonna make it,” I squealed, ruffling the rabbit-headed girl’s fur in a rush of excitement. I then quickly fumbled for my phone.

I called Darius. I’m not sure why him exactly, but his reliable tranquility was just about what I needed right then. He agreed to pick me up without asking a single question.

Madeleine and I waited by the side of the road. When his car finally pulled up on the roadside, we quickly hopped in. Darius had to do a double take at my companion. I think for a moment he believed he was hallucinating. I relayed what had happened as quickly and roughly as possible and he, level-headed as always, took it with a surprising calmness.

And here we are now, still in the car. It won’t be long until we’ll make it to the park. I’m not sure what will happen then, but for some reason, I’m rather confident. Sure, Warin got his hands on me for a few seconds back there, but I escaped, so that really can’t count as me being captured. I think we’re really going to make it.

desiderium

I work at an amusement park where only half of the actors are actual actors. The car ride was kind of relaxing, compared to the events that had led up to it. After a while of sitting in the car however, my back brushing against the seat, I felt a familiar sticky sensation on my skin.

I had been wearing a loose, thick shirt so I hadn't noticed right away that I had started to bleed again. Also, the journey into the underground had kept my mind fully occupied, so maybe I just hadn't paid any attention to fleeting discomfort. Now that I was leaning against the backrest, the fabric rubbing against my skin, I finally noticed the dampness.

"Sorry, could you pull over for just a second?" I begged my co-worker. Darius nodded and parked near the side of the road.

Madeleine, who had so far been staring out of the window from the backseat with wide, attentive eyes, perked up and tilted her head at me. "What is it?" she asked.

I wordlessly wrangled off my shirt. Thankfully, the blood had not left any bigger marks on it yet, but after also taking off the singlet I had been wearing underneath, I found that it was completely soaked. The blood had already started to dry, causing me to flinch in pain as I had to peel the crusted fabric off my skin.

"Ah, crap," Darius muttered.

"Don't worry, I don't think it's gotten onto the car seat," I said calmly, inspecting the large wet stains on my undershirt. I remembered I still had another fresh one in my backpack and after a bit of fumbling, I quickly put it on before slipping back into my shirt.

"Your tattoos are almost all gone. There's just like, a few colorful stains left," Darius remarked with a concerned look on his face.

"What? Ah, shit..." I cursed. "I loved them! Fuck... On the other hand, what was I expecting. They were already bleeding when we were messing around by the entrance. No wonder they've gone to crap while I was

actually down there."

"Why'd they bleed out though?" Madeleine asked.

"It's because tattoo ink partly consists of iron, I believe," I explained. "The underground really doesn't like that kinda stuff, does it?" I dropped the bloodied singlet under my seat before grabbing my backpack and pulling out my whip and revolver. After I had failed to keep either of them at hand last time, I wanted to make sure I'd have them closeby in case I would need them.

Darius watched me pensively before pulling back onto the road. "I can't believe you've managed to keep it together throughout this shit," he muttered, a hint of respect in his tone. "I would've probably just lost it at some point."

I smiled. "I'm too stupid to care. Speaking of which, there's still some things I don't understand. Like, remember that photo I found in Dale's office?"

"The one with the people with no faces?" Darius offered.

"Yeah. Like, what's up with that?"

The rabbit-headed girl suddenly leaned forward. "Faceless people on photos? That's what happens to people when one of the Wild Ones takes their form. Their faces vanish from all photos with them in them." After a short pause, she added, "I heard one of the ones who took me away talk about that. He said that the one who took my form should see to destroying whatever pictures they found of me around the house so mom and dad wouldn't get suspicious."

"Woah. That's awful," Darius muttered.

Madeleine nodded. "Yeah, my life sucks. But at least I get to piss off Warin, so that's a win."

“Another thing I’ve been wondering about is what the number threemeans to Warin. I noticed it when I watched him eat. He kept breaking his bread into three pieces. He also got shot three times, maybe that’s why, but I’m not sure,” I thought out loud.

“Actually, a ton of the older ones have a thing for the number three. Like, they always do stuff three times,” the rabbit-headed girl chimed in. “Like eating three berries at once or repeating what they say three times. I never quite understood what the deal with that is, though.”

Suddenly perking up, I took out my phone and dialed Clara’s number. She’d know, I remember thinking. My friend picked up almost right away and I put her on speaker. “Hey, girl,” she greeted me cheerfully. “I’ve been waiting for you to call! Got some free time? We could --”

“Sorry, I kinda need your help,” I explained curtly. I felt sorry for interrupting her, especially since she had no idea what I had experienced these last few days. I made a mental note to tell her sometime. She’d totally freak out. “What does the number three mean?”

She paused for a second. “Like, in occultism?”

“Yes.”

“Okay. Uh... first thing that comes to mind is the Rule of Three. Not sure how to explain, but think, like... karma. You know, everything you do comes back to you. The Three-fold Law basically just says that it comes back to you three times. It can count for every aspect of life, but it’s especially related to magic. Then there’s the number three in the Christian faith, as in the devil tempted Jesus three times and there’s the Holy Trinity and so on...” Her voice trailed off. “Why you wanna know?”

“I’ll explain later, I promise. Okay, thanks, bye,” I quickly stammered before ending the call. “You think that may be it?” I asked Madeleine.

“I got no clue. Maybe it’s just meaningful to ‘em, like... who knows. They’re a bunch of stiffs anyways. No wonder they’re so into numbers

and rules." She sounded a little nervous and I couldn't help but wonder if she might have been thinking about what the ones underground would do to her if they would find her amiss.

We pulled up in front of the park's employee entrance only minutes later. The sun had fully set by now and the moon was high in the sky. I could see the ferris wheel looming over us in the distance, faintly shimmering in the pale silver light. It looked ominously foreboding.

I tucked the revolver into my waistband as best I could and secured the whip to one of my belt loops.

"So... what do we do now?" Darius asked.

"I'm not quite sure to be honest. I need to go on my own though. First, I gotta get to Nathan. That was the aim of my wager, after all. I'm not sure if Warin is already here, but I don't think it matters either way. He never said I had to beat him to the park, just that I'd have to be here before two days passed. And this was hardly one single day, so... I think I'm good. Let's just hope he makes good on his promise." I swallowed, looking up at the night sky pensively.

"I'm pretty sure he has to," Madeleine told me reassuringly. "Then again, he doesn't really stick to rules all the time, apparently," she added in a worried tone.

"Maybe we should call the others," Darius offered. "You know. In case things get out of hand."

His audible concern and the implications of his words sent a shiver down my spine. "I don't want to get them into trouble," I muttered.

"We could use some help though. I'm not leaving here either, by the way," Darius stated.

"Well, do it then. But tell them exactly what they're getting themselves into. I don't want them to get hurt. Madeleine, stay with Darius, okay?"

The rabbit-headed girl nodded. I cracked her and my colleague a forced smile before turning to get on my way. “Be careful!” I heard Madeleine shout after me.

The park had always been frightening at night. There’s just something to it, knowing that you’re not on your own and that something could be hiding right around the corner. This time however, I felt like the sound of my quickening heartbeat could drown out that of my breathing itself. I marched through the streets, the utter silence keeping me on high alert.

I was heading for Twin Vale Point, but I couldn’t help but stop by the horror section. Mr Scratch’s cage stood deserted next to the funhouse. I simply wanted to see him. I needed this. I whistled sharply, then uttered his name a couple times. Finally, I could hear rustling coming from somewhere around the corner and only seconds later, the sock puppet came bounding out from behind the building.

He would have almost collided with me, but came to a surprisingly swift halt and rubbed his horned black head against my shoulder in greeting.

“Baby,” I whispered. “Aw, it’s so good to see you...” I reached out to pet him and he nuzzled me as if to ask where I’d been. Realizing I had no time, I reluctantly pulled away and set out for the Western town once again, only to notice the steady thumps of his paws following me. I turned around and smiled at him. “You comin’ with me, buddy?”

The sock puppet quickly caught up to me and we proceeded to pick up our pace, running through the streets side by side. The ground soon changed from dark and solid to light and sandy underneath my feet. Upon entering Twin Vale Point, I felt a sharp sting of reminiscence as I was instantly reminded of love I used to harbor for its rugged, charming aesthetic.

It took us a while to find the Stagecoach. Just when I was about to panick, thinking that Warin had screwed me over and taken away Nathan to some other place, I heard the sound of horses puffing. I spun around

and there he was. He had parked the carriage right in front of a saloon. I shuddered when I realized that it was the exact same one in which I had encountered the Laughing Cowboy for the last time. The last time before I had learned his name.

Still, I immediately ran over to the coachseat, the sock puppet following suit. Nathan was sprawled out across it, peacefully slumbering, the plush stork clutched tightly in his hands. I reached up to nudge him awake. His eyes fluttered open and he drowsily sat up in his seat.

"What's going on...?" he murmured, blinking and rubbing his head. I could see him squint in an attempt to make out my features in the darkness. "Leah, is that you?"

"Yes! Yes, it's me! Are you alright?"

"Of course..." he slurred. "Why wouldn't I be? What are you doing here?"

"I don't know if I got time to explain, but I'm here because of you and everything's gonna be fine. Now I just need to wait..."

"Wait for what?" Nathan asked, regarding me and my fluffy companion in confusion.

"Not for what," I corrected him. I glanced around, wishing it was only a little brighter. Where was he? Should I just stay here? I had reached Nathan. I had won. I felt myself growing more and more nervous, my fingers fidgeting with the locket around my neck.

Suddenly, Mr Scratch let out a low, soft growl. I spun around only to find the broad silhouette of a man standing out against the moonlight. He was casually leaning against the wooden porch pillar of the closed gift shop right across from us. I could tell by the fit of his clothing that he was Colt again.

"Good to see you." A low chuckle erupted from his throat. "Did you miss me?"

“With every knife so far,” I replied dryly.

Warin let out a loud cackle before lowering his voice. “You wouldn’t talk like that if you knew what’s good for you.”

“So? Will you make good on your wager? I’m here. I made it.” I tried hard to sound firm, but my voice was shaking ever so slightly.

“And I am incredibly proud of you.” The cowboy’s tone was mocking. “I did have you though. For just a mere few seconds I had you.”

“Like hell you did! You said “find and capture”. Me and my friend kicked your ass, I’d hardly call that captured.”

“But do you not think that is a bit unfair?”

I shook my vehemently shook my head. “I don’t. Also, you said you’d give me a head start of ten hours. No way that was that long in.”

“I said “maybe” I would give you ten hours.”

I felt my heart drop. “You can’t do this! No matter when you think you caught me, I made it out and I’m standing here right now. You promised. No matter how you look at it, I won.”

Warin let out a soft sigh. “Come here.” He gestured for me to come closer.

“What? No way.” I quickly leaned behind Mr Scratch, my hand on the revolver.

“I said come here,” he repeated, more sternly this time.

I’m not sure why, but I felt my eyes tear up ever so slightly. “Make good on your bargain,” I hissed, clinging to the sock puppet’s fur. I could hear a growl rumble in his throat ever so quietly.

“To be frank, I did not think you would make it. When I was underground at the time, I was not even looking for you to be honest.” He let out a short laugh. “Imagine my surprise.”

I caught Nathan’s glance out of the corner of my eye. He was looking beyond confused. “What’s... what’s going on?” he stammered.

I shook my head in his direction. Warin pushed himself off the pillar and slowly began to approach us. There was a certain ease in his step, but as he got closer, I could see the deep scowl on his face. He reached out, grabbed Nathan by the collar and swiftly flung him off his coachseat. He let out a startled gasp followed by a muffled grunt as his body hit the ground.

“What are you doing?” I whimpered in a voice much more anxious than I had intended. “You’re hurting him!”

Warin shrugged and gave Nathan a small kick in the ribs. I lunged at him, pushing him away. He stumbled a few steps backwards, but quickly regained his footing.

“There. He’s on the ground again.”

Ignoring Warin’s sneer, I bent down by Nathan’s side. He was lying in the dirt, motionless. “Nathan,” I uttered, patting him on the shoulder. My heart was pounding in my chest and my head was spinning. I had no idea what was happening. “Are you okay? Say something!”

My friend let out a low groan. Warin chuckled from behind me. “Ah, he’ll be fine. If you were to only sit on a carriage all day, you would not remember how to walk right away either. He is just a little weak is all.”

I swallowed and shakily rose to my feet. “Does that mean you fixed him? Just like that?” After a short pause, I added, “Are you shitting me?”

“Am not.” He sounded almost annoyed with me. “Think about it. It was me who chose him. He belonged to me. It was due to my will that he was

bound to that carriage. When I want him to be able to get off it again, he can get off it."

I calmed down a bit, my breathing slowing down. "Good," I uttered, slightly more confident. "Now make me normal again."

Warin let out that same haughty low chuckle. "Now why would I do that?"

I froze. "That was part of your end of the wager! You said you would --"

"I said nothing of that sort. Your exact words were that you wanted me to, and I quote, stop whatever weird shit I started doing to your body. I will therefore not try to feed you again." His usage of the word "feed" nearly made me gag. "Not that I'd need to anymore. That was what you meant, right?" he added mockingly.

"No! You know it wasn't! I want my humanity back," I protested, a mixture of both rage and fear bubbling up inside me.

"I am so sorry. I simply did not understand it that way. Then again, as we have already discussed in regards to Dale, one cannot bargain with something one doesn't possess."

"What do you mean?"

"Eleven days. It's been eleven days since I first fed you. Face it. You are way too far gone for there to be anything left one could consider salvagable. It's just a matter of time now until it's complete."

"No," I breathed, then, more fiercely, repeated, "No! You're lying, you... you fucking asshole, this isn't how this works! I asked you for it, and you said it was common sense, I..." My voice trailed off as I began to fumble for words. Not knowing what else to say, anger took over and I lunged at him, pushing uselessly against his chest. He just laughed. He stood there and he just fucking laughed. "But you just did it with Nathan!" I protested.

”Well, Nathan has never been to the underground. That is the difference, you see? Those who stay up here... they become like your friend. Those who are brought down there however... well, I am sure you can figure that put on your own. Your little bunny is a prime example.”

“I trusted you,” I whispered.

“I know.”

I grabbed the revolver and, without hesitation, shot him in the stomach. He cursed and doubled over, coughing up black goo which dripped onto the dirt ground below him. My fingers trembling, I stepped closer, still aiming at him, ignoring my awareness of the futility of hurting him. He slowly rose to his feet. Except for a hole in his vest, there was nothing left of the wound the bullet should have torn into him.

“I wish you would stop doing that,” he hissed. “Is this really the road you want to go down? Come on now. We both know you were meant to --”

I shot him again, this time, the bullet entered right above his hip. He stayed still, staring at me intently. Then, all of a sudden, he lunged forward, grabbed me the hair and flung me to the ground. Before he could press his foot down on me though, I pushed myself up and stumbled right into the sock puppet who was motionlessly standing behind me. He growled and was obviously on high alert, but he didn’t do anything.

“You think he will help you?” Warin called out, appearing to have noticed my confusion. “He won’t attack the one who made him.”

By now he was steadily walking towards me. I quickly scrambled to my feet and, for lack of a better idea, began to run. I could hear him pick up his speed as well, his boots drumming on the dirt ground as he took up chase. I didn’t know where I’d be going and in the darkness, I couldn’t even quite tell where I was exactly. The only thing I knew was that I needed to shake him off and get back to the employee entrance somehow. That’s where Darius and Madeleine were waiting. They would

know what to do. They had to.

I rounded the corner behind the saloon, hoping that I could lose him somehow. Dashing through the empty sand streets, I let go of a breath when I saw the entrance sign to Twin Vale Point come into sight. I ran towards it, entering the horror section. I remember being grateful for the soft soles of my shoes. The quieter I'd be, the harder it'd be for him to find me.

I continued to sprint until finally, the entrance to Hollywood came into sight. By then, the footsteps behind me had trailed off in the distance. I didn't slow down though. My heart skipped a beat when I spotted a group of figures standing in front of it. The closer I got, the more I could make out. There were Darius and Madeleine, but also Mitchell, Oliver and Caroline. I ran towards them, not halting when I passed them, but hastily gesturing for them to follow me.

"Come, quick," I panted.

I did not have to tell them twice. Darius grabbed the rabbit-headed girl by the hand and pulled her along with him while the others followed suit. I led them to the restaurant where the Pianist was playing, rapt and unfazed as always. We crouched down behind the counter and I had to take a moment to catch my breath.

The questioning voices of my colleagues were drowned out my the sound of my pulse and beating heart. I heard Madeleine and Darius trying to explain the situation to them, but I knew very well there was no way they could fathom all this in such a short time.

My mind was racing as I feverishly tried to come up with an idea, something, anything, I couldn't keep running from Warin, I wanted to be back to normal, I wished desperately that all this was just a nightmare, some grotesque dream I hadn't yet managed to wake up from. Was I really beyond salvagable? I couldn't imagine it. I didn't want to.

Suddenly, a thought crossed my mind. If what Warin had said about

him essentially being the main authority over everyone he had turned was true, there might just be one way to get out of this situation. I wasn't sure if it made any sense, but I was basically clinging to straws. Maybe, in some magical way that was way beyond my understanding, it would work.

I needed to kill Warin.

I knew it had not worked the last time I had tried it, but the second I was about to discard the idea, the number three popped up in my mind. And all at once, I realized something, something I had never thought of before. Third time's the charm, right? Maybe all it took to actually destroy him were three relatively successful attempts. The first one had been made by Colt when he shot him with the iron bullets, the second one by me a few nights prior, and now...

If I were to get my hands on some iron I could use as a weapon, I would possibly stand a chance. But I neither had Colt's bullets nor Bridget's hunting knife. So what was I going to do? As if a switch had been flipped, another idea came to me seemingly out of thin air. Perhaps the iron bullets Colt had used were still stuck in his body. Maybe that was why they had never healed either.

I shot up, facing my co-workers. Upon seeing my stern gaze, they immediately fell silent. "We need to capture Warin," I said curtly.

About fifteen minutes later, I was standing beside the entrance of the hospital-themed funhouse. My heart was hammering in my chest when I opened my mouth and called his name. At first, I received no response. I called out again. "Warin? Warin, where are you? I just want to talk. I promise I won't try anything this time!"

Silence. Then, suddenly, I felt cold hands grabbing me by the shoulders, their chill even piercing through the fabric of my shirt. I gasped, spun around and, of course, there he stood.

"You... you're very good at sneaking up on me, I'll give you that. Or am

I just easy to startle?" I stammered breathlessly.

He stared at me with piercing pale eyes, an unreadable expression on his face. He didn't reply. I cursed inwardly. I could only pray this would work one more time.

I swallowed. "Please say something," I uttered. "Are you mad?"

He slowly, ever so slowly shook his head, but his face remained stiff and numb. I slowly took a step towards the entrance of the funhouse to see if he would follow. He did. I proceeded to walk inside before halting, waiting for him to come closer. Half of the room was pitch-black, no moonlight shining reaching the far corners.

The second he set foot inside, I grabbed him by the arm, pulled him closer and pushed him to the floor, letting out a scream. "NOW!"

Oliver, Caroline, Mitchell and Darius came lunging out from their dark hiding spots. Caroline and Darius grabbed Warin's legs and pressed them down while Mitchell and Oliver held his arms in place.

"We got him!" Mitchell yelled.

I fumbled for my phone and switched on its flashlight, pointing it at the struggling and hissing pretender. I then reached out to tear open his shirt. Peeling the wrinkly old fabric aside, I laid eyes on the three bullet holes. Ignoring the queasy feeling in my stomach, I plunged my pointer and middle finger into the lower one. I almost gagged as I made contact with the frayed, rotten flesh. Warin let out a howl of pain as my fingers proceeded to search for the iron bullet. I could only pray it wasn't to deep down.

Then, finally, my fingertips met with something hard. I pinched it with my nails and attempted to pull it out. It took me about an entire minute to produce it from the grayed flesh, but when I finally did, I wasted no time and tore out the other two as fast as I could. Warin was thrashing and squirming and my friends were visibly straining themselves to keep

him in place. I dropped my phone. I had no idea if this would work in any way. Still, I felt like I should at least try. [I removed the locket from my neck and pressed it to the upper bullet wound. Its tip sank into the flesh, but it wasn't nearly deep enough. I looked down at Warin and he stared back up at me with void pale eyes. For once, there was no hatred in his gaze, no jeer, no mockery and for a short moment, a mere split second, I hesitated.

"What are you waiting for? Do it!" I heard Caroline cry out from behind me.

I raised my hand and shut my eyes. Then, I brought my palm down on the locket with all my might. Warin let out a loud howl of pain, arching his back as the iron and silver filled with the red verbena blossoms buried themselves in his flesh. Collecting the old slugs in my fist, I forced open his mouth, trying to avoid his teeth, and shoved them inside. He was barely moving anymore, but still struggled to try and spit them out, but I pressed my hand over his lips.

Muffled screams of agony erupted from his throat and I squeezed my eyes shut, turning my head. I didn't want to look at him, I didn't want to see him die. And then, suddenly, his head grew limp in my grasp and fell to the floor. He must have finally swallowed them, he wasn't moving anymore. I slowly, ever so slowly, removed my wet, trembling palm from his mouth.

My friends uncertainly pulled away from him. It was only when Caroline hugged me from behind, squealing that I'd made it, that I felt hot, thick tears running down my cheeks. Madeleine jumped out from her hiding place, cheering and clapping her hands, but I felt like she was just somewhere far, far away.

I still know I stammered something about Nathan lying in Twin Vale Point and that he needed help, quickly, but everything else is just a blur by now.

Caroline drove me home that night. She has something really motherly

to her. She made sure I cleaned myself up a bit before essentially sending me to bed. She asked if she should stay on the couch for the night to watch out for me, but I gratefully declined. I passed out from exhaustion pretty quickly and slept dreamlessly.

I woke up this morning to five missed calls from Dale, two from Mitchell, one from Darius and three from an unknown number.

I called Darius back first. He told me that he had brought Nathan to a hospital. He had apparently woken up about six hours after they had taken him in. He asked if I was okay, and I told him I was. I asked him about Madeleine and he told me she had stayed in the park for the night.

The next person I called was Dale. He picked up immediately. After he had apologized a couple times and I reassured him that it was fine, he revealed that he was still on his way back to the park, but had already heard of what had happened as Mitchell had told him everything over the phone. I asked about the contract and whether it was still in place. He grew very stern as he told me that it was, but with Warin gone, there was no enforcer, and Mulberry and Moth most certainly wouldn't fill the role.

Of course, I immediately told him about Madeleine, suggesting he'd talk to the elders underground and see to it that maybe she could take his place. I think if the contract has to live on, she's the best guard of the park that we could possibly come across. Dale said he liked the idea and that he would see what he could make of it. I also asked if I could have my job back, and he said he could hardly deny me this wish given the circumstances.

I found my backpack resting near my bedside. I emptied it, spilling its contents all over the floor. Apart from my used clothing and the revolver which I dared not to look at, there was one of the iron nails I had carried around with me earlier too. I picked it up, feeling a slight sting. I'm not sure why, but I felt uncomfortable holding it. I tossed into the trashcan, then proceeded to freshen up and got on my way to the park. Just a quick visit to satisfy my yearning for the sock puppet. The first being I

encountered however was Madeleine. She was sitting by the employee entrance, almost as if she had been expecting me.

“Hello! How are you? Are you feeling better yet? You looked awful yesterday night,” she chattered, sounding partly worried and partly happy to see me.

I smiled at her. “I’m okay, I guess. How are you doing?”

“I’m great! Not only hasn’t anyone shown up to get me yet, I also had a really good night’s rest. I slept in the room of the piano man. Right on top of his piano.” She giggled.

“Weren’t you frightened at all? I was pretty shocked after yesterday...”

She shook her head. “No, I’m brave like that.”

She proceeded to take me by the hand and lead me off into the park. We passed the Aged Diva on our way through Hollywood and I waved at her. “Hi, Grace!” I called out. She didn’t say anything, but I believe to have seen her crack the tiniest of smiles.

I admit I’m disappointed that the contract is still in place. I had wished for the other not-actors to be... well, I don’t know what I wished for exactly. Even though this thought kept gnawing at me, it was hard to feel sad. The air of the park seemed a lot lighter somehow, the sun was shining... I was just happy for some reason.

We headed to Mr Scratch’s cage. He was lazily laying out front, but immediately bounced up to come running at me when we approached. We spent some time with him, until Madeleine suddenly pointed over at the haunted hospital.

“You think he’s still in there?” she asked.

“Sure. Dead people don’t move as far as I know.
Let Dale take care of it. I don’t really wanna see him,”

I muttered, swallowing the lump that had formed in my throat.

Madeleine couldn't be stopped though. Just the morbid curiousity of a child, I guess. She skipped over to the hospital to take a look inside, only to come sprinting back at full speed.

"He's not in there!" she squeaked.

"What?" I rose to my feet. "You're kidding, right?"

"No! He really isn't!" she insisted. "The entrance to the underground, where is it? We gotta go check!"

I led her over to the restroom, Mr Scratch following the two of us. To Madeleine's great relief, we found the restroom door in place and locked, just like we had left it after our investigation last time. God, it feels like that was ages ago.

"Thank goodness," Madeleine sighed. "Crap... I really thought he got away for a second. I guess Wild Ones just dissolve when they die. Like, turn to dust or something."

I refrained from pointing out to her that the restroom window was open. We went by the candyland to check on Moth and Mulberry. The ballerina was dancing atop her little stage and the Mime was hanging on one of the light fixtures as always.

"They really don't give a damn, do they?" Madeleine remarked and I giggled. I watched as the dancing squid-beaked girl twirled, turned and jumped in her tutu. It looked really pretty, now that I thought about it.

On our way back out, we passed Laila. The Nurse was standing in front of the funhouse again, staring into nothingness. Even though it felt quite pointless, I walked up to her and greeted her. "Hello. I just wanted to say thanks for... the key. I don't know how you got it, but it was very helpful."

"I don't think she can hear you," Madeleine remarked.

“I wouldn’t be so sure,” I replied.

Soon after, I headed back home to finally answer the other missed calls I had. The one from the unknown number was from a phone Nathan had requested to use in the hospital. He asked if I could come over. I told him I was flattered that he wanted to see me and that I had more or less expected him to want to talk to Dale first.

“Yeah... no. I’d rather not see someone who did not speak to me once in like, what? Ten years? First thing after waking up in the hospital.”

I told him I understood. While I personally believe this notion to be perfectly reasonable, in the end it’s none of my business. As of me writing this, I’m having lunch in the living room while watching a rerun of a season of Kitchen Nightmares. I’m going to go visit Nathan right after though. I want to bring him some flowers too. I decided on the potted laurel tree.

For some reason, the thought of having that ugly thing stand around in my living room any longer really isn’t that appealing to me anymore.